

Schools of Buddhism — Revision Guide

Reconciled learner edition. The immutable formal session and workbook are preserved separately in FORMAL-SOURCE-MIRROR.md; current canonical PYQ ownership controls this guide.

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Schools of Buddhism — Complete Learning Session

Syllabus, verbatim: Schools of Buddhism : Prat Ityasamutpada; Ksanikavada, Nairatmyavada. — UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section B, item 14. The printed spellings and spacing are reproduced exactly; the normalised scholarly forms used below are pratītyasamutpāda, kṣaṇikavāda and nairātmyavāda.

Evidence discipline: □ marks convergent doctrine, □□ marks analytical reconstruction or evaluation, and □ marks a contested textual, historical or sectarian point. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.

Terminology rule: the English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit or Pali term in IAST follows immediately in parentheses. Where the Pali form is the one a candidate is likely to meet, it is given as well.

What this package contains

| Component | Count |

|---|---|

| Progressive teaching sessions in the Basic block | 15 |

| Original diagnostic MCQs — 24 core plus 8 remedial drills | 32 |

| Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full | 14 |

| Supporting routed PYQs solved in full | 3 |

| Original solved Mains models — two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks | 6 |

| Consolidated register parts | 12 (A–L) |

| ASCII master flow panels | 14 |

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CONCEPT SPINE — ENGLISH FIRST, SANSKRIT OR PALI IMMEDIATELY AFTER

ONE DIAGNOSIS ONE METHOD
FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS (catvāri DEPENDENT ORIGINATION
āryasatyāni): suffering exists, <--> (pratītyasamutpāda): whatever arises,
it has an origin, it can cease, arises depending on conditions; whatever
a path leads to that cessation ceases, ceases when they cease

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ONE MIDDLE, TAKEN IN TWO SENSES

PRACTICAL: between sensual indulgence and self-mortification

-> Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga)

DOCTRINAL: between eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism

(ucchedavāda) -> conditioned continuity without a permanent self

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v v v

IMPERMANENCE radicalised THE PERSON ANALYSED SUFFERING STOPPED

-> MOMENTARINESS -> five aggregates -> CESSATION OF

(kṣaṇikavāda) (pañca-skandha) CONDITIONED

real = causally -> NO PERMANENT SELF SUFFERING (nirvāṇa)
 efficient moment (nairātmavāda) three fires extinguished
 |||
 +-----+-----+
 |
 v
 FOUR SCHOOLS AS ONE ARGUMENT-CHAIN
 Vaibhāṣika ----> Sautrāntika ----> Yogācāra / consciousness-only ----> Mādhyamika /
 direct representational (vijñānavāda) emptiness
 realism realism store-consciousness (śūnyavāda)
 about dharmas external object (ālaya-vijñāna), no dharma has
 inferred three natures intrinsic nature
 (svabhāva)

Concept spine: read it downward. The diagnosis on the top left and the causal method on the top right generate the double Middle Path; the Middle Path generates the three printed syllabus doctrines; and the four schools are four successive answers to the single question of what survives the analysis.

Answer-worthiness. Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda), momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) and no permanent self (nairātmavāda) are the printed core. Both senses of the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā), the Four Noble Truths, the twelve links, the five aggregates, cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa), the Three Jewels (Triratna) and the four philosophical schools are marks-essential core, because no routed previous-year question can be answered without them. The Buddhist theory of the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), the exclusion theory of meaning (apoha), the undeclared questions (avyākṛta) and the creator-God critique are core supporting depth wherever they decide a routed question. Detailed scholastic taxonomies and the internal Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika dispute are optional enrichment and are held back to the clearly labelled optional block.

HOW TO READ THIS SESSION

□□ Reconstruction discipline. Buddhism is a living, textually rich tradition, so doctrine can be stated positively. What still needs qualification is threefold: the relation between early discourse and later scholastic systematisation, the sectarian and doxographic status of the four-school matrix, and the interpretation of Madhyamaka negation. Where those appear they are marked □ and reported rather than settled.

Complete the Basic block first. Every optional interpretive dispute is deliberately withheld until the labelled optional block that follows the practice sections. Nothing in that block is required for a full-marks core answer.

□□ The single most common structural failure in Buddhism scripts is to treat the three printed terms as three separate topics. They are one derivation. Dependent origination establishes conditioned impermanence; the argument from causal efficacy radicalises impermanence into momentariness; and exhaustive analysis of the person under that momentary ontology yields no permanent self. Every session below is placed so that this derivation is visible.

ONE-SCREEN MAP OF THE FIFTEEN SESSIONS

WHAT BUDDHISM IS -> S1 therapeutic architecture, Four Noble Truths, the school map
 THE MIDDLE -> S2 practical middle + Noble Eightfold Path + doctrinal middle
 WHO IS SPEAKING -> S3 early Buddhism, Theravāda, the "Hīnayāna" label, Mahāyāna
 THE METHOD -> S4 dependent origination: formula, argument, three marks
 THE CHAIN -> S5 the twelve links and the three legitimate readings
 TIME -> S6 momentariness: causal efficacy, the dilemma, the continuum
 THE PERSON -> S7 no-self: five aggregates, chariot, personal vs phenomenon no-self
 CONTINUITY -> S8 action and moral consequence, memory, identity, rebirth
 RELEASE -> S9 cessation of conditioned suffering, Three Jewels, consistency
 REALISM I & II -> S10 Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika
 IDEALISM -> S11 Yogācāra: store-consciousness, three natures, anti-realist arguments
 EMPTINESS -> S12 Mādhyamika: emptiness, four corners, two truths, negation
 KNOWING -> S13 two means of valid knowledge, unique particular, exclusion theory
 SILENCE & GOD -> S14 undeclared questions, creator-God critique, the school escalation
 JUDGEMENT -> S15 named objections and replies, positioning, graded verdict

This is a route map, not a substitute for the fifteen complete Basic subtopics below.

SESSION 1 — WHAT BUDDHISM IS: A THERAPEUTIC ARCHITECTURE, NOT A CREED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Buddhist philosophy is a family of liberation-centred systems that explains suffering as something produced by identifiable conditions, so that removing those conditions removes the suffering.

Technical definition: Buddhist philosophy (bauddha-darśana) is a non-Vedic (nāstika) anti-substantialist family of systems that explains all conditioned phenomena through dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda), denies a permanent self (ātman) and any creator God as an explanatory requirement, and defines the goal as the cessation of the conditioned production of suffering (duḥkha-nirodha) rather than the release of a soul-substance.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism is best introduced as a medical rather than a metaphysical architecture: it names a disease, isolates its cause, asserts a cure and prescribes a therapy — and every doctrine on the syllabus, from dependent origination to emptiness, is an answer generated inside that four-step diagnostic frame.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Four Noble Truths (catvāri āryasatyāni) — suffering, its origin, its cessation, the path
- suffering or unsatisfactoriness (duḥkha; Pali: dukkha)
- dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda)
- liberation-centred goal (nirvāṇa; Pali: nibbāna)
- anti-substantialism — no permanent bearer behind the process
- soteriology — the theory of how release is achieved

How to use them: never open a Buddhism answer with a date or a biography. Open by stating the diagnostic frame, then say which of the four truths the question actually sits in. A question on dependent origination sits in the second and third truths; a question on the Noble Eightfold Path sits in the fourth; a question on no-self or momentariness sits in the analysis that supports all four.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

STEP 1 THIS HURTS -> suffering (duḥkha) is a fact, not a mood
|
STEP 2 IT HAS A CAUSE -> craving (tṛṣṇā) fed by ignorance (avidyā)
|
STEP 3 THE CAUSE CAN BE REMOVED -> therefore the result can stop
|
STEP 4 HERE IS THE METHOD -> the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga)

The whole system is the *reason why* step 3 is true:
if a thing is produced by conditions, it ends when those conditions end.

In simple words: Buddhism does not begin by asking what the world is made of. It begins by asking why life goes wrong, and it answers that life goes wrong through a process. Because a process has parts and each part has a cause, it can be interrupted. Everything technical in Buddhism — momentary events, aggregates, seeds, emptiness — exists to make that interruption intelligible.

| Remember first | Meaning |

|---|---|

| Duḥkha | Not "life is sad" but "whatever is conditioned and grasped cannot give secure satisfaction" |

| Samudaya | The origin: craving conditioned by ignorance about how things exist |

| Nirodha | Cessation: the same process running down when its fuel is withdrawn |

| Mārga | The path: eight disciplined factors that change the causal environment |

| What Buddhism denies | A permanent self and a necessary creator — not causation, ethics, rebirth or liberation |

One-line memory: Buddhism is a therapy that had to become a metaphysics in order to explain why the therapy works.

□ □ VISUAL — THE FOUR TRUTHS AS A CAUSAL CIRCUIT, NOT A LIST

FORWARD ORDER (arising) REVERSE ORDER (cessation)
ignorance (avidyā) knowledge of dependent origination
||
v v
craving (tṛṣṇā) and clinging (upādāna) craving withdrawn, clinging released
||

v v
 becoming (bhava) and renewed birth (jāti) no further appropriation, no renewal
 ||
 v v
 ageing and death (jarā-maraṇa) = DUḤKHA CESSATION (nirodha) = NIRVĀṆA

TRUTH 1 names the bottom-left box. TRUTH 2 names the arrows that reach it.
 TRUTH 3 asserts the right-hand column is possible. TRUTH 4 is how to walk it.

□□ Caption. Read the diagram left to right and the whole of Buddhism is visible in one movement: the same causal chain, read forward, is the theory of bondage, and read backward, is the theory of liberation. Scripts that describe the four truths as a numbered list lose exactly this point, which is why examiners reward the phrase "the third truth is a corollary of the second".

1. Why the diagnosis has to become a metaphysics

- The second truth claims that suffering has an origin. That claim is empty unless something explains how an origin produces an effect. Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is that explanation, and it is the reason Buddhism cannot stop at ethics.
- The third truth claims that suffering can cease. That claim is only defensible if nothing in the situation is permanent, because a permanent cause would produce a permanent effect. Impermanence (anitya; Pali: anicca), later radicalised into momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda), is therefore not an ornament on the therapy but its precondition.
- The path is possible only if the person is the kind of thing that can be changed at all. A permanent, unchanging self (ātman) could neither be improved nor liberated. No permanent self (nairātmyavāda) is thus the third structural requirement.
- The examinable consequence. The three printed syllabus terms are exactly the three metaphysical commitments the therapy needs. That is why the syllabus prints those three and not, say, a list of schools.

2. Where Buddhism sits in the classification of Indian systems

Classification test	Buddhist position	What must not be inferred
Accepts Vedic authority?	□ No — hence classified as unorthodox (nāstika)	Not that it denies rebirth, moral consequence or liberation
Accepts a creator God?	□ No — a creator adds no necessary explanatory work	Not that it is materialist; it rejects Cārvāka reduction as firmly as it rejects theism
Accepts a permanent self?	□ No — the person is a conventional designation on aggregates	Not that the person is a worthless illusion; conventional truth is operative
Accepts causal continuity across lives?	□ Yes — through a causal series, not a transmigrating soul	Not that a soul travels; the device is the stream, never the self

□ Buddhism and Jainism are both non-Vedic renouncer (śramaṇa) traditions, and both deny a creator. □□ The decisive difference is that Jainism affirms a real, intrinsically omniscient soul (jīva), while Buddhism denies precisely such a substance. Writing that "both deny the soul" is a standard and heavily penalised error.

3. The map of what the syllabus term "Schools of Buddhism" actually asks

□ The printed clause names three doctrines and one plural noun. The plural noun requires the four-position philosophical matrix:

1. Vaibhāṣika — external objects are real and directly perceived.
2. Sautrāntika — external objects are real but known only by inference from mental representation.
3. Yogācāra / consciousness-only (vijñānavāda) — what is given is cognition; the externality of the object is a construction.
4. Mādhyamika / emptiness (śūnyavāda) — no dharma whatsoever possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva).

□□ The four are not four independent doctrines to be listed. They are an argumentative escalation in which each position is generated by pressing an objection against the previous one. An answer that presents them as a list scores description marks; an answer that presents them as a chain scores analysis marks.

□ Taxonomic caution. The four-school matrix is a philosophical doxography used in Indian and Tibetan classificatory literature and reproduced in standard Indian-philosophy textbooks. It is not a complete institutional history of Buddhism, and it does not map neatly onto the historical schools and monastic lineages.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Buddhist metaphysics is generated by its soteriology, not appended to it.

Named evidence. The Four Noble Truths state the problem, its origin, its cessation and the path; dependent origination supplies the causal grammar of the second and third truths in the formula "this being, that becomes; from the cessation of this, that ceases"; and the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga) supplies the content of the fourth.

Analysis. Because the third truth asserts that a produced effect can be stopped, Buddhism is committed in advance to denying any permanent cause and any permanent bearer — which is exactly what momentariness and no-self deliver. The doctrines are therefore entailments of the therapeutic claim rather than free-standing speculations.

Qualification / link. The entailment runs from therapy to metaphysics, not the reverse, so a script must not present dependent origination as a general cosmology; its primary subject-matter is the arising and cessation of suffering, and the wider ontological readings are later scholastic extensions.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Opening with the Buddha's biography or dates. ☐ Open with the diagnostic frame; philosophy papers reward doctrine, not hagiography.
2. ☐ Calling Buddhism pessimistic because of duḥkha. ☐ The first truth is a diagnosis; the third truth is explicitly optimistic about cessation.
3. ☐ Writing that Buddhism and Jainism both deny the soul. ☐ Buddhism denies a permanent self; Jainism strongly affirms an intrinsically omniscient soul (jīva).
4. ☐ Treating the four schools as a list. ☐ Present them as a chain of objection and reply.
5. ☐ Calling Buddhism atheistic in the modern sense. ☐ It denies that a creator is explanatorily necessary; it is non-theistic within a moral cosmos, not materialist.

RAPID REVISION

- Frame: Four Noble Truths — suffering, origin, cessation, path.
- The second and third truths need a causal theory: that theory is dependent origination.
- The third truth needs impermanence; the fourth needs a changeable person: hence momentariness and no-self.
- Unorthodox (nāstika) on the Veda criterion, non-theistic on the creator criterion, and anti-substantialist on the self criterion — three distinct denials.
- The plural in "Schools of Buddhism" means the four-position matrix, read as an escalation.

SESSION 2 — THE MIDDLE PATH (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā) IN BOTH ITS SENSES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: the Middle Path is Buddhism's refusal of two pairs of extremes — one about how to live, one about what exists — and its positive replacement for both.

Technical definition: the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā) is (i) the practical route between sensual indulgence (kāma-sukhallikānuyoga) and self-mortification (attakilamathānuyoga), whose positive content is the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga), and (ii) the doctrinal route between eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), whose positive content is dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Middle Path is not moderation but double avoidance: it refuses the two ways of living that defeat liberation and the two ways of thinking that make liberation unintelligible, and in each case it replaces the rejected extremes with a positive discipline rather than with a compromise between them.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā)
- sensual indulgence and self-mortification — the two practical extremes

- Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga)
- wisdom (prajñā) · ethical discipline (śīla) · meditative discipline (samādhi) — the three trainings
- eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda) — the two doctrinal extremes
- conditioned continuity — what replaces both

How to use them: whenever a question asks about no-self, momentariness, action and moral consequence, or liberation, the Middle Path is the bridge sentence that prevents your answer from collapsing into nihilism. Write: Buddhism denies permanence without asserting annihilation, because dependent origination supplies continuity without a bearer.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

EXTREME 1 MIDDLE EXTREME 2

live for pleasure X disciplined eightfold X torture the body
(kāma-sukhallikā- training: see, intend, (attakilamatha-
nuyoga) speak, act, work, strive, nuyoga)
attend, concentrate

something permanent conditioned continuity: nothing survives at all;
survives unchanged X this conditions that, X the person is simply
(śāśvatavāda) and ceases with it obliterated (ucchedavāda)

NOTE: the middle is NOT the average of the two extremes.
It is a third, positively specified route that avoids the defects of both.

In simple words: two people can both fail to cross a river — one by refusing to leave the near bank, one by drowning in the current. The Middle Path is neither bank and not the average of the banks; it is the bridge. In practice the bridge is the eight-factor training. In doctrine the bridge is the claim that things really arise and really cease, but never as unchanging substances.

| The two middles | What is rejected | What replaces it |

|---|---|---|

| Practical | Indulgence and mortification | The Noble Eightfold Path under three trainings |

| Doctrinal | Eternalism and annihilationism | Dependent origination and conditioned continuity |

One-line memory: one middle tells you how to walk; the other tells you why walking can get you anywhere at all.

□ □ VISUAL — THE NOBLE EIGHTFOLD PATH GROUPED UNDER THE THREE TRAININGS

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+-----+
| WISDOM (prajñā) -- what you must SEE and INTEND |
| 1. right view (samyag-dṛṣṭi) |
| 2. right intention (samyak-saṃkalpa) |
+-----+
| correct seeing reorders conduct
v
+-----+
| ETHICAL DISCIPLINE (śīla) -- what you must DO |
| 3. right speech (samyag-vāc) |
| 4. right action (samyak-karmānta) |
| 5. right livelihood (samyag-ājīva) |
+-----+
| settled conduct makes attention stable
v
+-----+
| MEDITATIVE DISCIPLINE (samādhi) -- what you must ATTEND TO |
| 6. right effort (samyag-vyāyāma) |
| 7. right mindfulness (samyak-smṛti) |
| 8. right concentration (samyak-samādhi) |
+-----+
| stabilised attention deepens right view again
v
the loop tightens until craving loses its fuel

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□ □ Caption. The eight factors are not eight commandments performed in sequence and then ticked off; they are three mutually reinforcing trainings. Right view begins the cycle and is also its product, which is why the fourth truth is a path rather than a rule-book. In an answer, always group the eight under the three trainings — the grouping is itself a mark-scoring analytical move.

1. The practical middle: why it is not moderation

☐ The first-sermon framework rejects two courses that were both live options in the renouncer world of the time: devotion to sense-pleasure, and severe self-mortification.

☐ The rejection is diagnostic, not aesthetic. Indulgence is rejected because it feeds craving, which is the named origin of suffering in the second truth. Mortification is rejected because it exhausts and distracts the practitioner without touching craving at all; punishing the body does not remove ignorance from the mind.

☐ Therefore the middle is not "a little pleasure and a little austerity". It is a differently specified activity — the eightfold training — that attacks the actual cause identified by the diagnosis. The test of the middle is causal efficacy against craving and ignorance, not a location halfway between two points.

☐ Named evidence to cite. The Buddha's own biography, as the tradition itself presents it, is the argument in narrative form: extended austerity is reported as having failed to produce liberation, and the awakening follows the abandonment of that extreme. The tradition uses this as evidence that mortification is ineffective, not merely unpleasant.

2. The positive content: the Noble Eightfold Path under three trainings

Training	English-first path factors	What the training actually changes
Wisdom	right view (samyag-dṛṣṭi); right intention (samyak-saṃkalpa)	The cognitive framing that misreads conditioned processes as stable possessions
Ethical discipline	right speech (samyag-vāc); right action (samyak-karmānta); right livelihood (samyag-ājīva)	The conduct that continually renews the conditions of craving
Meditative discipline	right effort (samyag-vyāyāma); right mindfulness (samyak-smṛti); right concentration (samyak-samādhi)	The attention that lets feeling harden into craving unnoticed

☐ The path operationalises the fourth truth: because suffering arises conditionally, disciplined changes in understanding, conduct and attention change the causal environment in which craving is produced.

☐ Where the path meets the twelve links. The single most useful analytical sentence a candidate can write here is that the path targets the feeling → craving junction. Feeling (vedanā) arises unavoidably from contact; craving (tṛṣṇā) does not. Mindfulness is precisely the discipline of not letting the first automatically become the second. This is why the chain is soteriologically usable rather than fatalistic.

3. The doctrinal middle: between eternalism and annihilationism

☐ Eternalism (śāśvatavāda) is the view that some enduring self or substance persists unchanged through change. ☐ Annihilationism (ucchedavāda) is the view that things are sheer nullities, or that a person is simply obliterated with no causal continuity.

☐ Dependent origination avoids both. It denies permanence because whatever depends on conditions alters as those conditions alter. It denies annihilation because what arises does so in ordered dependence and conditions further arising; nothing comes from nothing and nothing vanishes without consequence.

☐ Why this is genuinely a middle and not a fudge. The two extremes share a hidden assumption — that continuity requires an identical persisting thing. Eternalism keeps the thing; annihilationism, finding no such thing, concludes that nothing continues. Buddhism rejects the shared assumption: continuity is carried by causal dependence, not by numerical identity. Once that assumption is dropped, the two extremes are seen as twins rather than opposites.

☐ Where each extreme would break the system. If eternalism were true, the third truth would fail, because a permanent cause of suffering could not be removed. If annihilationism were true, the fourth truth would fail, because there would be no continuity along which discipline could accumulate and bear fruit.

4. How the two middles reinforce each other

☐ The practical and doctrinal middles are not two unrelated uses of one word. Each is unstable without the other:

1. Without the doctrinal middle, the practical path is unintelligible — training a permanently fixed self is pointless, and training a stream with no continuity is futile.

2. Without the practical middle, the doctrinal middle is inert — an accurate metaphysics of conditionality changes nothing unless conduct and attention change the conditions.

3. Both are governed by the same criterion: does this remove the conditions of suffering? The practical extremes are rejected because they do not; the doctrinal extremes are rejected because they make removal either impossible or meaningless.

□ Grasping (upādāna) is the shared root. The tradition treats grasping as operating in the conduct-domain as craving for sense-objects and in the doctrine-domain as clinging to views (dṛṣṭi-upādāna). Both middles are therefore two applications of one therapy against one disease.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. The Middle Path is Buddhism's structural principle, and both of its senses must appear in any answer on no-self, momentariness or liberation.

Named evidence. The first-sermon framework rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification and prescribes the Noble Eightfold Path grouped as wisdom, ethical discipline and meditative discipline; the same word names the doctrinal refusal of eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), which dependent origination replaces with conditioned continuity.

Analysis. The two senses share one logic: in each case Buddhism identifies two failures with a common hidden assumption — that satisfaction requires either indulging or destroying the body, that continuity requires either a permanent bearer or nothing at all — and denies the assumption rather than choosing a side. This is why the Middle Path is a third route and not an average.

Qualification / link. The doctrinal middle secures continuity only at the conventional level; the persistent objection, pressed hardest by Nyāya, is that a causally continuous series can explain succession without explaining ownership, and a strong answer states that residual pressure instead of pretending the middle dissolves it.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Defining the Middle Path as moderation or as an Aristotelian mean. □ It is double avoidance with positive content, and the criterion is causal efficacy against craving, not balance.
2. □ Mentioning only the practical sense. □ The doctrinal sense between eternalism and annihilationism is the one that carries marks in metaphysics questions.
3. □ Listing the eight factors ungrouped. □ Group them under wisdom, ethical discipline and meditative discipline.
4. □ Saying the eightfold path is a sequence completed once. □ It is a reinforcing loop in which right view is both entry point and product.
5. □ Treating annihilationism as the same as no-self. □ No-self denies a permanent bearer; annihilationism denies causal continuity, and Buddhism rejects it explicitly.

RAPID REVISION

- Two middles, one logic: practical (indulgence / mortification) and doctrinal (eternalism / annihilationism).
- Positive content: Noble Eightfold Path under three trainings; dependent origination under conditioned continuity.
- The path's precise target is the feeling → craving junction, which is why the chain is not fatalism.
- Eternalism would defeat the third truth; annihilationism would defeat the fourth.
- Shared hidden assumption denied by Buddhism: continuity requires an identical persisting thing.

SESSION 3 — WHO IS SPEAKING: EARLY BUDDHISM, THERAVĀDA, THE "HĪNAYĀNA" LABEL AND MAHĀYĀNA

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: before comparing four philosophical schools, a candidate must know which historical tradition each position belongs to, and which labels are polemical rather than descriptive.

Technical definition: the orientation distinguishes (i) early Buddhism, the earliest recoverable discourse and discipline traditions; (ii) Theravāda, the surviving "Teaching of the Elders" with the Pali Tipiṭaka; (iii) the "Lesser Vehicle" (Hīnayāna) label, a Mahāyāna-applied and historically loaded classification; and (iv) Mahāyāna, the "Great Vehicle" family within which Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are the two major philosophical formations.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The fourfold school matrix is a philosophical doxography, not an institutional history, and the single most damaging error in a Buddhism script is to treat "Hīnayāna" as a synonym for Theravāda and then attach Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika to it as though they were its branches.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- early Buddhism — pre-systematic common diagnostic core
- Theravāda — one surviving school; Pali Tipiṭaka
- "Lesser Vehicle" (Hīnayāna) — Mahāyāna-applied, historically loaded label
- Mahāyāna — the vehicle within which Yogācāra and Mādhyamika sit
- liberated saint (arhat; Pali: arahant) and awakening being (bodhisattva)
- Sarvāstivāda — the scholastic world of Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika

How to use them: one sentence of orientation, placed early, buys accuracy for the whole answer: Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna scholastic positions, while Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna philosophical traditions. Then move to doctrine.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

EARLY BUDDHISM (the shared diagnosis: four truths, middle path, conditionality)

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NON-MAHĀYĀNA WORLD MAHĀYĀNA WORLD

(disciple-vehicle traditions) (bodhisattva orientation)

||

Theravāda -- a LIVING school Yogācāra -- consciousness-only

with the Pali Tipiṭaka |

| Mādhyamika -- emptiness

Sarvāstivāda world:

Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika

"HīNAYĀNA" = a label applied FROM the right-hand column TO the left.

It is not a self-designation and it is NOT another name for Theravāda.

In simple words: think of two columns, not a ladder. The left column contains living and historical non-Mahāyāna traditions, including Theravāda and the Sarvāstivāda scholastic world. The right column contains Mahāyāna, inside which the two idealist and emptiness philosophies grew. The word "Hīnayāna" was coined in the right column about the left, so using it as a neutral name repeats a polemic.

| Term | Safe description | Unsafe move |

|---|---|---|

| Early Buddhism | Earliest recoverable discourse and discipline traditions | Identifying it with any one later school |

| Theravāda | One surviving school with the Pali Tipiṭaka and the liberated-saint ideal | Using it as the name for every non-Mahāyāna school |

| "Hīnayāna" | A Mahāyāna-origin, often polemical classification | Treating it as a neutral synonym for Theravāda |

| Mahāyāna | A diverse family foregrounding the awakening-being path | Treating it as a single uniform doctrine |

One-line memory: two columns, one label crossing between them — and that label is not a name the left column gave itself.

□ □ VISUAL — WHERE THE FOUR PHILOSOPHICAL SCHOOLS ACTUALLY SIT

HISTORICAL PLACEMENT PHILOSOPHICAL POSITION DO NOT INFER

Vaibhāṣika external dharmas are real and that it is a branch of
Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma, directly perceived Theravāda
Kashmir *Mahāvibhāṣā* tradition

Sautrāntika external objects real but that it is one unified
critical current in the inferred from representation monastic institution
Sarvāstivāda orbit; privileges
sūtra over Abhidharma claims

Yogācāra consciousness-only; three that Mahāyāna = Yogācāra,
major Mahāyāna tradition natures; store-consciousness or that it means private
fantasy

Mādhyaṃika emptiness of intrinsic nature; that Mahāyāna = Mādhyaṃika, major Mahāyāna tradition two truths; dependent or that emptiness is designation sheer non-being

□□ Caption. The left column is history, the middle column is philosophy and the right column is the trap. Examiners test the right column: candidates who know the doctrines still lose marks by attaching them to the wrong tradition or by using a polemical label as a neutral one.

1. The two normative ideals, stated without caricature

□ The liberated-saint ideal (arhat; Pali: arahant) is central to early disciple traditions and Theravāda: the practitioner follows the Buddha's path and extinguishes the causes of rebirth and suffering.

□ The awakening-being ideal (bodhisattva) is foregrounded in Mahāyāna: the practitioner cultivates wisdom (prajñā) and compassion (karuṇā) toward complete Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.

□□ The careful formulation. "The bodhisattva simply postpones nirvāṇa" is an oversimplification. The stronger and safer claim is that the bodhisattva does not treat the attainment of arhatship as the final aim but follows the longer path to complete Buddhahood.

□□ Why caricature costs marks. Theravāda itself recognises the bodhisattva career of a future Buddha, and Mahāyāna texts still know the arhat category. The contrast identifies dominant normative ideals within each family, not mutually exclusive vocabularies, and certainly not a moral contrast between "selfish" and "altruistic" practitioners.

2. Canon and language — only the accurate minimum

□ Theravāda preserves the Pali Tipiṭaka: the discipline basket (Vinaya Piṭaka), the discourse basket (Sutta Piṭaka) and the higher-teaching basket (Abhidhamma Piṭaka).

□ Early Buddhist discourse is not historically reducible to "Pali Buddhism". Parallel early materials survive in the Chinese Āgamas and in Sanskrit and other fragmentary witnesses.

□ Sarvāstivāda, Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika materials are substantially preserved through Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan textual histories; they do not share the Theravāda Pali canon.

□ Many Mahāyāna discourses and treatises were transmitted in Sanskrit or Buddhist Hybrid Sanskrit and through Chinese and Tibetan translation. "Mahāyāna equals Sanskrit" is therefore a broad orientation, not an exhaustive rule.

□□ Answer discipline. Two sentences on canon are enough, and they must be qualified. Confident unqualified claims about canonical language are a reliable way to lose a mark that the doctrine itself had already earned.

3. What the fourfold matrix is for, and what it is not

□ What it is for: it arranges four coherent philosophical positions on one question — what survives ultimate analysis — so that the positions can be compared argumentatively.

□ What it is not: a complete institutional history, a chronology, or a claim that exactly four Buddhist schools ever existed. Buddhist doxographies list many more schools, and the philosophical matrix deliberately compresses them.

□□ How to say this in one line. "The fourfold scheme is a teaching matrix used by Indian and Tibetan doxographies to organise philosophical positions; it is not a census of Buddhist institutions." That single sentence protects an entire answer.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Accurate placement of the four philosophical schools within the broad traditions is a marks-bearing part of a "Schools of Buddhism" answer, not background decoration.

Named evidence. Vaibhāṣika is a Sarvāstivāda Abhidharma formation associated especially with the Kashmir Mahāvibhāṣā tradition; Sautrāntika is a critical current in the same orbit that privileges sūtra reasoning; Yogācāra and Mādhyaṃika are Mahāyāna philosophical traditions; Theravāda is a distinct surviving school preserving the Pali Tipiṭaka.

Analysis. Because "Hīnayāna" was applied by Mahāyāna authors to disciple-vehicle traditions rather than adopted by them, using it as a neutral synonym for Theravāda both misdescribes the tradition and conceals the fact that Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world rather than to the Pali canonical tradition.

Qualification / link. The fourfold matrix remains a doxographic device, so a script should present it as a philosophical arrangement of positions and should not convert it into a historical claim about the number or lineage of Buddhist schools.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Writing "Hīnayāna (Theravāda)". ☐ Name Theravāda directly; if the older label is needed, place it in quotation marks and explain its Mahāyāna origin.
2. ☐ Calling Vaibhāṣika or Sautrāntika a Theravāda school. ☐ Both belong to the Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna scholastic world.
3. ☐ Saying all early Buddhist material survives only in Pali. ☐ Parallel Āgama and Sanskrit witnesses exist.
4. ☐ Contrasting a selfish arhat with an altruistic bodhisattva. ☐ Contrast the dominant final aims, and note that each family knows the other's category.
5. ☐ Presenting the four schools as the complete history of Buddhism. ☐ It is a philosophical doxography.

RAPID REVISION

- Two columns: non-Mahāyāna (Theravāda; Sarvāstivāda world with Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika) and Mahāyāna (Yogācāra, Mādhyamika).
- "Hīnayāna" is applied, loaded and not a Theravāda synonym.
- Ideals: liberated saint (arhat) foregrounded in Theravāda; awakening being (bodhisattva) foregrounded in Mahāyāna — dominant aims, not moral opposites.
- Canon: Pali Tipiṭaka for Theravāda; Āgama, Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan witnesses elsewhere.
- The matrix is a teaching doxography, not an institutional census.

SESSION 4 — DEPENDENT ORIGINATION (pratītyasamutpāda): THE CAUSAL GRAMMAR

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: dependent origination is the claim that nothing conditioned stands on its own — whatever arises does so because supporting conditions are present, and it ceases when they are withdrawn.

Technical definition: dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is the principle that every conditioned phenomenon (saṃskṛta-dharma) arises in dependence on causes and conditions and ceases upon their cessation, stated in the formula *imasmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imasmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati* — "this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases."

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Dependent origination is not a cosmology of how the universe began but a grammar of how suffering is manufactured, and its philosophical power lies in the fact that a single formula, read forward, states the theory of bondage and, read backward, states the theory of release.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) — the formula, quoted in substance
- conditioned (saṃskṛta) versus unconditioned (asaṃskṛta)
- three marks (trilakṣaṇa; Pali: tilakkhaṇa) — impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, no-self
- eternalism (śāśvatavāda) / annihilationism (ucchedavāda)
- absence of intrinsic nature (svabhāva) — the Mādhyamika reading
- conditioned reality of dharmas — the Vaibhāṣika–Sautrāntika reading

How to use them: quote the formula in substance early; it is the single highest-yield sentence in the topic. Then state that the same formula generates two ontological readings — emptiness and conditioned realism — which is exactly what the 2024 question asks.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

A FLAME BURNS ONLY WHILE ITS CONDITIONS HOLD

wick + oil + air + ignition -> FLAME -> remove any one -> no flame
|
while burning it is NOT unreal
when out it has NOT gone somewhere

The flame is neither an eternal fire-substance nor a nothing.
It is exactly as real as its conditions make it, for exactly as long.

In simple words: ask what a flame is and you will look for a thing. Buddhism says stop looking for the thing and look at the arrangement. The flame is what the arrangement is doing. Persons, sensations, thoughts and sufferings are like that: real while their conditions hold, and finished — not relocated — when they do not.

| First idea | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Conditionality | Nothing conditioned explains itself; it always points to something else |

| Not fatalism | Conditions can be altered, so the outcome can be altered |

| Not chance | The dependence is ordered and regular, not random |

| Not creation | No first maker is invoked; the chain explains without a starter |

One-line memory: the flame is not a thing that burns; burning is what the conditions are doing.

□ □ VISUAL — WHAT DEPENDENT ORIGATION DENIES AND WHAT IT KEEPS

DEPENDENT ORIGATION

|

+-----+-----+

|

WHAT IT DENIES WHAT IT KEEPS

X self-existent things (svabhāva) □ real arising and real ceasing
X an unchanging substratum (ātman, dravya) □ ordered, law-like dependence
X a creator outside the chain □ moral consequence of action
X an absolutely first cause □ the possibility of cessation

|

+-----+-----+

|

SO IT IS A ****MIDDLE****:
not eternalism (keeps too much), not annihilationism
(keeps nothing at all)

□ □ Caption. Almost every objection to Buddhism is an attempt to show that the left column takes away something the right column needs. The Nyāya objection says you cannot keep moral consequence after removing the self; the Advaita objection says you cannot keep the unity of experience; the nihilism charge says you cannot keep anything at all. Knowing the two columns tells you in advance where every objection will strike.

1. The statement and the formula

□ Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) means that whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.

□ The standard formula, in substance: imasmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imasmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati — this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases.

□ It is not merely a cosmological thesis. Its primary subject-matter is the arising of suffering (duḥkha) and therefore the possibility of its cessation.

□ □ How to deploy the formula. The four clauses are two pairs: the first pair states positive conditionality (presence and arising), the second states negative conditionality (absence and cessation). Quoting all four, rather than only the first, is what shows the examiner that you understand cessation to be built into the formula rather than added later.

2. The Four Noble Truths as the frame

- □ Buddhism states the problem first: suffering (duḥkha).

- ☐ It then identifies a causal structure: suffering has an origin.
- ☐ Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.
- ☐ Therefore a path is possible.

☐☐ Dependent origination is thus the philosophical grammar of the Four Noble Truths: the first truth states the fact of suffering; the second gives its dependent arising; the third gives its dependent cessation; the fourth gives the discipline that breaks the chain. This one-sentence mapping is the strongest opening available for the 2023 soteriology question.

3. The three marks (trilakṣaṇa; Pali: tilakkhaṇa)

English-first mark	Doctrinal meaning	Relation to the syllabus
---	---	---
Impermanence (anitya; Pali: anicca)	All conditioned formations arise, alter and cease	Supplies the foundation that later Buddhist logicians radicalise into momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda)
Unsatisfactoriness (duḥkha; Pali: dukkha)	What is impermanent and appropriated as "mine" cannot give secure satisfaction	Connects metaphysics to the first Noble Truth and to the diagnosis of craving
No-self (anātman; Pali: anattā)	No permanent independent owner is found in the changing aggregates	Directly prepares the printed doctrine of no permanent self (nairātmyavāda)

☐ The three marks connect diagnosis and liberation: insight sees conditioned phenomena as impermanent, unsatisfactory when grasped, and not-self.

☐☐ Historical caution. Impermanence is the early teaching; the universal one-moment thesis of momentariness is a stronger later scholastic development. Do not present the two formulations as verbally identical.

☐☐ Scope caution. The standard formula applies impermanence and unsatisfactoriness to conditioned formations, whereas not-self is applied more widely. Do not infer that cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa), classified as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) in important Buddhist traditions, is simply another momentary conditioned event.

4. The argument, stated in the order to be written

1. ☐ What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.
2. ☐ If a thing were self-existent by its own nature, it would not depend on conditions.
3. ☐ But all conditioned phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions.
4. ☐ Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness; they are dependent processes.
5. ☐☐ The existential conclusion is that suffering too is a process rather than a metaphysical fate, and is therefore removable.

5. Presupposition and the standard objection

☐☐ Presupposition. Explanation should proceed through conditional relations rather than through a static substratum such as ātman or Brahman, and not through a creator standing outside the chain. A second presupposition is that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained now.

☐ Objection. If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism ultimately explain nothing? Does it generate an infinite regress of conditions?

☐ Reply. Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible. Its concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable. ☐☐ A strong answer states explicitly that dependent origination is not a failed search for a first cause but a diagnosis of dependent becoming — the regress objection assumes the very explanatory model Buddhism has rejected.

6. The derivation of momentariness — the 2019 and 2020 bridge

- ☐ What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it alters with the rise and fall of those conditions.
- ☐ Therefore what is conditioned is impermanent (anitya); Buddhist logicians radicalise this into momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda), on which whatever is real is momentary.

- ☐ ☐ The honest step. Dependent origination by itself establishes conditioned impermanence, not strict one-moment duration. The extra premise that converts impermanence into momentariness is the argument from causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva) developed in Session 6. Writing the derivation without that extra premise is the most common logical gap in scripts on the 2020 twenty-marker.

7. Why "everything is void" and "everything is real" both follow — the 2024 hinge

(a) Mādhyamika: dependence implies emptiness.

- ☐ Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess intrinsic nature (svabhāva).
- ☐ Therefore all dharmas are empty (śūnya) of independent essence, and Nāgārjuna in substance identifies dependent origination with emptiness.
- ☐ ☐ This does not mean sheer non-being; it means the absence of intrinsic, self-subsistent reality.

(b) Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika: dependence implies conditioned reality.

- ☐ The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.
- ☐ But they infer that precisely because things arise causally, they are real as conditioned entities.
- ☐ Vaibhāṣika treats dharmas as real and directly knowable; Sautrāntika treats them as real though known through representation.

(c) Distinguishing the two conclusions.

| School move | What is denied | What is affirmed |

|---|---|---|

| Mādhyamika | intrinsic nature (svabhāva) | conventional dependent existence |

| Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika | eternal substance and permanent self | reality of conditioned dharmas |

- ☐ ☐ The decisive analytical sentence. The two conclusions are not contradictory because they answer different questions. "Everything is void" answers does anything possess intrinsic nature? "Everything is real" answers is anything causally efficacious? The realists deny permanence but not causal reality; the Mādhyamika denies intrinsic nature but not conventional functioning. The contradiction is verbal; the genuine dispute is over whether causal efficacy establishes ultimate status.

8. Cessation and knowledge — the 2023 hinge

- ☐ Ignorance of dependent origination is itself bondage; insight into it is the beginning of release. ☐ ☐ The 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — must therefore be answered not as an epistemic slogan but as a substantive claim: wrong metaphysical grasping is causally productive. Misreading conditioned processes as stable possessions is what generates craving, and craving is what renews becoming. Knowledge cures because the false framing was doing causal work.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Dependent origination is the principle from which every other Buddhist doctrine on the syllabus is derived, which is why the same formula supports two opposed ontological conclusions.

Named evidence. The formula *imasmim sati idaṃ hoti ... imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati* states arising and cessation together; Nāgārjuna in substance identifies dependent origination with emptiness, so that what is dependently arisen is empty of intrinsic nature; the Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika traditions draw the opposite emphasis and treat dependently arisen dharmas as real conditioned entities.

Analysis. The divergence is possible because dependence entails the absence of self-establishment but does not by itself entail the absence of causal reality. Mādhyamika presses the first entailment to deny ultimate status; the realists accept the first entailment about permanence while affirming the causal reality of momentary dharmas. The dispute is therefore about the criterion of the ultimately real, not about the causal principle they share.

Qualification / link. Dependent origination alone yields conditioned impermanence rather than strict momentariness, so any answer that moves from the formula directly to one-moment duration has skipped the causal-efficacy premise and has weakened the very derivation the 2020 question rewards.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Presenting dependent origination as a linear cosmology or creation story. ☐ It is a doctrine of dependent suffering and cessation.
2. ☐ Quoting only "this being, that becomes". ☐ Quote the cessation half too; the third truth lives there.

3. □ Deriving momentariness straight from dependence. □ Insert the causal-efficacy premise.
4. □ Saying the 2024 pair of conclusions is a contradiction inside Buddhism. □ They answer different questions about ultimacy.
5. □ Treating nirvāṇa as one more momentary conditioned event. □ Important traditions classify it as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta).

RAPID REVISION

- Formula in four clauses: presence → arising; absence → cessation.
- Maps onto the four truths: fact, dependent arising, dependent cessation, path.
- Three marks: impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, no-self — the third is applied more widely than the first two.
- Denies self-existence, substratum, creator and first cause; keeps arising, order, moral consequence and cessation.
- 2024 hinge: dependence → no intrinsic nature (Mādhyamika) or → real conditioned dharmas (realists).

SESSION 5 — THE TWELVE LINKS (dvādaśa-nidāna) AND THE THREE LEGITIMATE READINGS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: the twelve links are the detailed version of dependent origination — a twelve-step account of how ignorance ends in ageing and death, and of where the chain can be cut.

Technical definition: the twelve links (dvādaśa-nidāna) are the classical enumeration of the conditions of cyclic existence, running from ignorance (avidyā) to ageing-and-death (jarā-maraṇa), readable in forward order as the production of suffering (anuloma) and in reverse order as its cessation (pratiloma).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The twelve links are not a chronology to be recited but a diagnosis to be used: the chain identifies exactly one joint at which a practitioner can intervene, and locating that joint — between feeling and craving — is what separates an answer that has understood dependent origination from one that has merely memorised it.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- twelve links (dvādaśa-nidāna) in exact order
- ignorance (avidyā) → formations (saṃskāra) → consciousness (vijñāna)
- feeling (vedanā) → craving (tṛṣṇā) — the intervention point
- forward order (anuloma) and reverse order (pratiloma)
- wheel of becoming (bhava-cakra) — the visual pedagogy
- three-life reading · present-process reading · structural reading

How to use them: state the twelve in order without hesitation, then immediately do something with them — name the intervention joint, or name the two readings. Reciting the list without analysis is the classic half-mark answer.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

WHY DOES THE SAME TROUBLE KEEP COMING BACK?

You misread the situation → ignorance
 You act on the misreading → formations
 Awareness is shaped by the act → consciousness
 A psycho-physical set-up forms → name-and-form
 It has six windows on the world → six sense-bases
 The windows meet objects → contact
 Meeting produces liking/disliking → feeling
 ----- HERE IS THE DOOR -----
 Liking hardens into wanting → craving <-- CUT HERE
 Wanting hardens into holding → clinging
 Holding sets up a next round → becoming
 The round starts → birth
 The round wears out → ageing and death

In simple words: the chain is not a punishment schedule. It is a description of a habit. Everything above the dotted line happens to you; everything below it is something you do. That is why the discipline of mindfulness is placed exactly at the door.

Remember first	Easy meaning
Ignorance	Not stupidity — misreading conditioned processes as stable possessions
Formations	Habitual dispositions built by acting on that misreading
Feeling	Bare pleasantness or unpleasantness; morally neutral
Craving	Feeling turned into demand; this is where suffering is manufactured
Reverse order	Stop ignorance and craving and the rest of the chain has nothing to run on

One-line memory: feeling is unavoidable; craving is optional — and the whole path lives in that gap.

□ □ VISUAL — THE CHAIN, THE THREE-LIFE ARRANGEMENT AND THE CUT

PAST CAUSES | PRESENT RESULTS | PRESENT CAUSES | FUTURE RESULTS

----- | ----- | ----- | -----
 1 ignorance | 3 consciousness | 8 craving | 11 birth
 (avidyā) | (vijñāna) | (tṛṣṇā) | (jāti)
 2 formations | 4 name-and-form | 9 clinging | 12 ageing-death
 (saṃskāra) | (nāma-rūpa) | (upādāna) | (jarā-maraṇa)
5 six sense-bases	10 becoming
(ṣaḍāyatana)	(bhava)
6 contact (sparśa)	
7 feeling (vedanā)	

 ^ ^
 | |
 results: cannot be undone causes: CAN be interrupted
 \ _____ /
 THE CUT GOES HERE (7 -> 8)

□ □ Caption. The three-life arrangement is a pedagogic device, not the only legitimate reading, but it earns its place because it shows why the chain is not fatalism: the boxes on the left are already produced, while the box labelled "present causes" is still open. A script that draws or describes this division has answered "why is dependent origination not determinism?" without needing a separate paragraph.

1. The twelve links in order

• □ The classical chain is expressed through the twelve-link sequence (dvādaśa-nidāna):

1. ignorance (avidyā)
2. formations or dispositions (saṃskāra)
3. consciousness (vijñāna)
4. name-and-form (nāma-rūpa)
5. six sense-bases (ṣaḍāyatana)
6. contact (sparśa)
7. feeling (vedanā)
8. craving (tṛṣṇā)
9. clinging or grasping (upādāna)
10. becoming or existence (bhava)
11. birth (jāti)
12. ageing and death (jarā-maraṇa)

• □ In Buddhist visual pedagogy the sequence is often represented through the wheel of becoming (bhava-cakra), showing how ignorance and craving keep cyclic existence in motion.

□ □ Two orderings students confuse. Formations (2) precede consciousness (3), and craving (8) precedes clinging (9) and becoming (10). Reversing either pair is an immediately visible factual error.

2. The three exam-useful interpretations

| Interpretation | How it reads the chain | Caution |

|---|---|---|

| Three-life pedagogic reading | Past causes: ignorance and formations. Present results: consciousness through feeling. Present causes: craving, clinging and becoming. Future results: birth, ageing and death. | This common Abhidharma and textbook arrangement explains rebirth and karmic continuity, but it is not the only legitimate reading. |

| Present-process or psychological reading | In each lived episode, ignorance conditions habitual construction; consciousness and name-and-form organise experience; contact and feeling arise; craving turns feeling into appropriation and renewed becoming. | "Psychological" does not mean merely private or imaginary; the point is the conditioned construction of suffering here and now. |

| Structural and soteriological reading | The chain identifies the conditions that maintain suffering and can be read forward as arising and in reverse as cessation. It diagnoses a pattern, not an absolutely first cause. | Early formulations vary in order and number before the twelve-link list becomes standard; do not force every occurrence into one rigid linear chronology. |

□□ Answer use. State the standard twelve-link sequence, then add one sentence: the three-life model explains rebirth and karmic continuity, while the present-process model shows why dependent origination is immediately practical. That single sentence converts recitation into analysis.

3. Why ignorance is placed first without being a first cause

□ Ignorance heads the list because it is the condition whose removal collapses the rest, not because it is an absolute beginning. □□ The tradition explicitly resists reading avidyā as a temporal origin: it is itself conditioned, notably by the very formations it conditions, which is why the chain is drawn as a wheel rather than a line.

□□ The examinable consequence. Buddhism can therefore deny an absolutely first cause without denying explanation. What it offers is a structural explanation — a self-sustaining loop identified precisely enough to be broken — rather than a genetic one. This is the deepest reason Buddhism does not need a creator: the demand for a first term is treated as a badly formed demand.

4. Reverse order (pratiloma) — the cessation sequence

□ Read backwards, each link's cessation is stated as the cessation of its condition: with the cessation of ignorance, formations cease; with the cessation of formations, consciousness ceases; and so on to the cessation of ageing-and-death.

□□ What the reverse order proves. It proves that the third Noble Truth is not an article of faith. Cessation is not an additional event that must be hoped for; it is the logical consequence of removing a condition in a dependently arisen series. This is exactly the argument the 2023 twenty-marker asks a candidate to present.

□ Named anchors for this subtopic. The three-life division is the standard Abhidharma and textbook arrangement, retained in the Theravāda commentarial tradition; the wheel of becoming (bhava-cakra) is the pedagogic image in which the same chain is drawn as a closed circle; and the Buddha's own framework, in which the chain is set out in forward order as arising and in reverse order as cessation, is what licenses reading a single sequence in two directions.

□ Two practical cut-points, not one. The tradition identifies removal of ignorance through insight (prajñā) and removal of craving through discipline and mindfulness. The first is the wisdom training; the second is the ethical and meditative training. The Noble Eightfold Path is therefore structurally matched to the chain: it attacks both cut-points simultaneously.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. The twelve links are a soteriological instrument, and their value in an answer lies in identifying where the chain is cut rather than in reciting its order.

Named evidence. The sequence runs ignorance, formations, consciousness, name-and-form, six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, ageing-and-death; the three-life arrangement divides it into past causes, present results, present causes and future results; the reverse order (pratiloma) states cessation link by link.

Analysis. Because feeling arises unavoidably from contact while craving does not arise unavoidably from feeling, the chain contains exactly one joint at which present practice is effective, and the Noble Eightfold Path is built to operate on it — mindfulness at the feeling–craving junction, insight at ignorance. The reverse order then converts the third Noble Truth from an assertion into an entailment.

Qualification / link. Early formulations vary in order and number before the twelve-link list stabilises, so the chain should be presented as the standard classical enumeration rather than as a fixed chronology, and ignorance should be described as the condition whose removal collapses the series rather than as an absolutely first cause.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Reciting twelve terms and stopping. ☐ Name the intervention joint and the two readings.
2. ☐ Swapping formations and consciousness, or craving and clinging. ☐ Learn the two fragile pairs.
3. ☐ Treating ignorance as an absolute first cause. ☐ It is conditioned; the figure is a wheel.
4. ☐ Presenting only the three-life reading. ☐ Add the present-process reading, which shows immediate practical bite.
5. ☐ Saying the chain proves determinism. ☐ Present causes remain open, which is why the path is possible.

RAPID REVISION

- Order: ignorance · formations · consciousness · name-and-form · six sense-bases · contact · feeling · craving · clinging · becoming · birth · ageing-and-death.
- Cut at feeling → craving; insight cuts at ignorance.
- Three readings: three-life, present-process, structural-soteriological.
- Reverse order (pratiloma) makes the third truth an entailment, not a hope.
- The wheel image encodes the refusal of an absolutely first cause.

SESSION 6 — MOMENTARINESS (kṣaṇikavāda): CAUSAL EFFICACY, THE DILEMMA AND THE CONTINUUM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: momentariness is the claim that whatever is genuinely real lasts only a moment, and that what looks like an enduring thing is really a rapid succession of similar momentary events.

Technical definition: momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) holds that whatever is real is momentary — yat sat tat kṣaṇikam — because the real is defined as what is capable of producing an effect (sat = arthakriyā-samartha), and only a moment-specific entity can account for the determinate occurrence of an effect.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Momentariness is not the claim that nothing exists but the claim that existence is evental rather than substantial: what a realist calls a thing enduring through change, the Buddhist calls a series of causally efficient moments so closely similar that language, memory and practice treat them as one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda); yat sat tat kṣaṇikam
- causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva); sat = arthakriyā-samartha
- simultaneity horn (yauḡapadya) and succession horn (krama)
- auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) and the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma
- argument from destruction (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga)
- causal continuum (santāna / santati) and similarity (sādrśya)

How to use them: the technical vocabulary here is the difference between a descriptive and an analytical answer. A script that writes "yat sat tat kṣaṇikam, because sat = arthakriyā-samartha" and then unpacks the dilemma has already secured the core of the 2020 twenty-marker.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

A CANDLE FLAME LOOKS LIKE ONE THING

t1 t2 t3 t4 t5 t6 t7 <- actually: distinct flame-moments

|||||||

-> -> -> -> -> -> each conditions the next

Because they are so similar and so fast, we say "the flame".
Nothing wrong with saying it — but nothing in it stays.

TEST: what makes something REAL?
Buddhist answer: it can DO something. And doing something takes a moment.

In simple words: ask when a seed does its job. Not "always" — otherwise the sprout would appear immediately and forever. It does its job at a particular moment, under particular conditions. The Buddhist says: that is what being real amounts to, and anything that is real in that sense is tied to its moment.

First idea	Easy meaning
Real = effective	Something that makes no difference anywhere is, for this analysis, nothing
Effective = timed	Doing something happens at a time, not at all times
Therefore momentary	What is tied to its moment of operation cannot be permanent
Continuity survives	The next moment is caused by this one — that is what "the same thing" means

One-line memory: to be is to do; to do is to do now; so to be is to be now.

□□ VISUAL — THE DILEMMA THAT KILLS THE PERMANENT CAUSE

SUPPOSE A PERMANENT ENTITY PRODUCES AN EFFECT.

|
+-----+-----+
||
ALL AT ONCE ONE AFTER ANOTHER
(yauḡapadya horn) (krama horn)
||
then nothing is left over then it operates differently
for later production — at different times —
effects should be complete but what operates differently
and simultaneous has CHANGED
||
contradicts observation contradicts permanence
+-----+-----+
|
"IT ACTS ONLY WHEN AUXILIARIES (sahakārin) ARE PRESENT"
|
THE sahakāri-anapekṣā DILEMMA REPLIES:
either it already had the power (so auxiliaries are idle)
or the auxiliaries supply the power (so the permanent
thing is causally redundant)
|
v
PERMANENT + EFFICIENT = INCOHERENT
therefore yat sat tat kṣaṇikam

□□ Caption. This is the single most reusable argument-diagram in Indian philosophy: it is the Buddhist weapon against Nyāya substance, and its structure — dilemma, then closure of the escape route — is exactly what the directive "critically discuss" is asking a candidate to reproduce. Note that the argument does not assert momentariness directly; it eliminates the permanent alternative.

1. Statement

- □ Momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) holds that whatever is real is momentary.
- □ A standard scholastic formulation runs in substance as sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam — whatever is truly real is momentary.
- □□ The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is eventual rather than substantial. Mistaking the two is the second-most-penalised error in the topic.

2. The argument from causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva)

Statement.

- □ Causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva), the capacity to perform a function, is the Buddhist means-of-knowledge school's criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha, the real is what is capable of producing an effect.
- □ Momentariness follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.
- □□ This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) as ultimately real also grounds yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

Argument.

1. ☐ To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for this analysis.
2. ☐ Causal efficacy must occur either simultaneously or successively.
3. ☐ If a permanent entity produces its effect all at once, nothing remains for later production — the simultaneity horn (yaugapadya).
4. ☐ If it produces effects successively, it functions differently at different moments; what functions differently is not wholly permanent — the succession horn (krama).
5. ☐ If Nyāya replies that it acts only when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present, the Buddhist presses the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma: either the permanent thing already has the power and does not need auxiliaries, or the decisive causal power lies in the changing auxiliaries rather than in the permanent thing.
6. ☐ Therefore a permanent entity cannot coherently be causally efficient.
7. ☐ Therefore whatever is real is momentary: yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

Presupposition.

- ☐ ☐ A pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.
- ☐ ☐ And a second: a single unchanged entity cannot have genuinely different causal profiles at different times without ceasing to be unchanged.

Distinction.

| Issue | ☐ Buddhist logician | ☐ Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika opponent |

|---|---|---|

| Test of reality | causal efficacy (arthakriyā) | membership in the categories: substance, quality, action, universal, inherence, absence |

| Enduring thing | only a conventional series | real substance enduring through changing qualities |

| Effect at different times | requires momentary causal phases | explained by auxiliary conditions acting on an enduring substance |

Example.

- ☐ ☐ A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout. But the seed that has exercised that precise sprout-producing capacity is no longer the same causal phase; the series has advanced.

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line).

- ☐ Why can a permanent substance not act at one time because the relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?
- ☐ Nyāya also uses recognition (pratyabhijñā) — "this is that same jar" — together with memory and moral desert to argue that enduring substances and selves are required.

Reply — Buddhist logicians.

- ☐ If the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, the decisive factor lies elsewhere and its own efficacy is redundant.
- ☐ Recognition is explained through similarity (sādṛśya) within a causal stream rather than through strict numerical identity.
- ☐ Memory and desert are explained through the causal continuum (santāna / santati), with store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device.
- ☐ ☐ Residual force. The Nyāya rejoinder retains real weight: a mere series seems unable to own memories or deserts unless something owns the series. A first-class answer states this rather than concealing it.

3. The argument from destruction (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga line)

- ☐ A second line holds that destruction does not require a separate destroyer added from outside.
- ☐ The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.
- ☐ ☐ Hence things are not first fully stable entities that are later destroyed; transience belongs to what they are.

☐ ☐ Why the second argument matters. The efficacy argument eliminates permanence; the destruction argument removes the need for an external annihilator and therefore blocks the realist move of treating perishing as an extra event requiring its own cause. Together they close both exits.

4. Apparent continuity: the causal continuum (santāna)

- ☐ If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?
- ☐ Buddhism answers through the causal continuum (santāna) — a causal series or stream.
- ☐ Each moment gives rise to the next sufficiently similar moment, producing the appearance of persistence.
- ☐ The standard illustrations are the flame and the stream: continuity without strict identity.

☐ The precise philosophical claim. "Same" in ordinary usage tracks causal continuity plus similarity, not numerical identity of a substance. Buddhism does not deny the usage; it re-describes what the usage is answering to. This is a two-truths move made before Madhyamaka formalises it.

5. Recognition (pratyabhijñā) — the standing objection

☐ Objection. Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

☐ Reply. Recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance. ☐ The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments. ☐ Whether the reply fully succeeds is genuinely contested: the realist can press that a judgement of sameness requires a subject who holds both terms together, which is precisely what a momentary series lacks.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Momentariness is established negatively, by eliminating the permanent cause, rather than positively, by observing moments.

Named evidence. The Buddhist logicians define the real as what is capable of an effect (sat = arthakriyā-samartha) and press the simultaneity (yauḡapadya) and succession (krama) horns; the Nyāya escape through auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) is closed by the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma; the destruction argument adds that perishing needs no external destroyer.

Analysis. Because the argument proceeds by exhausting the alternatives open to a permanent efficient cause, its strength does not depend on perceiving momentary phases, which no one claims to do; it depends only on the criterion of the real. That is why Nyāya's most effective counter is not perceptual but criterial — it rejects the identification of reality with causal efficacy.

Qualification / link. The continuum (santāna) explains succession and similarity, but the Nyāya charge that a series cannot own memory or moral desert unless something owns the series is not fully dissolved, and an answer that concedes this residual pressure while showing that ownership is a conventional designation will read as philosophically honest rather than evasive.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Saying momentariness means nothing exists. ☐ It means the real is evental, not substantial.
2. ☐ Presenting momentariness as directly perceived. ☐ It is inferred by eliminating the permanent efficient cause.
3. ☐ Omitting the auxiliary-conditions escape and its closure. ☐ The sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma is the heart of the argument.
4. ☐ Explaining continuity by smuggling in a subtle self. ☐ The device is the causal continuum, never a self.
5. ☐ Presenting the Nyāya objection as already defeated. ☐ State the residual force; "critically discuss" requires it.

RAPID REVISION

- Thesis: yat sat tat kṣaṇikam, grounded on sat = arthakriyā-samartha.
- Two horns: yauḡapadya (all at once) and krama (successively).
- Escape closed by sahakāri-anapekṣā: auxiliaries are either idle or decisive.
- Second argument: perishing is intrinsic, so no external destroyer is needed.
- Continuity device: santāna plus sādṛśya; illustrations: flame and stream.

SESSION 7 — NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda): THE FIVE AGGREGATES AND THE TWO NO-SELVES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: no-self is the claim that when you look carefully at a person you find processes and no owner of the processes — and that the missing owner is not hidden but simply not there.

Technical definition: no permanent self (nairātmyavāda; anātmavāda) denies a permanent, unchanging, independent self (ātman) behind experience, holding that what is conventionally called a person is a designation (prajñapti) made upon five aggregates (pañca-skandha) which are individually and jointly impermanent, unsatisfactory when grasped, and not fit to be owned.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhist no-self is the conclusion of an exhaustive search, not the premise of a doctrine: the aggregates are enumerated precisely so that the question "and what else is there?" can be asked and answered, and the philosophical force of the doctrine lies entirely in the completeness of that enumeration.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- no permanent self (nairātmyavāda; anātmavāda)
- five aggregates (pañca-skandha): form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness
- chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha) and designation (prajñapti)
- personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) and phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya)
- the person-theory foil (Puggalavāda / Vātsīputrīya)
- conventional person (prajñapti-puruṣa)

How to use them: the 2021 ten-marker asks precisely for the two no-selves, and the 2020 fifteen-marker asks for the aggregates plus liberation. Both are lost by candidates who define no-self without enumerating the aggregates, because enumeration is the argument.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

TAKE A CHARIOT APART

axle wheels frame pole yoke reins ... and where is the chariot?

Not the axle. Not the wheels. Not the sum lying in a heap.
Not something extra hovering above the parts.

"Chariot" is a USEFUL NAME for parts working together.
Nothing is lost: you can still ride it, buy it, repair it.

NOW DO THE SAME TO A PERSON:
body · feeling · recognition · dispositions · awareness ... and the self?

In simple words: the doctrine is not that you are an illusion. It is that "you" is the sort of word "chariot" is — completely usable, entirely legitimate, and not the name of an extra ingredient. Buddhism removes an item from the inventory, not a person from the world.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Aggregate | A heap or bundle; five categories that exhaust the person |

| Designation | A name that works without naming a separate thing |

| Conventional person | The person who practises, remembers and takes refuge |

| Not annihilation | Denying an owner is not denying the process it was thought to own |

One-line memory: Buddhism did not lose the person; it lost the owner.

□ □ VISUAL — THE FIVE AGGREGATES AND THE FOUR TESTS THEY FAIL

THE PERSON, EXHAUSTIVELY ANALYSED

+-----+
1 form (rūpa)	the material body and its physical basis
2 feeling	bare pleasant / unpleasant / neutral tone
(vedanā)	
3 perception	recognition and identification of objects
(saṃjñā)	
4 formations	dispositions, volitions, habitual tendencies

```

| (saṃskāra) | |
| 5 consciousness | awareness arising with an object and a base |
| (vijñāna) | |
+-----+-----+
| | |
v v v
IS ANY OF THEM IS ANY OF THEM IS THERE A SIXTH
PERMANENT? INDEPENDENT? ITEM BEHIND THEM?
NO NO NO
\ | /
\ | /
v v v
THEREFORE: "self" is a DESIGNATION on the five,
not a discovery among them or behind them.

```

□□ Caption. The diagram is the argument. Everything depends on the claim that the list is exhaustive: if a sixth category could be produced, the doctrine would fail immediately. That is exactly why the person-theory foil (Puggalavāda) is philosophically interesting — it is an attempt from inside Buddhism to add something without adding a self.

1. Statement and the five aggregates

- □ No permanent self (nairātmyavāda) denies a permanent, unchanging self (ātman) behind experience.
- □ What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.
- □ The person is analysed into five aggregates (skandhas):
 1. form or material body (rūpa)
 2. feeling or sensation (vedanā)
 3. perception or recognition (saṃjñā)
 4. dispositions or formations (saṃskāra)
 5. consciousness (vijñāna)
- □□ The philosophical force lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation rather than an independently real substance.
- The canonical test formula. Each aggregate is examined and found impermanent; what is impermanent and grasped is unsatisfactory; and what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be regarded as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self". The argument therefore runs through the three marks and is not a separate line of reasoning.

2. The chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha)

- □ The classic chariot analogy argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.
- □ Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas.
- □□ The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal. It is that the person is conventionally valid but not ultimately self-subsistent.
- Deploying the analogy well. Weak scripts use the chariot to say "the self is unreal". Strong scripts use it to make a semantic point: the analogy shows that a term can be true without being referential to a further entity. That distinction is what protects Buddhism from the charge of denying persons.

3. Personal no-self and phenomenon no-self — the 2021 distinction

Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya).

- □ Denial of a permanent personal self (pudgala, person).
- □ This is the minimum no-self thesis shared across Buddhism.

Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya).

- □ Denial that even the constituent factors (dharma) possess intrinsic self-nature (svabhāva).
- □ This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

School difference.

- ☐ Early Buddhism and non-Mahāyāna Abhidharma traditions share the denial of a permanent personal self. Several realist Abhidharma schools nevertheless treat dharmas as ultimately real.
- ☐ Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika, extends the denial to intrinsic nature in the dharmas themselves.
- ☐ This is a difference of philosophical scope, not a licence to equate Theravāda with the loaded "Hīnayāna" label.

| Thesis | What is denied | Who strongly stresses it |

|---|---|---|

| Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) | an enduring person or self | shared across Buddhist traditions |

| Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) | intrinsic nature of dharmas | developed emphatically in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika |

☐ The one-sentence contrast that scores. The first no-self dissolves the owner; the second dissolves the inventory on which the owner was denied. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika accept the first while keeping a real inventory; Mādhyamika applies the same analysis to the inventory itself.

4. The person-theory foil (Puggalavāda)

- ☐ Some Buddhist groups, associated especially with the Vātsīputrīyas, proposed a person (pudgala) that is neither identical with nor different from the aggregates.
- ☐ Mainstream Buddhists criticised this as a relapse toward self-theory.
- ☐ In answers, use the foil constructively: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real and internally felt, and that orthodox Buddhist thought refused to relieve it by reintroducing a substantial person.

☐ Why the foil is worth two lines in any no-self answer. It pre-empts the examiner's implicit question — "did Buddhists themselves find this satisfying?" — and answers it honestly. The doctrine is stronger, not weaker, for being shown to have cost something.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. No-self is a conclusion drawn from an exhaustive analysis of the person, and its philosophical burden rests on the completeness of the five-aggregate enumeration.

Named evidence. The person is analysed as form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; the chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha shows that a term can function correctly without designating an additional entity; the Puggalavāda of the Vātsīputrīyas attempted a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates and was rejected by mainstream Buddhism.

Analysis. Because each aggregate fails the tests of permanence and independence, and because no sixth item is discovered, "self" is exposed as a designation rather than a referent. The rejection of the Puggalavāda then shows that Buddhism accepted the cost of the analysis rather than softening it, which is why the doctrine cannot be read as a merely verbal denial.

Qualification / link. The denial operates on the ultimate level while leaving the conventional person fully functional, so an answer must distinguish the two levels explicitly; without that distinction, the doctrine looks either trivially verbal or self-defeating for ethics and practice.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Defining no-self without listing the aggregates. ☐ The enumeration is the argument.
2. ☐ Confusing personal and phenomenon no-self. ☐ Owner versus inventory; the 2021 question tests exactly this.
3. ☐ Saying Buddhism denies the person. ☐ It denies a permanent self; the conventional person is retained.
4. ☐ Using the chariot to prove unreality. ☐ Use it to prove non-referential correctness.
5. ☐ Ignoring the Puggalavāda. ☐ It shows the internal pressure and its principled refusal.

RAPID REVISION

- Five aggregates: form · feeling · perception · formations · consciousness.
- Argument: exhaustive analysis + three marks → "self" is a designation (prajñapti).
- Personal no-self denies the owner; phenomenon no-self denies intrinsic nature in the factors.
- Chariot analogy: a term can be true without naming a further thing.
- Puggalavāda is a rejected internal foil, useful as evidence of principled cost.

SESSION 8 — ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (karma), MEMORY, IDENTITY AND REBIRTH WITHOUT A SELF

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: if nothing lasts and nobody owns the process, how can the person who acts be the person who pays? This session is Buddhism's answer.

Technical definition: Buddhism explains moral consequence, memory, personal identity and rebirth through the causal continuum (santāna), holding that the later stream-stage is neither identical with nor wholly different from the earlier one (na sa eva na cānyaḥ), supplemented in Yogācāra by store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Buddhist account of moral consequence is deliberately a middle: strict identity between agent and recipient would reinstate the eternal self it has just denied, while strict difference would make reward and punishment fall on a stranger — so Buddhism denies the shared assumption that responsibility requires either.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- causal continuum (santāna / santati); reconnection (pratisandhāna)
- neither identical nor wholly different (na sa eva na cānyaḥ)
- store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja)
- intention (cetanā) as the locus of moral quality
- recognition (pratyabhijñā) — the Nyāya pressure point
- lamp-to-lamp and flame / stream analogies

How to use them: the 2021 fifteen-marker and the 2022 twenty-marker both live here. Both require the middle formula stated explicitly, both require a named objection, and both require an honest statement of residual force.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

ONE LAMP LIGHTS ANOTHER

lamp A ---- flame passes ----> lamp B

Is B's flame the same flame as A's? NO — not numerically.
Is it unrelated to A's flame? NO — it was caused by it.

So: NEITHER THE SAME NOR ANOTHER.

Now read it morally:
the stream that acted -> conditions -> the stream that receives
not the same person, not a different person, but ONE CAUSAL SERIES

In simple words: the objection assumes there are only two options — same person or different person. The lamp shows a third: causally continuous. Ordinary life already accepts this. A promise made at twenty binds at sixty although almost nothing physical or mental has stayed identical.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Series | Moments causally linked, each conditioning the next |

| Neither/nor formula | Not the same, not another — the standard Buddhist phrasing |

| Seeds | Latent tendencies carried forward, maturing when conditions permit |

| Rebirth | One psycho-physical series conditions another; nothing travels |

One-line memory: nothing crosses over; everything is handed on.

□ □ VISUAL — WHERE THE OBJECTION STRIKES AND WHAT ANSWERS IT

OBJECTION (Nyāya · Mīmāṃsā · Vedānta) BUDDHIST DEVICE

"Who remembers?" -> santāna: later cognition is memory needs one subject at two times conditioned by the earlier one

"Who recognises?" -> sādṛśya within a stream: pratyabhijñā needs numerical identity similarity misread as identity

"Who deserves?" -> na sa eva na cānyaḥ: the fruit desert needs the doer = the enjoyer falls on the continuous series

"What is reborn?" -> pratisandhāna: relinking of one rebirth seems to need a traveller series to the next; nothing travels

"What stores it all?" -> ālaya-vijñāna with bīja (Yogācāra supplement) — a transforming stream, NOT an ātman

RESIDUAL FORCE ☐ a series may explain succession without explaining OWNERSHIP

☐ ☐ Caption. Learn the right-hand column as a set of named devices, each attached to the objection it answers. The last row is deliberately included: examiners reward candidates who can state where the reply is weakest, and "critically discuss" is a standing instruction to do so.

1. Memory and personal identity under momentariness — the 2021 question

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line).

- ☐ If every mental state perishes instantly, who remembers a past event?
- ☐ If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

Buddhist replies.

1. ☐ Causal continuum (santāna) — memory belongs to the same causal stream rather than to a permanent self; the earlier experience conditions a later cognition that presents itself as recollection.
2. ☐ Reconnection (pratisandhāna) — relinking explains continuity across moments and across lives.
3. ☐ Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) in Yogācāra — a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (bīja, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential without a self.

☐ ☐ Philosophical point. The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than the earlier one.

☐ ☐ Where the reply is strongest and weakest. It is strongest against the demand for a carrier, since seeds and streams discharge that function. It is weakest against the demand for a subject, since the phenomenology of memory presents a first-person claim ("I did that") which a series can explain causally but arguably not vindicate.

2. Action and moral consequence without a permanent self — the 2022 question

Problem.

- ☐ Moral consequence seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

Buddhist answer.

- ☐ The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.
- ☐ The relation is neither identity nor utter difference.
- ☐ ☐ If it were strict identity, Buddhism would collapse into eternalism; if it were total difference, responsibility would collapse. The doctrine of the series protects moral continuity without substantial selfhood.

☐ What carries the moral quality. Buddhism locates the moral character of an act in intention (cetanā), not in outward movement. Intention is a formation (saṃskāra), so it belongs to the aggregates and is fully available to the series analysis. This is why the doctrine does not need a self to make actions moral: it needs only that volitions condition later states.

☐ ☐ Example. One lamp lights another. The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it. Rebirth and karmic fruition are explained analogically in this way — with the deliberate implication that nothing passes across, and that what continues is a pattern of conditioning.

3. Rebirth without transmigration

□ Rebirth in Buddhism is not transmigration. Nothing exits one body and enters another. One psycho-physical series conditions the arising of another, with the relinking consciousness (pratisandhi-vijñāna in the Theravāda analysis) as the first moment of the new series.

□□ The contrast that earns marks. Jainism, Nyāya and Vedānta all give rebirth a subject — the soul that travels. Buddhism gives rebirth a relation — the conditioning of one series by another. This is exactly why the 2024 Cārvāka comparison matters: Cārvāka denies continuity altogether, Vedānta gives it a permanent bearer, and Buddhism keeps the continuity while refusing the bearer.

4. The residual pressure, stated honestly

□□ The unresolved question is whether causal continuity alone is enough for desert, as distinct from explanation. That a later stage is caused by an earlier one explains why it has certain features; it is less obvious that it makes the later stage deserving of what the earlier one earned.

□ The best Buddhist rejoinder. Desert, like ownership, is a conventional notion, and conventional notions are legitimate precisely because they track causal continuity. The realist demand for ultimate desert presupposes an ultimate subject — the very item under dispute — so the objection begs the question at the ultimate level while being perfectly satisfiable at the conventional level.

□ Verdict to write. The Buddhist position is coherent and is not defeated, but it purchases coherence by relocating desert to the conventional level; whether that relocation satisfies moral intuition remains the genuine dispute between Buddhism and its realist critics.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Moral consequence, memory and rebirth are compatible with momentariness and no-self because Buddhism replaces the identity requirement with a continuity requirement.

Named evidence. The formula na sa eva na cānyaḥ states that the later stage is neither the same nor another; the causal continuum (santāna) and reconnection (pratisandhāna) carry memory and rebirth; Yogācāra adds store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) with seeds (bīja); the moral quality of an act is located in intention (cetanā), which is itself a formation among the aggregates.

Analysis. Because the objection from Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta assumes that responsibility requires either strict identity or strict difference, Buddhism's reply works by denying the disjunction rather than by choosing a branch: causal appropriation within one series does the work formerly assigned to a persisting owner, and intention supplies the moral content without a bearer.

Qualification / link. The reply explains succession more successfully than it explains ownership, so the honest verdict is that desert is preserved at the conventional level while the realist demand for an ultimate subject is refused as question-begging — a defensible position, but not one that removes the pressure.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Answering the karma objection by quietly reintroducing a subtle self. □ The device is santāna, never ātman.
2. □ Treating store-consciousness as a Buddhist soul. □ It is a conditioned, transforming stream carrying seeds.
3. □ Describing rebirth as transmigration. □ Nothing travels; one series conditions another.
4. □ Omitting intention (cetanā). □ It is where the moral quality of the act resides.
5. □ Declaring the objection defeated. □ State the ownership gap; the directive demands it.

RAPID REVISION

- Formula: na sa eva na cānyaḥ — neither the same nor another.
- Devices: santāna, sādṛśya, pratisandhāna, and in Yogācāra ālaya-vijñāna + bīja.
- Moral content sits in intention (cetanā), a formation among the aggregates.
- Rebirth is relinking, not transmigration.
- Residual force: continuity explains succession better than it explains ownership.

SESSION 9 — CESSATION OF CONDITIONED SUFFERING (nirvāṇa), THE THREE JEWELS (Triratna) AND THE CONSISTENCY QUESTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: liberation in Buddhism is not a place reached or a possession gained; it is a process stopping because its fuel has run out.

Technical definition: cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa; Pali: nibbāna) is the extinction of the three fires — attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and delusion (moha) — and thereby the cessation of the conditioned production of suffering; important Buddhist classifications treat it as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) without making it the state of an eternal self.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The question "if there is no self, who attains liberation?" is not a difficulty for Buddhism but a demonstration of the point at issue: it presupposes the very claimant whose removal is the liberation, and the Buddhist reply is to show that the question is malformed rather than merely unanswered.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa; Pali: nibbāna)
- the three fires: attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa), delusion (moha)
- unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) — the classificatory point
- Three Jewels (Triratna): Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha
- conventional person (prajñapti-puruṣa) — who takes refuge
- saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms — the Nāgārjuna formulation

How to use them: the 2018 fifteen-marker and the 2025 fifteen-marker are near-twins on exactly this consistency question, and the 2022 fifteen-marker asks the same question through the Three Jewels. One well-built answer-frame serves all three.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

A FIRE GOES OUT.

Wrong question: "Where did the fire GO?"

north? south? east? west?

Right answer: it did not go anywhere — its fuel ended.

Now: "If there is no self, WHO is liberated?"

Same shape of question. Same reply.

Nothing is released FROM the process.

The process of releasing-and-grasping simply stops.

In simple words: we imagine liberation as a prize handed to somebody. Buddhism says the prize-model is exactly the ignorance being cured. Craving invents an owner; liberation is what happens when the invention stops being made.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Three fires | Attachment, aversion, delusion — what is extinguished |

| Not a place | Not a heaven, not a substance, not a state of an ego |

| Not annihilation | The process ends; there was never a self to be destroyed |

| Who practises? | The conventional person — a valid designation, not a soul |

One-line memory: the fire does not travel when it goes out, and neither does the person.

□ □ VISUAL — THE CONSISTENCY ARGUMENT IN FOUR MOVES

OBJECTION (Śaṃkara-type Advaita and Nyāya realist)

=====

(a) If there is no self, WHO attains nirvāṇa?

(b) If everything is momentary, WHAT persists in liberation?

|

v

MOVE 1 The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism denies.

|

v

MOVE 2 Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.

|

v

MOVE 3 It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.

|

v

MOVE 4 Therefore CONSONANCE: no-self removes the false claimant; momentariness explains why the chain CAN in fact cease.

|

v

□□ RESIDUAL: the first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained as a conventional index within the stream — the Advaitin presses that the UNITY of experience still needs accounting for.

□□ Caption. Memorise the four moves as a unit. They convert a defensive answer ("Buddhism can survive the objection") into an offensive one ("the objection presupposes what is under dispute"), which is the difference between a mid-range and a high-range script on the 2018 and 2025 questions.

1. What cessation of conditioned suffering is

- □ Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) extinguishes the three fires: attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and delusion (moha).
- □ It is not best understood as a substantial place or an eternal self-state gained by an entity.
- □□ It is the cessation of the very process that produces bondage.
- The classificatory nuance that must be stated. Important Buddhist traditions classify nirvāṇa as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta). □□ This does not smuggle in an eternal self: to be unconditioned is to be outside the series of dependently arisen formations, not to be a substance that owns properties. A candidate who writes "nirvāṇa is just another momentary event" has misread the classification; a candidate who writes "nirvāṇa is the eternal self attained" has misread it in the opposite direction.

2. The Three Jewels (Triratna) and no-self — the 2022 question

Problem.

- □ If there is no self, who takes refuge in the Three Jewels (Triratna) — Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha?

Reply.

- □ The refuge-taker is the conventional person, a designated person (prajñapti-puruṣa), not an ultimately real soul.
- □ Ethical and spiritual practice proceeds at the level of conventional truth without requiring a metaphysical ātman.
- □□ No-self therefore does not abolish discipline; it purifies discipline of ego-metaphysics.
- The internal relation the question asks for. The three are not a list of objects of devotion but a functional triad: the Buddha is the one who discovered and demonstrated the path; the Dharma is the teaching and the truth it states, and is what actually liberates; the Saṅgha is the community that preserves, transmits and exemplifies it. □□ The dependence runs Buddha → Dharma → Saṅgha in origin, and Saṅgha → Dharma → Buddha in access: a practitioner today reaches the Buddha only through the community that preserved the teaching.
- Why the triad is consistent with no-self. Refuge is not surrender of a soul to a saviour. The Dharma is efficacious as teaching, so what is required of the refuge-taker is not an enduring metaphysical subject but a series capable of being conditioned by instruction. Since intention and dispositions are aggregates, the series has exactly the properties refuge requires.

3. Is cessation consistent with momentariness and no-self? — the 2018 and 2025 questions

Objection — Śaṃkara-type Advaita and Nyāya realist.

- □ If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?
- □ If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?

Reply.

1. ☐ The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects.
2. ☐ Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.
3. ☐ It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.
4. ☐ So consonance exists: no-self removes the false claimant to liberation, while momentariness explains why the chain can in fact cease.

☐ The strongest single sentence. Far from being in tension, the three doctrines are mutually supporting: if the self were permanent, liberation would be impossible; if events were not momentary, the chain could not be interrupted; and if the process were not conditioned, cessation would not follow from removing a condition.

Theravāda and Mahāyāna nuance.

- ☐ Theravāda foregrounds the liberated-saint (arhat; Pali: arahant) ideal and describes cessation of suffering as nibbāna; important Theravāda classifications treat nibbāna as unconditioned without making it the state of an eternal self.
- ☐ Mahāyāna foregrounds the awakening-being (bodhisattva) path toward complete Buddhahood for the benefit of all beings.
- ☐ Do not reproduce the old polemical caricature that arhatship is simply selfish or that the bodhisattva ideal is merely delayed personal salvation.
- ☐ In Nāgārjuna's radical formulation, saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

4. The residual difficulty, stated honestly

☐ Causal continuity explains transmission, but critics ask whether it fully explains the first-person claim "I am liberated". ☐ The Buddhist answer is that this "I" is a conventional index within the stream rather than evidence for an eternal self. ☐ The Advaitin presses further: the unity of experience — the fact that a manifold is presented as one field — seems to require a witnessing consciousness that Buddhism cannot supply without reifying it. This is the strongest surviving objection in the topic, and naming it is a mark of philosophical maturity rather than a concession.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. No permanent self and cessation of conditioned suffering are not merely compatible; each is required by the other.
Named evidence. Nirvāṇa is defined as the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion; important traditions classify it as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta); the refuge-taker in the Three Jewels is the conventional designated person (prajñapti-puruṣa); and Nāgārjuna holds that saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms.
Analysis. Because liberation is redescribed as the cessation of a conditioned process rather than as an acquisition by an owner, the demand for a persisting attainer is exposed as an artefact of the ignorance being cured; momentariness then supplies the positive explanation of why cessation is possible at all, since only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by removing a condition.
Qualification / link. The reply secures consistency at the cost of relocating the first-person claim to conventional truth, and the Advaitic charge that the unity of experience still requires a witness is the one objection Buddhism answers by refusal rather than by explanation — a defensible refusal, but the point at which the debate genuinely rests.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Describing nirvāṇa as a place or a heaven. ☐ It is the extinction of the three fires and the cessation of a process.
2. ☐ Calling nirvāṇa annihilation. ☐ There was never a self to annihilate; the process ends.
3. ☐ Saying the Three Jewels contradict no-self. ☐ The conventional person is a valid designation and is all that refuge requires.
4. ☐ Treating unconditioned status as proof of an eternal self. ☐ Unconditioned means outside the dependent series, not substantial.
5. ☐ Answering the consistency question defensively. ☐ Show that the objection presupposes the disputed self.

RAPID REVISION

- Definition: extinction of attachment, aversion, delusion; cessation of the conditioned process.
- Classification: unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) in important traditions — outside the series, not a substance.

- Three Jewels: Buddha discovered, Dharma liberates, Saṅgha transmits; the refuge-taker is the conventional person.
- Four moves: presupposition exposed → not an entity → cessation of the series → mutual support.
- Residual: the unity of experience objection from Advaita is answered by refusal, not by explanation.

SESSION 10 — VAIBHĀṢIKA AND SAUTRĀNTIKA: THE TWO BUDDHIST REALISMS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: the first two schools agree that the external world is real and disagree about whether we see it directly or only work it out from what appears in the mind.

Technical definition: Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about external objects (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda) together with the Sarvāstivāda thesis that dharmas of the three times have some mode of existence; Sautrāntika holds representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda), on which external objects exist but are known only inferentially through mental representation (ākāra), and restricts full existence to the present moment.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The two Buddhist realisms are separated by a single question with enormous consequences: if the object-moment has already ceased when the cognition of it arises, can that cognition be a seeing of the object at all — and Sautrāntika's answer, that it can only be a representing, opens the door through which Yogācāra will later walk.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Vaibhāṣika; Sarvāstivāda; the Kashmir Mahāvibhāṣā tradition
- direct realism (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda); sarvam asti
- Sautrāntika; representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda)
- representation or form (ākāra) and presentism about time
- momentariness as the pressure point between them

How to use them: the 2024 fifteen-marker requires this pair to supply the "everything is real" half of the contrast. Do not treat them as minor scholastic detail; they are one half of the question.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

YOU SEE A BLUE PATCH.

VAIBHĀṢIKA: the blue thing itself is what your awareness grasps.
Cognition reaches out and takes hold of the object.

SAUTRĀNTIKA: by the time awareness happens, the blue moment is over.
What you have is a blue-formed image. From that image
you INFER a corresponding external cause.

The gap between them is TIME, not scepticism.
Both say the external world is real. They differ on access.

In simple words: imagine light from a star. Vaibhāṣika says you are looking at the star. Sautrāntika says you are looking at light that the star sent, and reasoning back to the star. Both agree the star is there.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Both are realists | External objects exist independently of being known |

| Vaibhāṣika access | Direct perception; cognition grasps the object |

| Sautrāntika access | Representation plus inference; cognition presents a form |

| The pressure | Momentariness — the object has already gone |

One-line memory: the disagreement is not "is it there?" but "how late are we?"

□ □ VISUAL — ONE PREMISE, TWO REALISMS, AND WHY THE SECOND IS UNSTABLE

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SHARED PREMISE: everything conditioned is momentary
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||
VAIBHĀŚIKA SAUTRĀNTIKA
keep DIRECT ACCESS keep the TIME-GAP
||
must allow dharmas of past must allow that what is
and future SOME mode of present to awareness is a
existence (sarvam asti) FORM (ākāra), not the object
||
COST: strains momentariness; COST: the external object
overpopulates the ontology becomes an INFERENCE
||
Sautrāntika objects -----> Yogācāra objects:
if all you ever have is the
form, the inferred external
object does NO WORK
|
v
CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY

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□□ Caption. This diagram is the engine of the whole four-school escalation. Each school is generated by keeping one commitment and paying for it. Reproducing this structure — commitment, cost, objection, next position — is what turns a list of four schools into the argumentative chain the syllabus term "Schools of Buddhism" is really asking for.

1. Vaibhāṣika direct realism

- □ Usually associated with Sarvāstivāda realism, especially the Kashmir Mahāvibhāṣā tradition, from whose commentary (vibhāṣā) the school takes its name.
- □ Holds direct realism (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda): external objects are directly perceived.
- □ Affirms sarvam asti — "all exists" — in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.
- □□ The doctrine does not mean that all three times are causally active in the same way; present dharmas have the distinctive present efficacy.

Philosophical significance.

- □□ Vaibhāṣika preserves the Buddhist anti-self doctrine while maintaining a robust realism about dharmas: the person is dissolved, the inventory is not.
- □□ It is therefore the indispensable contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism, and it is the school that makes "everything is real" a genuinely Buddhist conclusion rather than a foreign import.

□□ *Why sarvam asti is asserted at all.* Two problems drive it: a past act must be able to produce a future fruit, and a cognition must have an object. If only the present exists, both relations lose one relatum. Vaibhāṣika buys the relations at the price of a crowded ontology — which is precisely what Sautrāntika refuses to pay.

2. Sautrāntika representational realism

- □ Holds representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda): external objects exist but are known only inferentially through mental representations.
- □ Rejects the Sarvāstivāda thesis that past and future dharmas exist in the same sense as present ones.
- □ Strongly privileges the present moment.
- □□ Historically, "Sautrāntika" can designate critical currents rather than one simple institutional school; the exam-relevant doxographic contrast is its appeal to sūtra against Vaibhāṣika Abhidharma claims, together with inferred external objects against direct realism.

Distinction from Vaibhāṣika.

Issue	Vaibhāṣika	Sautrāntika
External object	real	real
How known	directly perceived	inferentially known via representation

□ The Sautrāntika argument, stated in order. (i) All conditioned things are momentary. (ii) Cognition and its object are distinct events. (iii) A cause must precede its effect. (iv) Therefore when the cognition occurs, the object-moment that caused it has already ceased. (v) Therefore cognition cannot grasp the object; it can only bear its form (ākāra). (vi) The external object is therefore established by inference from that form, not by perception of the object itself.

□□ The price. Representational realism must explain correspondence: why the inferred external cause should resemble the form it produces. This is the classical weak point, and it is exactly the joint at which Yogācāra applies pressure.

3. Why this pair supplies the "everything is real" half of the 2024 question

□ Both schools accept dependent origination. □ Both infer from it that dependently arisen dharmas are real as conditioned entities — real because causally efficacious, not real because permanent.

□□ The precise formulation to write. For the realists, dependence proves the absence of permanence, not the absence of reality. For Mādhyamika, dependence proves the absence of intrinsic nature, which for it is the criterion of ultimate reality. The two conclusions therefore diverge because the schools apply different criteria of the ultimately real to the same causal premise. That sentence is the analytical core of the 2024 answer.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. The two Buddhist realisms are generated by a single unresolved tension between momentariness and perceptual access.

Named evidence. Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda) and affirms sarvam asti, that dharmas of the three times have some mode of existence; Sautrāntika holds representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda), restricts full existence to the present moment, and treats cognition as bearing the object's form (ākāra) from which the external object is inferred.

Analysis. Because a momentary object must cease before the cognition it causes can arise, direct grasping can be preserved only by extending existence across the three times, as Vaibhāṣika does, or abandoned in favour of representation, as Sautrāntika does. Each school therefore pays for what it keeps: Vaibhāṣika pays in ontological economy, Sautrāntika pays in the correspondence problem.

Qualification / link. "Sautrāntika" names critical currents rather than a single institution, so the contrast should be presented as a doxographic and philosophical one, and the school's instability should be reported as the reason Yogācāra could press its objection rather than as a defect the tradition itself failed to notice.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Calling either school a branch of Theravāda. □ Both belong to the Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna world.
2. □ Reading sarvam asti as eternalism. □ It is a technical thesis about modes of existence across the three times, not permanence of substance.
3. □ Treating Sautrāntika as sceptical about the external world. □ It affirms the external world and disputes only the mode of access.
4. □ Omitting the correspondence problem. □ It is the joint through which Yogācāra advances.
5. □ Presenting the pair as scholastic trivia. □ They supply the entire "everything is real" half of the 2024 question.

RAPID REVISION

- Vaibhāṣika: direct realism + sarvam asti; named from the Mahāvibhāṣā.
- Sautrāntika: representational realism + presentism; named from reliance on the sūtras.
- Sautrāntika argument: momentariness → time-gap → form (ākāra) → inference to the object.
- Costs: Vaibhāṣika overpopulates; Sautrāntika owes an account of correspondence.
- Both give "everything is real" the sense of causally efficacious, not permanent.

SESSION 11 — YOGĀCĀRA / CONSCIOUSNESS-ONLY (vijñānavāda): STORE-CONSCIOUSNESS AND THE THREE NATURES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Yogācāra argues that everything we can ever check is an appearance in awareness, so the extra step of positing an independent object outside awareness explains nothing that awareness has not already explained.

Technical definition: Yogācāra advances consciousness-only or representation-only (vijñaptimātra): what appears as an external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness; continuity and regularity are explained by store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja); and the analysis is organised through the three natures (tri-svabhāva) — imagined, dependent and perfected.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Yogācāra is best stated as an argument about redundancy rather than an assertion about magic: it does not claim that a private ego conjures the world, but that once the representational analysis is accepted, the further external object performs no explanatory work that store-consciousness and karmic seeds do not already perform.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- consciousness-only / representation-only (vijñaptimātra)
- store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja); latent impressions (vāsanā)
- dream argument and the atom critique
- three natures (tri-svabhāva): parikalpita, paratantra, pariniṣpanna
- self-awareness of cognition (svasaṃvedana)
- not solipsism — shared karmic conditioning

How to use them: the 2019 ten-marker asks exactly how Yogācāra denies the external world. Give arguments, not translation. Three arguments plus the three natures plus one anti-solipsism sentence is a complete answer.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

IN A DREAM YOU SEE A ROOM.

It has depth, colour, other people, and a "you" looking at it.
Everything needed for a WORLD is present.
Nothing outside consciousness is required to supply it.

THEREFORE: the mere fact that experience LOOKS outer
does not prove that something outer CAUSES it.

Question that follows:
if awareness can produce all of this by itself,
what work is the extra external object doing?

In simple words: Yogācāra does not begin by denying the world. It begins by noticing that "it seems external" is a feature of the experience, and features of the experience cannot by themselves prove something beyond experience. The rest of the school is an attempt to explain order without that extra step.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Representation-only | What is given is presentation, not an independently established object |

| Store-consciousness | An underlying stream holding tendencies that ripen into experience |

| Seeds | Latent karmic potentials; they explain why experience is regular |

| Not solipsism | Shared conditioning, not one ego inventing everything |

One-line memory: the dream proves that appearing-outer is cheap; the seeds explain why the appearing is orderly.

□ □ VISUAL — THE THREE NATURES AS ONE DIAGNOSIS, NOT THREE WORLDS

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| 3. PERFECTED NATURE (pariniṣpanna) |
| the dependent flow SEEN AS IT IS — without the imagined duality |
| ^ |
| | remove the superimposition |
| | |
| 2. DEPENDENT NATURE (paratantra) |
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| the actual causally conditioned flow of cognition |
| | |
| | superimpose subject-vs-object |
| v |
| 1. IMAGINED NATURE (parikalpita) |
| the constructed duality: "a knower over here, a thing over there" |
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ONE flow, described three ways:
as it is falsely taken (1), as it actually runs (2), as it is truly seen (3).

□□ Caption. The commonest error is to treat the three natures as three kinds of entity. They are three descriptions of the same dependent flow. Saying this explicitly earns marks, because it simultaneously answers the objection that Yogācāra multiplies realities and shows why liberation is a change in seeing rather than a change in inventory.

1. Statement

- □ Yogācāra advances consciousness-only or representation-only (vijñaptimātra).
- □ What appears as an external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

□□ The careful formulation. The thesis is best stated as the denial of an independently established external object, not as the claim that objects are figments. This wording is defensible against every standard objection and is what distinguishes a philosophically literate script.

2. Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna)

- □ Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) preserves karmic seeds (bīja), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.
- □□ Store-consciousness is a conditioned, transforming stream, not an eternal ātman in disguise. Mādhyamika will press exactly this charge, and a script must pre-empt it.
- What it explains, listed for use in an answer. (i) Why experience is orderly rather than arbitrary — seeds ripen according to karmic conditions. (ii) Why memory is possible without a self — impressions (vāsanā) are deposited and later activated. (iii) Why rebirth is possible without transmigration — the stream carries seeds across the discontinuity of death. (iv) Why the world appears shared — beings with similar karmic accumulation undergo similarly structured experience.
- The anti-solipsism sentence. Yogācāra's world is intersubjective because it is karmically conditioned in common, not because a plurality of egos happen to agree. This is the single most effective line against the charge that consciousness-only makes shared experience mysterious.

3. Arguments against external realism

1. □ Dream argument. Dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.
2. □ Atom critique. If atoms are partless, they cannot combine spatially — a partless thing has no side to touch another. If they have parts, they are not ultimate atoms. Hence external atomism is unstable, and with it the standard realist account of gross objects.
3. □ The time-gap argument, taken over from Sautrāntika and pressed further. If both object and cognition are momentary, the object allegedly known has already ceased when cognition arises; only its presented form is available. Yogācāra concludes that the inferred external cause is idle.
- How the three arguments divide labour. The dream argument removes the evidence for externality; the atom critique removes the coherence of the external object; the time-gap argument removes its explanatory role. Presenting them as a division of labour rather than as three parallel points is the analytical move that lifts the 2019 answer.

4. The three natures (tri-svabhāva)

- □ imagined nature (parikalpita-svabhāva) — the constructed subject–object duality
- □ dependent nature (paratantra-svabhāva) — the dependently arisen flow of cognition
- □ perfected or consummate nature (pariṇiṣpanna-svabhāva) — that same flow realised as free of imagined duality
- □□ Together they explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

□ Self-awareness (svasaṃvedana). Yogācāra epistemology treats cognition as self-revealing: a cognition manifests itself without requiring a second cognition to know it. □□ This is what allows consciousness-only to avoid an infinite regress of knowers, and it is precisely what Nyāya attacks as collapsing object, cognition and knower into one.

5. The standing difficulty

□□ The genuine question is whether ordinary experience can be explained without covertly restoring an object-independent world: the regularity that seeds are invoked to explain is just the regularity a realist would explain by objects, and the critic asks whether "seed" is doing more than renaming the explanandum.

□ The Yogācāra rejoinder. Seeds are not a redescription but a causal posit within a system that already requires karmic continuity for independent reasons — memory, moral consequence and rebirth. Since store-consciousness is needed anyway, explaining perceptual order by the same mechanism is theoretical economy rather than evasion. □ Whether that rejoinder succeeds is one of the live interpretive disputes reserved for the optional block.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Yogācāra denies the independently established external object by argument, not by assertion, and replaces its explanatory role with store-consciousness.

Named evidence. The dream argument shows that a complete world-appearance requires no external correlate; the atom critique shows that partless atoms cannot combine while composite ones are not ultimate; store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) with seeds (bīja) supplies continuity, memory and shared regularity; and the three natures — imagined, dependent and perfected — describe one flow under false, actual and realised aspects.

Analysis. Because each argument attacks a different support of realism — its evidence, its coherence and its explanatory function — the cumulative case is that the external object is not refuted so much as made redundant, and the three natures then show that liberation consists in withdrawing a superimposition rather than in acquiring a new object.

Qualification / link. The account owes an explanation of intersubjective order that does not simply rename what realism explained by objects, and the honest position is that shared karmic conditioning discharges the debt only if store-consciousness is independently required, which Buddhism argues it is on grounds of memory and moral consequence.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Translating vijñaptimātra as "the mind creates the world". □ It denies an independently established object; it does not license private fantasy.
2. □ Treating store-consciousness as a self. □ It is a conditioned transforming stream carrying seeds.
3. □ Listing the three natures as three realities. □ They are three descriptions of one dependent flow.
4. □ Giving only the dream argument. □ Add the atom critique and the time-gap argument.
5. □ Ignoring the intersubjectivity objection. □ Answer it by shared karmic conditioning.

RAPID REVISION

- Thesis: representation-only (vijñaptimātra) — no independently established external object.
- Three arguments: dream (evidence), atoms (coherence), time-gap (explanatory role).
- Continuity engine: ālaya-vijñāna + bīja + vāsanā; explains memory, rebirth, shared order.
- Three natures: parikalpita (imagined) · paratantra (dependent) · pariniṣpanna (perfected).
- svasaṃvedana blocks the regress of knowers and is attacked by Nyāya.

SESSION 12 — MĀDHYAMIKA / EMPTINESS (śūnyavāda): FOUR CORNERS, TWO TRUTHS AND NEGATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Mādhyamika argues that nothing at all — not objects, not the mind, not even emptiness — has a nature of its own, and that this is exactly what dependent origination has been saying all along.

Technical definition: Mādhyamika or emptiness-doctrine (śūnyavāda), associated especially with Nāgārjuna, holds that all dharmas are empty (śūnya) of intrinsic nature (svabhāva); it deploys the four-cornered analysis (catuṣkoṭi) as a non-implicative negation

(prasajya-pratiṣedha) and preserves ordinary life through the doctrine of two truths — conventional (saṃvṛti-satya) and ultimate (paramārtha-satya).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Emptiness is not a thesis about what there is but a refusal of a question: Nāgārjuna does not say that things are nothing, he says that the demand for an intrinsic nature has no answerable form, and the doctrine of two truths exists precisely to stop that refusal from becoming nihilism.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- emptiness (śūnyatā); intrinsic nature or own-being (svabhāva)
- four-cornered analysis (catuṣkoṭi): asti · nāsti · asti ca nāsti ca · naivāsti naiva nāsti
- non-implicative negation (prasajya-pratiṣedha) vs implicative negation (paryudāsa-pratiṣedha)
- two truths: conventional (saṃvṛti-satya) and ultimate (paramārtha-satya)
- no thesis of my own (pratijñā) — the Vigrahavyāvartanī move
- emptiness of emptiness; the snake-wrongly-seized warning

How to use them: the 2018 ten-marker asks for the derivation from dependent origination to emptiness; the 2024 fifteen-marker asks for the contrast with the realists. The two-truths frame is compulsory in both, because without it the answer reads as nihilism.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

ASK OF ANYTHING: "WHAT IS IT, ALL BY ITSELF?"

a chariot -> parts + arrangement + use + a name
a flame -> fuel + air + heat
a person -> five aggregates + conditions + a designation
a cause -> only a cause RELATIVE to an effect
emptiness -> only the absence of self-nature IN dependently arisen things

Every answer points OUTWARD to something else.
Nothing answers the question from inside itself.
That "nothing answers from inside" is what ŚŪNYATĀ names.

NOTE: the chariot still carries you. Emptiness removes an ANSWER, not a chariot.

In simple words: emptiness is the report of a failed search, and the search was for a thing that could be what it is without depending on anything. Nothing passes that test — which is exactly what dependent origination said. Nāgārjuna's originality is to see that the two statements are one statement.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Empty of what? | Empty of intrinsic nature, not empty of existence |

| Why "middle"? | Between "it exists absolutely" and "it does not exist at all" |

| Two truths | Conventional life is preserved; ultimate analysis denies self-nature |

| Emptiness of emptiness | Emptiness is not a new absolute; it too is dependent designation |

One-line memory: dependently arisen and empty are two names for one fact.

□ □ VISUAL — THE FOUR CORNERS AND WHY DENYING ALL FOUR IS NOT CONTRADICTION

THE FOUR CORNERS (catuṣkoṭi), APPLIED TO A THING TAKEN AS HAVING svabhāva

+---+-----+-----+
1	asti	it IS
2	nāsti	it IS NOT
3	asti ca nāsti ca	it both is and is not
4	naivāsti naiva nāsti	it neither is nor is not
+---+-----+-----+

|
ALL FOUR ARE DENIED
|

+-----+-----+
||

IF the negation were IMPLICATIVE BUT it is NON-IMPLICATIVE
 (paryudāsa: "not-A" asserts B) (prasajya: denies without
 | asserting any alternative)
 v |
 then denying all four WOULD be v
 contradiction — you would be no fifth position is installed;
 asserting four incompatible things the QUESTION is withdrawn
 |
 v
 "I have no thesis (pratijñā) of my own"
 — and my words are empty too

□□ Caption. This is the single most misunderstood diagram in Indian philosophy, and examiners know it. The negation type is the whole answer: candidates who write "Nāgārjuna denies the law of contradiction" lose the question, while candidates who write "prasajya-pratiṣedha, so no fifth thesis is installed" have supplied the reply to the self-refutation charge before it is even raised.

1. Statement

- Associated especially with Nāgārjuna.
- The central thesis is emptiness (śūnyatā): the absence of intrinsic nature or own-being (svabhāva), not sheer nothingness.
- In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is what is called empty.

□□ The derivation to write for the 2018 question. (i) To possess svabhāva is to exist by one's own nature, independently. (ii) What exists by its own nature does not depend on conditions. (iii) But everything conditioned arises in dependence on conditions. (iv) Therefore nothing conditioned possesses svabhāva. (v) To lack svabhāva is to be empty. (vi) Therefore whatever is dependently arisen is empty. Six steps, each one line — this is the highest-yield derivation in the topic.

2. The four-cornered analysis (catuṣkoṭi)

Corner	Sanskrit	Basic claim
1	asti	It is.
2	nāsti	It is not.
3	asti ca nāsti ca	It both is and is not.
4	naivāsti naiva nāsti	It neither is nor is not.

- Early use. The undeclared (avyākata / avyākṛta) questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.
- Madhyamaka use. Nāgārjuna negates all four alternatives when they are applied to things imagined as possessing svabhāva.
- The early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

3. Why this is not simple contradiction

- Madhyamaka negation is best read as non-implicative negation (prasajya-pratiṣedha), not implicative negation (paryudāsa-pratiṣedha) that asserts a positive alternative.
- The four corners are denied *of things taken as having svabhāva*; once svabhāva* is dropped, the denial does not install a fifth positive thesis.
- Hence Nāgārjuna can claim, in the spirit of the Vigrahavyāvartanī, that he has no independent thesis (pratijñā) of his own.
- This means: "I deny that x has intrinsic nature" is not meant to assert a new metaphysical substrate called emptiness.

□□ The point that separates a good script from an excellent one. The negation is scoped. Every corner is denied under a restriction — "of x taken as self-established". Remove the restriction and the denials would indeed be contradictory. State the restriction explicitly and the charge of irrationalism collapses without further argument.

4. Two truths as the anti-nihilist frame

Truth	Meaning	Exam use
---	---	---

| conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya) | Language, persons, moral consequence, compassion and practice function dependently | Prevents Mādhyamaka from abolishing ordinary discourse |

| ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya) | No dharma possesses svabhāva | Prevents conventional truth from being mistaken for substance |

- ☐ Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.
- ☐ Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions.
- ☐ Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized.
- ☐ The two-truths doctrine keeps the four-cornered analysis from collapsing into nihilism: conventional functioning is preserved, ultimate intrinsic being is denied.

5. Objection and reply

Objection — Nyāya / Uddyotakara-type, and the modern irrationalism charge.

- ☐ If all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.
- ☐ The denial itself is a thesis, so the claim "I have no thesis" is self-refuting.

Reply — Nāgārjuna and later Mādhyamaka.

- ☐ Nāgārjuna's reply is the "my words are empty too" move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore create no positive ontological commitment.
- ☐ The traditional image is that one magically created person (nirmitaka) may counteract another magically created person; similarly, empty words may cure empty reifications.
- ☐ The Mādhyamika uses arguments as medicine, not as a new metaphysical substance.
- ☐ Whether this reply fully succeeds is genuinely debated.
- ☐ The Prāsaṅgika / Svātantrika split marks the debate internally: Candrakīrti is associated with using reductio (prasaṅga) without independent syllogisms, while Bhāvaviveka allows independent (svatantra) inferences in debate. The dispute is developed in the optional block and is not required for a core answer.

6. Emptiness is not nihilism

- ☐ To say things are empty is to say they lack intrinsic nature (svabhāva).
 - ☐ It is not to say they are absent in every sense.
 - ☐ Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, moral consequence and the path are not denied.
 - ☐ Emptiness undercuts metaphysical grasping, not dependent functioning.
- ☐ The strongest positive formulation. Emptiness is the condition of possibility of change, causation and liberation rather than their negation: if things possessed fixed intrinsic natures, nothing could arise, alter or cease, and no bound being could become free. Nāgārjuna's claim is therefore that emptiness makes the Four Noble Truths possible, and that the realist objection has the entailment exactly backwards.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Mādhyamika converts dependent origination into an anti-essentialist conclusion without converting it into nihilism.

Named evidence. Nāgārjuna in substance identifies the dependently arisen with the empty; the four-cornered analysis denies existence, non-existence, both and neither of anything taken as self-established; the Vīṅśatikāvivartaṇī states that the Mādhyamika has no independent thesis and that his own words are empty; and the two truths preserve conventional persons, moral consequence and practice.

Analysis. Because the negation is non-implicative and scoped to things imagined as possessing intrinsic nature, denying all four corners withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting four incompatible propositions; the two truths then locate ordinary discourse at a level the ultimate analysis never addressed, so the doctrine removes an answer without removing a world.

Qualification / link. Whether a non-implicative negation can be sustained without functioning as a covert thesis is genuinely disputed, and the internal Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika division over independent inference shows that the tradition itself did not treat the reply as settled.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Equating emptiness with non-existence. □ It is the absence of intrinsic nature.
2. □ Saying Nāgārjuna rejects logic. □ He uses scoped non-implicative negation.
3. □ Treating emptiness as a hidden absolute. □ Emptiness of emptiness blocks that reading; it is dependent designation.
4. □ Omitting the two truths. □ Without them the answer reads as nihilism.
5. □ Equating emptiness with Advaita Brahman. □ One is anti-substantialist, the other absolute-substantialist.

RAPID REVISION

- Six-step derivation: svabhāva → independence → dependence excludes it → empty.
- Four corners denied under scope; negation is prasajya, not paryudāsa.
- Two truths: saṃvṛti preserves practice; paramārtha denies self-nature.
- "No thesis" + "my words are empty" + nirmittaka simile + snake-wrongly-seized warning.
- Positive formulation: emptiness is the condition of possibility of change and liberation.

SESSION 13 — BUDDHIST MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (pramāṇa): PARTICULARS, PERCEPTION AND EXCLUSION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: the Buddhist logicians argue that there are exactly two ways of knowing because there are exactly two kinds of thing to be known — the particular you bump into, and the general idea you think with.

Technical definition: the Buddhist means-of-knowledge (pramāṇa) school of Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accepts only two independent means of valid knowledge — perception (pratyakṣa) of the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) and inference (anumāna) of the constructed general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa) — defines perception as non-conceptual (kalpanāpoḍha) and non-erroneous (abhrānta), explains word-meaning through exclusion (apoha), and identifies the instrument of knowledge with its result (pramāṇaphala).

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhist epistemology is not logic imported from outside the system: it is no-self and momentariness translated into a theory of knowledge, which is why it must reduce the means of knowing to two, deny real universals, and finally deny the distinction between the instrument of knowledge and its result.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- two means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa): perception and inference
- unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) and general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa)
- non-conceptual (kalpanāpoḍha) and non-erroneous (abhrānta)
- self-awareness of cognition (svasaṃvedana); yogic perception (yogi-pratyakṣa)
- exclusion theory of meaning (apoha); anya-apoha; "cow" = "not-non-cow"
- causal efficacy (arthakriyākāritva); instrument and result (pramāṇa / pramāṇaphala)

How to use them: this session decides the 2025 routed ten-marker on pramāṇa and pramāṇaphala and strengthens every answer on momentariness. Two sentences of epistemology inside a momentariness answer — the criterion of the real and the unique particular — visibly raise its level.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

TWO KINDS OF THING, THEREFORE TWO WAYS OF KNOWING

THE PARTICULAR THE GENERAL

this exact flame-moment "fire" as a repeatable idea
 unrepeatable, momentary stable, shareable, useful
 DOES things (burns you) does nothing by itself
 cannot be captured in words is precisely what words handle
 ||

v v
PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa) INFERENCE (anumāna)
wordless, image-free contact reasoning with concepts

No third kind of object -> no third means of knowledge.

In simple words: Nyāya lists four ways of knowing; Mīmāṃsā lists more. The Buddhist asks a different question: not "how many ways do people gain knowledge?" but "how many kinds of object are there?" Because there are two, there are two — and everything else on other lists is really inference in disguise.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Particular | The real thing; momentary; causally effective; beyond words |

| General | The concept; useful; constructed; causally inert |

| Perception | Grasps the particular, without concepts |

| Inference | Handles the general, entirely with concepts |

One-line memory: count the objects first, and the means of knowing count themselves.

□ □ VISUAL — HOW THE EPISTEMOLOGY IS FORCED BY THE METAPHYSICS

NO PERMANENT SELF (nairātmyavāda) MOMENTARINESS (kṣaṇikavāda)

||
||

no enduring KNOWER the real = the causally efficient

| moment (svalakṣaṇa)

||
v v

pramāṇa cannot be an instrument universals cannot be real, since

used by an agent on an object; they are neither momentary nor

the triad collapses into ONE causally efficient

momentary cognitive event |

| v

v APOHA: generality is built

pramāṇa = pramāṇaphala NEGATIVELY, by exclusion

(instrument is not other than result) "cow" = "not-non-cow"

\\

\\

v v

A COMPLETE EPISTEMOLOGY WITH NO KNOWER, NO UNIVERSAL

AND NO SEPARATE INSTRUMENT — exactly what the ontology required

□ □ Caption. The diagram answers the standard examiner probe: why does Buddhism need its own epistemology at all? Because a system with no self and no enduring thing cannot borrow the Nyāya knower–instrument–object–result architecture. Showing the derivation, rather than listing Buddhist doctrines beside Nyāya doctrines, is what earns the comparison marks in the 2025 question.

1. Two means of valid knowledge

Statement.

- □ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa): perception (pratyakṣa) and inference (anumāna).
- □ Other candidates — comparison (upamāna), postulation (arthāpatti), non-apprehension (anupalabdhi) and testimony (śabda) — are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.

Argument.

1. □ A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.
2. □ There are exactly two object-types: the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) and the general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa).
3. □ Perception grasps the unique particular.
4. □ Inference grasps the general character.
5. □ Therefore there are exactly two means of valid knowledge.

Presupposition.

- ☐ ☐ The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by an inventory of human cognitive habits.
- ☐ ☐ There is no third kind of object beyond the unique causal particular and the constructed general character.

Contrast with Nyāya.

| Issue | ☐ Buddhist pramāṇa school | ☐ Nyāya |

|---|---|---|

| Number of pramāṇas | Two: perception and inference | Four: perception, inference, comparison, testimony |

| Testimony | Reducible to inference from reliable signs and speaker-function | Independent pramāṇa |

| Universals | Conceptual constructions | Real universals inhering in particulars |

2. Unique particular and general character

| Feature | ☐ svalakṣaṇa | ☐ sāmānyalakṣaṇa |

|---|---|---|

| Ontological status | ultimately real (paramārtha-sat) | conventionally real (saṃvṛti-sat) |

| Temporal status | momentary | enduring only as a construct |

| Cognition | non-conceptual perception | conceptual inference and judgement |

| Language | ineffable as a unique particular | expressible and shareable |

| Causal role | causally efficient | causally inert as a universal construct |

- ☐ The unique particular is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.
- ☐ The general character is shareable, expressible and stable only as a conceptual construction.
- ☐ ☐ This is why Buddhist realism about momentary particulars can coexist with nominalism about universals — a combination that looks paradoxical only if one assumes that what is real must be what is expressible.

3. Perception as non-conceptual and non-erroneous

Statement.

- ☐ Dignāga defines perception as non-conceptual (kalpanāpoḍha) — free from conceptual construction.
- ☐ Dharmakīrti adds non-erroneous (abhrānta), so perception is both non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

Why the addition matters.

- ☐ Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.
- ☐ Illusions such as a double moon, or the circle produced by a whirling firebrand, can be vivid while still mistaken.
- ☐ ☐ Dharmakīrti's addition protects Buddhist epistemology from counting every non-conceptual appearance as valid knowledge.

Fourfold division of perception.

| Type | ☐ Meaning | ☐ Philosophical point |

|---|---|---|

| indriya-pratyakṣa | sense perception | non-conceptual contact with the particular through a sense-faculty |

| mānasa-pratyakṣa | mental perception | immediate mental awareness following sensory presentation |

| svasaṃvedana | self-awareness of cognition | cognition manifests itself without a second knower |

| yogi-pratyakṣa | yogic perception | disciplined direct insight into subtle truths relevant to liberation |

- ☐ ☐ Self-awareness (svasaṃvedana) connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism, because cognition is treated as self-revealing. This is precisely why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower into one.

4. The exclusion theory of meaning (apoha)

Statement.

- ☐ Exclusion (apoha) says a general term does not denote a real universal (jāti) inhering in particulars.

- ☐ A word functions through exclusion of the other (anya-apoha): "cow" means "not-non-cow".

Argument.

1. ☐ Only unique particulars are ultimately real.
2. ☐ Words and concepts are general.
3. ☐ If generality were real, one would need real universals; but universals are not perceived and generate the Nyāya problems of inherence and location.
4. ☐ Therefore generality must be constructed negatively, through exclusion.

Presupposition.

- ☐ Apoha presupposes that a negative or differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

Objection — Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara.

- ☐ The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.
- ☐ A merely negative content seems unable to explain the positive determinate cognition "cow".
- ☐ It also seems unable to explain the felt similarity among cows.

Reply — Dharmakīrti's line.

- ☐ Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.
- ☐ Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgement and the same successful practical activity.
- ☐ Apoha is a conceptual construct erected upon that causal convergence, not upon a prior grasp of a real universal.
- ☐ The circularity objection retains residual force; many critics hold that the Buddhist reply does not fully explain positive determination.

5. Causal efficacy as the criterion of the real

Statement.

- ☐ sat = arthakriyā-samartha: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.
- ☐ This criterion ranks the unique particular as ultimately real and the general character as conventional.

Argument connecting epistemology to momentariness.

1. ☐ To be real is to be causally efficacious.
2. ☐ Causal efficacy must occur either successively or simultaneously.
3. ☐ Neither is available to a wholly permanent entity, as shown by the two-horned dilemma.
4. ☐ Therefore whatever is real is momentary — yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

☐ Exam payoff. This is the clean bridge from epistemology to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular, while inference and language manage the conventional general construction.

6. Instrument and result (pramāṇa and pramāṇaphala) — the 2025 routed question

Statement.

- ☐ Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that the means of knowledge (pramāṇa) and its result (pramāṇaphala) are not two ultimately different things.
- ☐ The resultant cognition — the determination of the object together with the self-awareness of cognition — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as the instrument.

Argument.

- ☐ On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent–instrument–result triad.
- ☐ The analysis into instrument (karaṇa) and result (phala) is a conceptual overlay on one momentary cognitive event.
- ☐ This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by no-self and momentariness rather than by free-standing formal logic.

Contrast with Nyāya.

| Factor | ☐ Nyāya | ☐ Buddhist pramāṇa school |

|---|---|---|

| knower (pramātr) | real enduring subject | constructed stream, not an ultimate self |

| instrument (pramāṇa) | a distinct means | non-different from cognition as an event |

| object (prameya) | independently knowable object | ultimately the unique particular; conventionally a constructed object |

| result (pramiti / pramāṇaphala) | distinct resultant knowledge | not ultimately separate from the instrument |

☐ ☐ How to frame the 2025 answer. The debate is not a technical quarrel about definitions. Nyāya needs the fourfold apparatus because it has a real knower who uses a real instrument on a real object and obtains a real result; Buddhism cannot have that apparatus because it has denied the knower and the endurance. The disagreement about pramāṇaphala is therefore a downstream consequence of the disagreement about the self.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. Buddhist epistemology is the translation of no-self and momentariness into a theory of knowledge, and each of its distinctive theses is forced by that translation.

Named evidence. Dignāga and Dharmakīrti admit only perception and inference because there are only two object-types, the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) and the general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa); perception is defined as non-conceptual (kalpanāpoḍha) and, with Dharmakīrti, non-erroneous (abhrānta); word-meaning is explained by exclusion (anya-apoha), so that "cow" functions as "not-non-cow"; and the instrument of knowledge is held to be non-different from its result (pramāṇaphala).

Analysis. Because there is no enduring knower, the Nyāya agent–instrument–object–result architecture has no bearer, and the fourfold analysis must be reduced to a conceptual overlay on a single momentary cognition; because only momentary particulars are causally efficient, universals cannot be real and generality must be built negatively. The system is therefore internally coherent in a way that a mere shortening of the Nyāya list would not be.

Qualification / link. The exclusion theory remains open to the circularity charge pressed by Kumāṇila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara — that excluding non-cows presupposes knowing cows — and Dharmakīrti's appeal to shared causal capacity mitigates without fully dissolving it, so the honest verdict is economy purchased at the cost of an unexplained positive determination.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Saying Buddhist logic is Nyāya logic with fewer pramāṇas. ☐ It rests on momentary particulars, exclusion and no enduring knower.
2. ☐ Omitting abhrānta. ☐ Without it, vivid illusions would count as valid perception.
3. ☐ Treating apoha as a synonym for nominalism. ☐ Its mechanism is exclusion grounded in causal convergence.
4. ☐ Presenting pramāṇaphala as a definitional quibble. ☐ It follows from denying the enduring knower.
5. ☐ Declaring the circularity objection answered. ☐ Report the residual force.

RAPID REVISION

- Two pramāṇas because two object-types: svalakṣaṇa (perception) and sāmānyalakṣaṇa (inference).
- Perception: kalpanāpoḍha + abhrānta; four types including svasaṃvedana and yogi-pratyakṣa.
- Apoha: "cow" = "not-non-cow"; grounded on shared causal capacity, charged with circularity.
- Criterion of the real: sat = arthakriyā-samartha → yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.
- pramāṇa = pramāṇaphala because there is no enduring knower to hold the triad apart.

SESSION 14 — THE UNDECLARED QUESTIONS (avyākṛta), THE CREATOR-GOD CRITIQUE AND THE FOUR-SCHOOL ESCALATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: some questions the Buddha refused to answer — and the refusal is itself a philosophical position, not an evasion.

Technical definition: the undeclared questions (avyākata / avyākṛta) are a set of metaphysical questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected format, on the grounds that they are not conducive to the goal (na arthasaṃhita) and rest on a false presupposition of a substantial self or world; the same refusal of explanatory surplus grounds the Buddhist argument that a creator God is unnecessary.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Buddha's silence is best read as a refusal to let a malformed question dictate the grammar of the answer: every one of the four available replies would concede the substantial self or world that dependent origination has already dissolved, which is why the silence is doctrinally loaded rather than doctrinally empty.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- undeclared questions (avyākata / avyākṛta)
- not conducive to the goal (na arthasaṃhita)
- the arrow parable (Cūḷamālukya teaching)
- fire-going-out simile
- explanatory surplus — the structure of the creator-God critique
- the four-school escalation — realism → representationalism → idealism → emptiness

How to use them: silence is a high-yield enrichment in any answer on the Middle Path, no-self or nirvāṇa, and the creator-God critique is the natural cross-link to Paper II. Both are core supporting depth: valuable, but never at the expense of the printed doctrines.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

A MAN IS SHOT WITH A POISONED ARROW.

The surgeon steps forward. The man says:
"Wait. First tell me the archer's name, caste, village,
the wood of the bow, the feathers of the arrow..."

He dies before the treatment begins.

BUDDHA'S POINT: some questions are not merely hard.
They are the WRONG QUESTIONS FOR A PATIENT.

And some are worse: they assume something that is not there,
like "have you stopped beating your wife?"

In simple words: the silence is not "I don't know". It is "answering that in the form you asked would make you sicker". Two reasons are given: the question does not help, and the question hides a false assumption.

| Remember first | Easy meaning |

|---|---|

| Not conducive | Does not advance liberation; the arrow parable's stated reason |

| Presuppositionally defective | Assumes a substantial self or world that the analysis denies |

| Fire simile | Once fuel ends, directional questions no longer apply |

| Not agnosticism | The Buddha does teach positively — the four truths and the path |

One-line memory: the Buddha refuses the question, not the answer.

□ □ VISUAL — WHY EVERY AVAILABLE ANSWER WOULD BE A TRAP

QUESTION: "Does the Tathāgata exist after death?"

|

+-----+-----+-----+-----+

||||

YES NO BOTH YES/NO NEITHER

||||

v v v v

concedes concedes concedes still concedes

a self a self that a self a self about

that is destroyed with which the
 persists = ucchedavāda opposed predicate is
 = śāśvata- states withheld
 vāda

\ _____ /

|
 ALL FOUR share ONE presupposition:
 that there is a substantial X to be predicated of.

|
 v
 REMOVE THE PRESUPPOSITION -> the question dissolves.
 THIS is what the silence asserts.

□□ Caption. This diagram is also the bridge to Madhyamaka. The four options are the four corners (catuṣkoṭi); the early tradition sets them aside therapeutically, and Nāgārjuna later shows why they must be set aside logically. Writing that sentence connects two parts of the syllabus in one stroke.

1. The undeclared questions

- □ The undeclared (avyākata / avyākṛta) questions are those the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format.
- □ They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the life-principle (jīva) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the Tathāgata exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

AVYĀKRṬA CLUSTER

World: eternal? not eternal? finite? infinite?
 Self / body: is the jīva the same as the body? different from it?
 Tathāgata after death: exists? does not exist? both? neither?

2. Why the Buddha declined

Statement.

- □ The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

Argument.

1. □ The questions are not conducive to the goal (na arthasaṃhita) — not connected with welfare and liberation.
2. □ The arrow parable in the Cūḷamālūkya teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment.
3. □ The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or world of which the alternatives can be predicated.
4. □□ The structure resembles a loaded question, where any direct answer concedes the presupposition.
5. □ Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

Fire-going-out simile.

- □ For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.
- □□ The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

3. Three readings of the silence

Reading	Claim	Strength	Limit
□ Agnostic	The Buddha did not know, or the matter is unknowable	Explains non-answering simply	Fits poorly with the strong positive diagnosis of suffering and cessation
□ Pragmatic-therapeutic	The questions are useless for liberation	Best fits the arrow parable's stated reason	May understate the logical problem in the questions
□□ Logical-semantic	The questions are malformed because their presupposition of a substantial self or world fails	Best fits no-self and dependent origination	Not always explicitly formulated as a semantic theory in early sources

---|---|---|---

□ Agnostic | The Buddha did not know, or the matter is unknowable | Explains non-answering simply | Fits poorly with the strong positive diagnosis of suffering and cessation |

□ Pragmatic-therapeutic | The questions are useless for liberation | Best fits the arrow parable's stated reason | May understate the logical problem in the questions |

□□ Logical-semantic | The questions are malformed because their presupposition of a substantial self or world fails | Best fits no-self and dependent origination | Not always explicitly formulated as a semantic theory in early sources |

- ☐ The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.
- ☐ For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective. That combination is defensible, textually anchored and analytically strong.

Objection and reply.

- ☐ Objection (realist / metaphysical critic). Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.
- ☐ Reply. The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: the Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, the path and cessation. The Middle Path avoids both eternalism and annihilationism, and answering the undeclared questions in any of the four corners would concede the grammar of one of those extremes. ☐ Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is a refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.

4. The creator-God critique — core supporting depth

Core lines of criticism.

- ☐ If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.
- ☐ If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
- ☐ The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- ☐ Dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator explanatorily unnecessary.

Philosophical force.

- ☐ The Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, a creator adds cost without adding explanation.

☐ Placement discipline. This is a cross-paper theme. In a Paper I answer it belongs in one or two evaluative lines; the positive proofs of God and the philosophy-of-religion treatment are owned by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and by Paper II.

5. The internal escalation: how the four schools answer one another

| Stage | ☐ Position claimed | ☐ Becomes the objection for | ☐ Next Buddhist reply |

|---|---|---|---|

| Vaibhāṣika / Sarvāstivāda | Dharmas are real and, in the Sarvāstivāda sense, have existence across past, present and future | Sautrāntika objects that this weakens momentariness and overpopulates the ontology | Only the present moment is fully operative; external objects are inferred through representations |

| Sautrāntika | External objects exist but are known inferentially, not directly | Yogācāra objects that an inferred external object is unnecessary because all that is given is cognition | Representation-only (vijñapti-mātra): objecthood is inseparable from consciousness-appearance |

| Yogācāra | Consciousness-only explains appearance, moral consequence and continuity through store-consciousness | Madhyamaka objects that consciousness is being reified as a subtle substance | Even consciousness lacks intrinsic nature; all dharmas are empty |

| Madhyamaka | Emptiness (śūnyatā) prevents every reification, including the reification of emptiness | Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita object that this risks nihilism or self-refutation | The two truths preserve conventional practice while ultimate analysis denies intrinsic nature |

☐ Exam payoff. For a "Schools of Buddhism" question, do not list four schools mechanically. Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism about dharmas → presentist representationalism → idealist consciousness-only → anti-essentialist emptiness. Each move is generated by an objection that the previous position could not absorb.

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. The Buddha's silence and the Buddhist rejection of a creator are two applications of one methodological principle: refuse explanatory demands that the analysis has already dissolved.

Named evidence. The undeclared questions cover the eternity and finitude of the world, the identity of life-principle and body, and the post-mortem status of the Tathāgata; the arrow parable states that they are not conducive to the goal; the fire-going-out simile shows that directional predication lapses once conditions cease; and dependent origination is said to explain arising without a creator.

Analysis. Because all four available answers to an undeclared question presuppose a substantial subject of predication, the silence is a rejection of the question's grammar rather than an admission of ignorance; the same logic disqualifies a creator, since a cause invoked outside the conditional order adds a term the order did not require and cannot itself be explained by it.

Qualification / link. The tradition does not settle on one interpretation of the silence, and the logical-semantic reading is a reconstruction rather than an explicit early theory, so a careful answer combines the therapeutic and presuppositional readings while acknowledging that the agnostic reading exists and is weaker.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. □ Calling the silence agnosticism. □ It is therapeutic and presuppositional refusal, alongside strong positive teaching.
2. □ Reading the fire simile as a hidden self escaping. □ Directional predication lapses; nothing goes anywhere.
3. □ Treating the four undeclared options as unrelated to the four corners. □ They are the same fourfold structure.
4. □ Turning the creator critique into the main body of a Paper I answer. □ One or two evaluative lines; the topic is owned elsewhere.
5. □ Listing the four schools without the objections that generate them. □ Present the escalation.

RAPID REVISION

- Cluster: world's eternity and finitude · life-principle and body · Tathāgata after death.
- Reasons: not conducive (arrow parable) + false presupposition (loaded-question structure).
- Fire simile: conditions ceased, so directional questions lapse.
- Creator critique = refusal of explanatory surplus; cross-paper placement only.
- Escalation: Vaibhāṣika → Sautrāntika → Yogācāra → Madhyamaka, each driven by an unanswerable objection.

SESSION 15 — NAMED OBJECTIONS, REPLIES, INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING AND THE GRADED VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: this is the session that converts knowledge of Buddhism into marks — the named critics, what each one attacks, the Buddhist answer, and what remains genuinely unresolved.

Technical definition: the critical apparatus consists of five named opponent positions (pūrvapakṣa) — Nyāya on memory, recognition and moral desert; Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa on self and universals; Śaṅkara-type Advaita on the intelligibility of liberation; the Nyāya-realist nihilism charge against emptiness; and the injustice charge against moral consequence without a self — together with the Buddhist established conclusions (siddhānta) and the residual force of each objection.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Buddhism is strongest exactly where it is most often attacked and weakest exactly where it is most often praised: its causal account of bondage and release is philosophically formidable, while its treatment of ownership — of memories, of deserts, of the unity of a single experiencing life — is the point at which every serious rival applies pressure.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- opponent position (pūrvapakṣa) and established conclusion (siddhānta)
- Vātsyāyana · Uddotakara · Udayana (Nyāya); Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa (Mīmāṃsā); Śaṅkara (Advaita)
- recognition (pratyaḥijñā) and moral desert
- residual force — the phrase to use when conceding
- graded verdict — strong / weak / genuinely contested

How to use them: every "critically discuss" and "critically examine" directive is asking for this session. The formula is: doctrine → named objection → Buddhist reply → residual force → qualified verdict.

SIMPLE START — PLAIN-LANGUAGE GATEWAY

FIVE CRITICS, FIVE TARGETS, ONE SHARED COMPLAINT

NYĀYA -> "You cannot remember without a rememberer."
 KUMĀRILA -> "You cannot mean 'cow' without cow-ness."
 ŚAṂKARA -> "You cannot be liberated without someone to be liberated."
 NYĀYA (again) -> "If nothing has a nature, nothing is left."

ALL THREE -> "You cannot deserve without being the same person."

THE SHARED COMPLAINT:

Buddhism removed the OWNER and kept the PROPERTY.

Every critic asks: who does the property now belong to?

In simple words: learn the objections as a family. They are not five unrelated attacks; they are five instances of one question about ownership. Once that is seen, the Buddhist reply is also one reply repeated: ownership is a conventional designation on a causal series.

| Critic | What is attacked | Buddhist device |

|---|---|---|

| Nyāya | memory, recognition, desert | causal continuum, similarity |

| Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa | self and real universals | momentary cognitions, exclusion |

| Śaṅkara-type Advaita | intelligibility of liberation | two truths, self-revealing cognition |

| Nyāya realist | emptiness as nihilism | scoped negation, two truths |

One-line memory: one complaint — the missing owner; one reply — conventional designation on a real series.

□ □ VISUAL — THE GRADED VERDICT AS AN EXAM INSTRUMENT

□ WHAT IS STRONG	□ WHAT IS WEAK	□ WHAT IS CONTESTED
process account of	denial of a persisting	does svasaṃvedana prove
suffering, causation and	subject makes memory,	self-awareness or merely
liberation through	recognition and moral	reify cognition?
dependent origination	desert difficult	
avoids eternalism AND	apoha explains	do Madhyamaka's empty
annihilationism using	universals economically	statements avoid
causal continuity	but not positive	self-refutation?
determination		
momentariness has a	catuṣkoṭi and "no	is a causal series
sharp causal-efficacy	thesis" look unstable	sufficient for MORAL
argument	without the negation	responsibility without
nuance stated	an owner?	
two truths deny intrinsic		
nature without abolishing		
practice		

USE: one item from each column = a complete, balanced conclusion.

□ □ Caption. Treat the three columns as a conclusion-generator. A ten-marker needs one cell; a fifteen-marker needs one from the first two columns; a twenty-marker needs one from each. Conclusions written this way are graded rather than generic, which is exactly what "evaluate" and "critically discuss" reward.

1. Nyāya: memory, recognition and moral desert require a permanent self

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line).

- □ Recognition (pratyabhijñā) — "this is that same jar", "I am the same person who saw before" — appears to disclose identity through time.
- □ Memory seems to require that the subject who remembers be identical with the subject who experienced.
- □ Moral desert seems to require an enduring agent: the doer of an act must be the enjoyer or sufferer of its fruit.

Reply — Buddhist schools.

- □ Causal series (santāna / santati) explains continuity without an identical substance.
- □ Similarity (sādrśya) explains why recognition mistakes a later similar causal phase for the numerically same object.
- □ The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.
- □ Yogācāra adds store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja) as the carrier of karmic and mnemonic potential without accepting a self.

- ☐ ☐ Residual force. A series may explain causal succession, but it is less clear how a series can own memories unless something owns the series.

2. Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Mīmāṃsā: valid knowledge supports self and universals

Objection — Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa.

- ☐ Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.
- ☐ Kumāṛila resists exclusion (apoha) by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals rather than mere exclusion.
- ☐ A merely negative meaning such as "not-non-cow" seems unable to explain the positive cognition "cow".

Reply — Buddhist pramāṇa school.

- ☐ Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.
- ☐ Exclusion explains generality through causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgement and action, so a concept forms without a real universal.
- ☐ ☐ Residual force. Critics argue that the exclusion must already know what to exclude, making the theory circular.

3. Śaṅkara-type Advaita: momentariness and emptiness make liberation unintelligible

Objection — Śaṅkara-type Advaita.

- ☐ If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.
- ☐ If there is no self, the unity of the knower is unintelligible.
- ☐ If emptiness is ultimate, the very denial seems to presuppose a self-luminous witnessing consciousness that makes denial possible.

Reply — Buddhist two-truths response.

- ☐ Liberation does not require an eternal witness; it is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.
- ☐ At conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya), persons, practice and compassion are valid designations.
- ☐ At ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya), neither person nor witness has intrinsic nature.
- ☐ ☐ Residual force. The Advaitin's strongest point is that Buddhist analysis must explain the unity of experience without quietly importing a witness.

4. Nyāya and the realist charge: emptiness collapses into nihilism

Objection.

- ☐ If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.
- ☐ If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.

Reply — Madhyamaka.

- ☐ Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.
- ☐ The two truths preserve conventional causation, moral consequence and path-practice while denying intrinsic nature.
- ☐ Nāgārjuna's "empty words" strategy treats philosophical utterance as therapeutic instrument rather than final ontology.
- ☐ ☐ Residual force. The debate over whether non-implicative negation can avoid becoming a thesis remains open.

5. Moral consequence without a self is unjust

Objection — Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta.

- ☐ If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.
- ☐ If they are strictly different, punishment or reward falls on another.

Reply — Buddhist middle position.

- ☐ Buddhism rejects both strict identity and strict difference.

- ☐ The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.
- ☐ This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.
- ☐ Residual force. Whether causal continuity alone is enough for desert, rather than merely for causal explanation, remains unresolved.

6. Inter-school positioning

School Means of knowledge Ontology of self Permanence and change Causation Universals Liberation
--- --- --- --- --- ---
☐ Buddhism two: perception and inference no permanent self; person is aggregate or stream conditioned reals are momentary dependent origination exclusion (apoha); no real universal cessation of ignorance, craving and the suffering-process
☐ Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika usually four enduring self-substance substances endure through changing qualities production of a new effect (ārambhavāda) real universals knowledge of self and categories; cessation of suffering
☐ Sāṃkhya–Yoga perception, inference, testimony many selves (puruṣa) puruṣa permanent; prakṛti transforms pre-existent effect (satkāryavāda) less central isolation of puruṣa from prakṛti
☐ Jainism multiple standpoint-based approaches real soul (jīva), intrinsically conscious substance persists with changing modes many-sidedness and modal change real common features release of jīva from karmic matter
☐ Mīmāṃsā several, including postulation and non-apprehension enduring self as agent and enjoyer enduring subject and real ritual order ritual efficacy (apūrvā) real universals framed through duty; varies by sub-school
☐ Cārvāka perception alone self identified with the living body elements persist; no rebirth-continuity material causation only rejects metaphysical universals no liberation beyond worldly well-being
☐ Advaita Vedānta six in developed Advaita self is Brahman, self-luminous Brahman permanent; world ultimately mithyā appearance (vivarta) empirical universals within māyā knowledge of Brahman

Buddhism versus Jainism — high-yield distinction.

- ☐ Both are non-Vedic renouncer traditions and both reject a creator God as necessary for liberation.
- ☐ Jainism affirms many-sidedness (anekāntavāda): a substance can be permanent as substance and changing as mode.
- ☐ Buddhism denies substance: apparent persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying substance (dravya).
- ☐ The Jaina soul (jīva) is real and intrinsically omniscient when freed from karmic obstruction; the Buddhist self is a construct designated on the aggregates.
- ☐ Trap: do not say both deny the soul. Buddhism denies ātman; Jainism strongly affirms jīva.

Buddhism versus Advaita — avoid the crypto-Advaita trap.

- ☐ Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.
- ☐ Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous Brahman / ātman.
- ☐ Madhyamaka emptiness is the absence of intrinsic nature, not a hidden substrate.
- ☐ Advaita sublates the world into Brahman; Madhyamaka refuses to replace empty phenomena with a metaphysical ground.
- ☐ Trap to refute: "Buddhist emptiness is just Advaita Brahman under another name." The Buddhist case is anti-substantialist; Advaita is absolute-substantialist.

Cārvāka's rejection of self versus the Buddhist rejection of ātman — the 2024 routed contrast.

- ☐ Cārvāka denies a self beyond the body and moves toward materialist reduction.
- ☐ Buddhism denies a permanent self but does not reduce personhood to the gross body; it analyses the person into aggregates and preserves karmic continuity without substance.
- ☐ Both therefore reject an eternal ātman, but for different reasons and with opposite moral-metaphysical consequences: Cārvāka's denial abolishes rebirth and moral consequence, while Buddhism's denial is designed to preserve them without a bearer.

7. The graded verdict and the answer architecture

What is strong.

- ☐ A powerful process-based account of suffering, causation and liberation through dependent origination.
- ☐ It avoids both eternalism and annihilationism by using causal continuity without an eternal self.
- ☐ Momentariness is supported by a sharp causal-efficacy argument, especially in Dharmakīrti's framework.

- ☐ Madhyamaka's two truths deny intrinsic nature without abolishing ordinary practice.

What is weak.

- ☐ The denial of a persisting subject makes memory, recognition and moral desert philosophically difficult.
- ☐ Exclusion explains universals economically but struggles to account for positive determinate cognition.
- ☐ The four-cornered analysis and the "no thesis" reply look self-referentially unstable unless the non-implicative-negation nuance is clearly stated.

What is genuinely contested.

- ☐ Whether self-awareness (svasaṃvedana) proves the self-revealing character of cognition or merely reifies it.
- ☐ Whether Madhyamaka's empty statements avoid self-refutation.
- ☐ Whether a causal series suffices for moral responsibility without an owner.

Ready one-line verdicts.

- ☐ 10 marks: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process, which makes suffering removable but raises the problem of continuity without a self.
- ☐ 15 marks: Dependent origination, momentariness and no-self form a coherent anti-substantialist system, though Nyāya and Vedānta press hard on memory, agency and liberation.
- ☐ 20 marks: Buddhism is strongest as a therapeutic and causal philosophy of liberation; its deepest unresolved issue is whether causal continuity and two truths can fully replace the work done by self, substance and universals in rival systems.

Answer architecture.

10 MARKS define in one line -> 3-4 crisp argument steps -> one distinction
-> one line of significance

15 MARKS locate the issue in Buddhist soteriology -> doctrine stated precisely
-> argument with one example -> named objection and reply
-> why it matters for suffering and cessation

20 MARKS frame through the Four Noble Truths -> full doctrine with technical vocabulary -> derive the linked claim (e.g. momentariness from dependent origination) -> contrast two schools or answer a major objection -> balanced verdict from the three-column grid

Directive decoder.

| Directive | What is being tested | Structural move | Closing verdict |

|---|---|---|---|

| Discuss | balanced exposition and significance | define → explain argument → add school nuance → conclude | "Thus the doctrine is central because ..." |

| Examine | internal logic and assumptions | state thesis → reconstruct reasoning → expose presupposition | "It stands if its presupposition about ... is accepted." |

| Critically examine / discuss | doctrine plus objections and replies | doctrine → named objection → reply → residual force | "Strong as soteriology, debated as metaphysics." |

| Analyse | components | divide into causation, self, moment, liberation, epistemology | "The components converge on anti-substantialism." |

| Evaluate | final judgement | strengths → weaknesses → contested point → verdict | "Adequate for ..., weaker against ..." |

| Compare / Distinguish | precise separation | table, then one decisive contrast | "Confusing them causes the standard trap." |

| Comment on a quotation | interpret a claim | unpack → support → qualify → conclude | "The claim holds if read as ... not as ..." |

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH — claim → named evidence → analysis → qualification

Claim. The five standing objections to Buddhism are one objection about ownership, and recognising this converts a memorised list of criticisms into a single reusable analytical move.

Named evidence. The Nyāya line of Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Udayana argues from recognition (pratyabhijñā), memory and moral desert; Kumāriḷa Bhaṭṭa argues that word-meaning and duty require a self and real universals; Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that liberation and the unity of the knower are unintelligible without a witness; and the realist nihilism charge argues that emptiness leaves nothing for ethics or knowledge.

Analysis. Each objection takes a function that Buddhism retains — remembering, meaning, being liberated, acting well — and argues that the function requires a bearer Buddhism has removed. The Buddhist reply is correspondingly single: the bearer is a conventional designation on a real causal series, and the demand for an ultimate bearer presupposes the very substance at issue.

Qualification / link. The reply succeeds against the demand for a carrier but only relocates the demand for a subject, so the defensible verdict is that Buddhism is strongest as a causal and therapeutic philosophy and weakest exactly where ownership rather than succession is at stake.

UPSC TRAPS IN THIS SUBTOPIC

1. ☐ Naming "the opponents" without naming individuals. ☐ Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara, Udayana, Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa, Śaṃkara.
2. ☐ Declaring every objection answered. ☐ State residual force; it is the mark of a critical answer.
3. ☐ Saying Buddhism and Jainism both deny the soul. ☐ Jainism affirms jīva emphatically.
4. ☐ Assimilating emptiness to Brahman. ☐ Anti-substantialist versus absolute-substantialist.
5. ☐ Ending with a generic summary. ☐ Use the three-column grid to write a graded verdict.

RAPID REVISION

- Five objections, one complaint: the missing owner.
- Devices: santāna, sādṛśya, ālaya-vijñāna + bīja, two truths, scoped negation.
- Named critics: Vātsyāyana · Uddyotakara · Udayana · Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa · Śaṃkara.
- Verdict grid: strong (process, middle, efficacy argument, two truths) / weak (ownership, positive determination, negation stability) / contested (svasaṃvedana, self-refutation, desert).
- Architecture: 10 = define–argue–distinguish–signify; 15 = locate–state–argue–object–conclude; 20 = frame–expound–derive–contrast–judge.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs — 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed independently, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS — 24 ITEMS

MCQ 1. What the Four Noble Truths are doing

With reference to the Four Noble Truths (catvāri āryasatyāni), consider the following statements.

1. The second truth supplies a causal account of how suffering is produced.
2. The third truth is an independent article of faith unconnected with the second.
3. The fourth truth prescribes the discipline by which the causal chain is interrupted.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: it retains statement 2, which severs cessation from origination, whereas cessation is precisely what follows once a dependently produced effect loses its condition.
- B: Incorrect: keeping statement 2 while dropping statement 1 removes the causal account that alone makes the path in statement 3 intelligible as a therapy.
- C: Correct: the second truth gives the dependent arising of suffering and the fourth gives the discipline that breaks it, which is exactly why the third truth is an entailment rather than a hope.
- D: Incorrect: statements 1 and 3 are sound, but including 2 contradicts them, since the third truth is derived from the conditionality asserted in the second.

Examiner trap 1: Presenting the four truths as a numbered list rather than as one causal circuit read forward and backward loses the analytical marks the directive is actually testing.

MCQ 2. Three denials that must not be merged

Buddhism is classified as unorthodox (nāstika), as non-theistic and as anti-substantialist. These three descriptions respectively rest on its rejection of

- A. Vedic scriptural authority, the explanatory necessity of a creator, and a permanent self behind experience
- B. the moral law of action, the practice of meditation, and the reality of the external world as such
- C. rebirth across lives, the possibility of liberation, and the validity of inference as a means of knowing
- D. renunciation as a way of life, the authority of teachers, and the conventional usefulness of ordinary speech

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the three labels track three distinct denials — of Vedic authority, of a required creator, and of a permanent self — and confusing them produces most classification errors in scripts.
- B: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms moral consequence and meditative discipline, and only some Buddhist schools question the external world, so none of these grounds the three labels.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms rebirth without a soul, affirms liberation as its whole purpose, and accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.
- D: Incorrect: renunciation and teachers are central to the tradition, and conventional speech is expressly preserved under the doctrine of conventional truth.

Examiner trap 2: Translating nāstika as "atheist" collapses the Veda criterion into the creator criterion and makes Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā, which are non-theistic yet Veda-accepting, unclassifiable.

MCQ 3. What the practical Middle Path actually rejects

In its practical sense, the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā) is best described as

- A. a proportionate blend of moderate enjoyment with moderate austerity, adjusted to the temperament of the practitioner
- B. an instruction to suspend judgement between rival philosophical positions until further evidence becomes available
- C. a rule of social conduct that regulates the relations between the monastic community and lay supporters
- D. a distinct disciplined route that rejects both sensual indulgence and self-mortification because neither removes craving

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the middle is not the average of the extremes; it is a third, positively specified training whose test is causal efficacy against craving rather than balance.

- B: Incorrect: suspension of judgement is a sceptical stance, whereas the Middle Path is a definite prescription with eight named factors.
- C: Incorrect: monastic and lay relations belong to disciplinary literature, not to the doctrinal content of the first-sermon framework.
- D: Correct: both extremes are rejected on the same diagnostic ground — indulgence feeds craving while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it — and the replacement is the eightfold training.

Examiner trap 3: Describing the Middle Path as moderation imports an Aristotelian mean and conceals the fact that Buddhism rejects the extremes for failing a causal test, not for being immoderate.

MCQ 4. Grouping the eight factors

The eight factors of the Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga) are classically grouped under three trainings. Right speech, right action and right livelihood belong to

- A. wisdom (prajñā), because each of them presupposes a correct view of conditioned things
- B. ethical discipline (śīla), because each of them regulates outward conduct that renews the conditions of craving
- C. meditative discipline (samādhi), because each of them is practised only during formal periods of sitting
- D. a fourth training of faith, which the tradition adds separately for lay practitioners of the path

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: wisdom covers right view and right intention; conduct factors presuppose wisdom but are not classified under it.
- B: Correct: speech, action and livelihood are the conduct factors, and their function is to stop renewing the conditions in which craving is generated.
- C: Incorrect: meditative discipline covers right effort, right mindfulness and right concentration, none of which is a conduct factor.
- D: Incorrect: the classical grouping is threefold, and no separate training of faith is added to the eightfold scheme.

Examiner trap 4: Listing the eight factors ungrouped reads as recitation; the grouping into wisdom, ethical discipline and meditative discipline is itself the analytical content the examiner is looking for.

MCQ 5. The doctrinal middle

The doctrinal sense of the Middle Path consists in the rejection of

- A. realism about external objects and idealism about consciousness, in favour of a neutral monism of events
- B. inference as an independent means of knowledge and testimony as a derived one, in favour of perception alone
- C. eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), in favour of conditioned continuity without a permanent bearer
- D. asceticism as a monastic ideal and ritual as a lay one, in favour of a purely contemplative discipline

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the realism–idealism dispute divides the four Buddhist schools internally and is not what the doctrinal middle names.
- B: Incorrect: that restriction describes the Cārvāka position on knowledge, whereas Buddhism accepts perception and inference alike.
- C: Correct: dependent origination denies an unchanging bearer without denying causal continuity, which is exactly the middle between the two named extremes.
- D: Incorrect: this restates the practical middle inaccurately and omits the metaphysical pair the doctrinal middle actually rejects.

Examiner trap 5: Treating no-self as a form of annihilationism reverses the doctrine, since annihilationism denies causal continuity while no-self denies only the permanent bearer of it.

MCQ 6. The formula of dependent origination

The standard formula of dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*) is significant for Buddhist soteriology chiefly because

- A. it states positive conditionality and negative conditionality together, so that cessation is built into the principle itself
- B. it identifies a first cause from which the entire series of conditioned phenomena can be shown to proceed
- C. it establishes that every effect pre-exists in its material cause and is merely manifested when conditions mature
- D. it demonstrates that the relation between cause and effect is a matter of habitual expectation rather than of nature

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the four clauses pair presence with arising and absence with cessation, which is why the third Noble Truth follows from the principle rather than being added to it.
- B: Incorrect: the doctrine explicitly declines to identify an absolutely first cause, and the wheel image encodes that refusal.
- C: Incorrect: the pre-existence of the effect in the cause is the Sāṃkhya thesis of *satkāryavāda*, which Buddhism does not hold.
- D: Incorrect: reducing causation to habitual expectation is a Humean position, whereas Buddhism treats conditionality as law-like and objective.

Examiner trap 6: Quoting only the arising half of the formula silently discards the cessation half, which is precisely the half that makes dependent origination a doctrine of liberation.

MCQ 7. The three marks and their scope

With reference to the three marks (*trilakṣaṇa*; Pali: *tilakkhaṇa*), consider the following statements.

1. Impermanence and unsatisfactoriness are standardly predicated of conditioned formations.
2. The mark of no-self is applied more widely than the other two.
3. Impermanence in the early teaching is verbally identical with the later thesis of momentariness.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: statement 3 erases the distinction between the early teaching of impermanence and the stronger scholastic thesis of one-moment duration.
- B: Correct: the standard formula restricts the first two marks to conditioned formations while applying not-self more widely, which is why the unconditioned status of cessation is not thereby contradicted.
- C: Incorrect: it keeps the false identification in statement 3 and drops the accurate scope claim in statement 1.
- D: Incorrect: statements 1 and 2 are correct, but statement 3 conflates an early teaching with a later radicalisation of it.

Examiner trap 7: Inferring from universal impermanence that cessation of conditioned suffering must itself be one more momentary event ignores its classification as unconditioned in important Buddhist traditions.

MCQ 8. The order of the chain

In the twelve-link sequence (dvādaśa-nidāna), the correct order of the links immediately following name-and-form (nāma-rūpa) is

- A. contact, six sense-bases, craving, feeling
- B. feeling, contact, six sense-bases, craving
- C. six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving
- D. craving, feeling, six sense-bases, contact

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: contact presupposes the sense-bases through which it occurs, so it cannot precede them, and feeling cannot follow craving.
- B: Incorrect: feeling arises from contact and cannot precede it, which reverses the very junction at which the path intervenes.
- C: Correct: name-and-form conditions the six sense-bases, which condition contact, which conditions feeling, which conditions craving.
- D: Incorrect: this inverts the whole segment and would make craving prior to the sensory conditions that generate it.

Examiner trap 8: Reversing feeling and craving destroys the doctrine's practical bite, because the entire discipline of mindfulness is located precisely in the gap between them.

MCQ 9. Why the chain is not fatalism

Buddhists deny that the twelve-link chain entails fatalism primarily because

- A. the links classified as present causes remain open to alteration, so present practice changes what is subsequently produced
- B. the sequence describes only the experience of unenlightened persons and does not apply to disciplined practitioners
- C. every link may be broken at any point by an act of divine grace conferred independently of the practitioner's effort
- D. the chain is a purely symbolic representation with no claim to describe the actual conditions of rebirth or suffering

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: on the three-life arrangement the past causes and present results are already produced, while craving, clinging and becoming remain open, which is where discipline operates.
- B: Incorrect: the chain describes the general conditions of cyclic existence, and a practitioner is precisely someone working within it rather than exempt from it.
- C: Incorrect: grace conferred by a deity has no place in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- D: Incorrect: treating the chain as merely symbolic would remove the causal claim that makes cessation possible at all.

Examiner trap 9: Presenting only the three-life reading suggests a fixed chronology; adding the present-process reading is what shows the chain to be immediately practical.

MCQ 10. The criterion behind momentariness

The Buddhist thesis yat sat tat kṣaṇikam is grounded on the prior claim that

- A. whatever is perceived by the senses must be composed of parts and is therefore liable to decomposition

- B. whatever is described by a general term must be a conceptual construction rather than an ultimately real entity
- C. whatever is denied by the opponent must be affirmed by the proponent if the debate is to remain intelligible
- D. whatever is real is capable of producing an effect, so that reality is identified with causal efficacy

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a different argument and would not by itself yield the strict one-moment thesis.
- B: Incorrect: this states the exclusion theory of meaning, which concerns universals rather than the temporal duration of the real.
- C: Incorrect: this is a debating convention and has no role in establishing an ontological thesis.
- D: Correct: the equation of the real with what is capable of an effect is the premise from which the two-horned dilemma against permanence is launched.

Examiner trap 10: Deriving momentariness directly from dependent origination skips the causal-efficacy premise and leaves the derivation demanded by the 2020 question logically incomplete.

MCQ 11. The two horns

In the Buddhist argument against a permanent efficient cause, the horn of simultaneity (yaugapadya) presses the objection that

- A. a permanent entity would be unable to enter into any relation with the auxiliary conditions that surround it
- B. a permanent entity would have to be perceived as enduring, whereas perception presents only momentary phases
- C. a permanent entity producing its whole effect at once leaves nothing available for later production
- D. a permanent entity would require a second permanent entity to destroy it when its function is complete

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the inability to relate is not asserted; the argument concedes auxiliaries and then shows that admitting them is fatal in a different way.
- B: Incorrect: the argument is inferential rather than perceptual, since no one claims to perceive momentary phases directly.
- C: Correct: if the complete power operates at once, later production has no remaining ground, which is exactly the simultaneity horn.
- D: Incorrect: this states the separate argument from destruction, which denies that perishing needs an external destroyer.

Examiner trap 11: Presenting momentariness as directly observed misrepresents an argument that works by eliminating the permanent alternative rather than by reporting an experience.

MCQ 12. Closing the Nyāya escape route

Nyāya replies that a permanent substance acts only when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present. The Buddhist counter-dilemma is that

- A. either the permanent thing already possesses the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing redundant
- B. auxiliary conditions are themselves permanent, so the reply merely postpones the original difficulty by one step
- C. auxiliary conditions cannot be perceived, so their postulation violates the Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge
- D. auxiliary conditions belong to the category of quality, which cannot be causally responsible for the production of a substance

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma exhausts the alternatives, leaving the permanent entity either unnecessary or altered by acquiring a power it lacked.
- B: Incorrect: Nyāya does not claim that auxiliaries are permanent, so the reply misses the actual position it is attacking.
- C: Incorrect: auxiliaries are ordinary observable conditions, so no epistemological restriction is violated by admitting them.
- D: Incorrect: this borrows Vaiśeṣika category language and does not correspond to any step of the Buddhist argument.

Examiner trap 12: Omitting the auxiliary-conditions reply and its closure leaves the momentariness argument looking like an assertion, because the dilemma is the point at which the realist alternative is actually eliminated.

MCQ 13. How continuity survives momentariness

Under momentariness, the appearance of an enduring object is explained by

- A. an underlying substance that persists while its qualities are successively replaced by similar qualities
- B. an act of divine sustenance that maintains resemblance between successive states of the world
- C. a permanent witnessing consciousness before which the succession of states is continuously displayed
- D. a causal series (santāna) whose successive members are sufficiently similar to be treated as one thing

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: an underlying persisting substance is precisely the Nyāya position the Buddhist argument has just eliminated.
- B: Incorrect: divine sustenance is unavailable in a system that treats a creator as explanatorily unnecessary.
- C: Incorrect: a permanent witness is the Advaitic device, and importing it would abandon no-self altogether.
- D: Correct: continuity is carried by causal succession plus similarity, which is what the flame and stream illustrations are used to convey.

Examiner trap 13: Explaining continuity by quietly reintroducing a subtle self converts the Buddhist answer into the position it was designed to refute; the device is always the series, never a bearer.

MCQ 14. The exhaustive analysis of the person

The philosophical force of the five-aggregate (pañca-skandha) analysis lies in the fact that

- A. the enumeration is claimed to be exhaustive, so that failure to find a sixth item is failure to find a self
- B. each aggregate is shown to be permanent in substance while impermanent in its successive modes
- C. the aggregates are ranked hierarchically, with consciousness serving as the owner of the remaining four
- D. the analysis is presented as a provisional teaching device that a more advanced practitioner may discard

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the doctrine stands or falls on exhaustiveness, since a further category would restore the very owner the analysis claims cannot be found.
- B: Incorrect: permanence of substance with changing modes is the Jaina definition of the real, which Buddhism explicitly rejects.
- C: Incorrect: consciousness is one aggregate among five and is examined and found not-self along with the others.
- D: Incorrect: the analysis is doctrinally central rather than provisional, and it is the standard route to the printed no-self thesis.

Examiner trap 14: Defining no-self without enumerating the aggregates removes the argument and leaves only the conclusion, which is why such answers read as assertion rather than demonstration.

MCQ 15. What the chariot analogy establishes

In the chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha, the philosophical point is that

- A. the chariot is wholly unreal, so that anyone who uses the word is making a straightforward factual mistake
- B. the chariot is identical with the sum of its parts arranged in a heap, so that the arrangement contributes nothing
- C. the term functions correctly as a designation without naming any further entity beyond the parts and their arrangement
- D. the chariot possesses a distinct nature that emerges from the parts and thereafter exists independently of them

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the analogy preserves ordinary usage, since the chariot can still be driven, purchased and repaired.
- B: Incorrect: a mere heap is expressly denied to be a chariot, which is why arrangement and function are part of the account.
- C: Correct: the analogy makes a semantic point — a term can be true without being referential to an additional item — and that is what protects the conventional person.
- D: Incorrect: an emergent independent nature would be a svabhāva, which the analogy is designed to exclude.

Examiner trap 15: Using the chariot to prove that the person is unreal overshoots the analogy and invites the charge that Buddhism cannot account for practice, ethics or refuge.

MCQ 16. Two no-selves, precisely distinguished

Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) and phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) are related as follows.

- A. Both are equally emphasised by every Buddhist school, so the distinction has only terminological significance
- B. The first denies the reality of external objects while the second denies the reality of internal mental states
- C. The first is a Mahāyāna innovation while the second belongs to the earliest strata of Buddhist teaching
- D. The first denies an enduring person, while the second extends the denial to intrinsic nature in the constituent factors

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: realist Abhidharma schools accept the first while treating dharmas as ultimately real, so the distinction is substantive.
- B: Incorrect: the division is not between outer and inner but between the owner and the inventory on which the owner was denied.
- C: Incorrect: the order is reversed, since personal no-self is the shared minimum thesis and the extension to dharmas is developed emphatically in Mahāyāna.
- D: Correct: the second applies the same analytic pressure to the factors themselves, which is why it is stressed most strongly by Mādhyamika.

Examiner trap 16: Treating the two theses as equivalent erases exactly the difference of scope that the 2021 question was framed to test.

MCQ 17. Moral consequence without a permanent self

The Buddhist formula that the later stage is "neither the same nor another" (na sa eva na cānyaḥ) is philosophically necessary because

- A. strict identity would preserve responsibility while strict difference would preserve impermanence, so both must be affirmed together
- B. strict identity would reinstate eternalism while strict difference would make the fruit fall on an unrelated recipient
- C. strict identity is asserted at the conventional level while strict difference is asserted at the ultimate level
- D. strict identity is a Nyāya doctrine while strict difference is a Sāṃkhya doctrine, so both must be rejected as non-Buddhist

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: affirming both together would be straightforwardly contradictory, whereas the formula denies both in favour of causal continuity.
- B: Correct: the formula is a middle precisely because each extreme destroys one of the things Buddhism wishes to keep — impermanence on one side, responsibility on the other.
- C: Incorrect: the two-truths distinction is not used to distribute identity and difference across levels in this way.
- D: Incorrect: the rejection is argued from internal consequences, not from the schools that happen to hold the positions.

Examiner trap 17: Locating moral quality in outward action rather than in intention (*cetanā*) removes the aggregate in which Buddhism actually places moral responsibility.

MCQ 18. What cessation of conditioned suffering is

Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*; Pali: *nibbāna*) is most accurately described as

- A. the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering
- B. the attainment by the liberated self of a permanent state of undisturbed bliss in a region beyond the world
- C. the complete annihilation of the individual, understood as the destruction of a substance that formerly existed
- D. the merging of individual consciousness into a universal consciousness from which it had been temporarily separated

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the three fires are what is extinguished, and what ceases is the conditioned production of suffering rather than an entity.
- B: Incorrect: this reinstates both the self and a place, each of which the doctrine expressly declines to posit.
- C: Incorrect: annihilation presupposes a substance to annihilate, and no such substance was ever admitted.
- D: Incorrect: merging into a universal consciousness is an Advaitic formulation and is precisely the crypto-Advaita reading the tradition resists.

Examiner trap 18: Treating the classification of *nirvāṇa* as unconditioned (*asaṃskṛta*) as evidence for an eternal self confuses being outside the dependent series with being a substance.

MCQ 19. The internal relation of the Three Jewels

In the Buddhist account of the Three Jewels (*Triratna*), the internal relation among Buddha, Dharma and Saṅgha is best stated as

- A. three independent objects of devotion, each sufficient on its own to secure liberation for the practitioner
- B. a hierarchy in which the community confers authority on the teaching and the teaching confers authority on the teacher
- C. a symbolic triad with no doctrinal content, retained only because the formula of refuge is ritually convenient
- D. a functional triad in which the teacher discovered the path, the teaching liberates, and the community preserves and transmits it

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the three are interdependent in function, and treating each as independently sufficient misstates the structure of refuge.
- B: Incorrect: the direction of origin runs from the teacher through the teaching to the community, even though access today runs the other way.
- C: Incorrect: the triad carries substantive doctrinal content, since what liberates is identified as the teaching rather than as devotion to a person.
- D: Correct: this states both the origin relation and the transmission relation, which is exactly what a question on internal relation is asking for.

Examiner trap 19: Arguing that refuge presupposes a soul misses the reply that the refuge-taker is the conventional designated person, which is all that being conditioned by instruction requires.

MCQ 20. Vaibhāṣika realism and its cost

The Vaibhāṣika affirmation that dharmas of the past, present and future have some mode of existence is best explained as

- A. an acceptance of an eternal substance underlying the momentary states in which it successively appears
- B. a device required to keep past acts able to bear future fruit and to give every cognition a genuine object
- C. a concession to Mahāyāna criticism that the momentary ontology of the earlier schools was too austere
- D. an inference from the impossibility of partless atoms combining to form perceptible gross objects

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: no eternal substance is admitted; what is claimed is a mode of existence for dharmas across the three times.
- B: Correct: both the karmic relation and the cognitive relation need two relata, and extending existence across the three times is how Vaibhāṣika supplies them.
- C: Incorrect: the thesis belongs to the Sarvāstivāda tradition on its own account and is not a response to Mahāyāna pressure.
- D: Incorrect: the atom argument is a Yogācāra weapon against external realism and does not support the three-times thesis.

Examiner trap 20: Reading sarvam asti as eternalism ignores the further Vaibhāṣika claim that only present dharmas possess the distinctive present efficacy.

MCQ 21. The Sautrāntika argument

Sautrāntika concludes that external objects are known only inferentially because

- A. the senses are unreliable instruments whose deliverances must always be corrected by scriptural testimony
- B. external objects are ultimately unreal, so any cognition of them must be a construction of the mind alone
- C. universals cannot be perceived, and therefore no cognition of a general object can ever be perceptual
- D. the object-moment has already ceased when the cognition it caused arises, so cognition can only bear its form

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: scriptural correction of the senses plays no part in the argument, which turns entirely on momentariness and causal order.
- B: Incorrect: Sautrāntika is a realist school that affirms external objects and disputes only the mode of access to them.

- C: Incorrect: this concerns universals rather than external particulars and belongs to the theory of exclusion.
- D: Correct: momentariness plus the requirement that a cause precede its effect yields a time-gap, so cognition presents a form from which the object is inferred.

Examiner trap 21: Classifying Sautrāntika as sceptical about the external world confuses a claim about access with a claim about existence and destroys its role as the realist half of the 2024 contrast.

MCQ 22. How Yogācāra argues against external realism

Consider the following Yogācāra arguments against external realism.

1. The dream argument, which shows that a complete world-appearance needs no external correlate.
2. The atom critique, which shows that partless atoms cannot combine while composite ones are not ultimate.
3. The time-gap argument, which shows that the inferred external object performs no explanatory work.

Which of the above arguments does Yogācāra employ?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: it omits the time-gap argument, which is the argument Yogācāra takes over from Sautrāntika and turns against it.
- B: Incorrect: it omits the dream argument, which is the school's best-known move and the one that removes the evidential basis of realism.
- C: Correct: all three are used, and they divide labour by attacking realism's evidence, its coherence and its explanatory role respectively.
- D: Incorrect: it omits the atom critique, which is the argument directed specifically at the realist account of gross objects.

Examiner trap 22: Giving only the dream argument leaves the position looking like an appeal to a single analogy, whereas the strength of the school lies in the convergence of three independent lines.

MCQ 23. The three natures

In Yogācāra, the imagined (*parikalpita*), dependent (*paratantra*) and perfected (*pariṇiṣpanna*) natures are best understood as

- A. three descriptions of one dependent flow — as falsely taken, as actually running, and as truly seen
- B. three distinct realities arranged in ascending order, the lowest being annihilated when the highest is realised
- C. three stages of meditative attainment, corresponding to concentration, insight and final absorption
- D. three types of cognition, corresponding respectively to perception, inference and testimony

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the three natures describe the same flow under a superimposed duality, in its actual conditioned running, and as realised free of that superimposition.
- B: Incorrect: treating them as three entities multiplies realities and invites the objection that Yogācāra abandons its own economy.
- C: Incorrect: they are an analysis of how objectification arises and is removed, not a graded ladder of meditative states.

- D: Incorrect: the Buddhist means-of-knowledge school admits only two means, and the three natures are not a classification of them.

Examiner trap 23: Presenting the three natures as three worlds makes liberation look like the acquisition of a new object rather than the withdrawal of a superimposition.

MCQ 24. From dependence to emptiness

The Mādhyamika derivation of emptiness (śūnyatā) from dependent origination turns on the premise that

- A. whatever is composite must eventually decompose, so that no composite thing can be counted as ultimately real
- B. whatever possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva) would exist through itself and would therefore not depend on conditions
- C. whatever is cognised must be identical with the cognition of it, so that no object stands outside awareness
- D. whatever is expressed by a word must be a construction, so that only the ineffable particular can be ultimately real

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: decomposition of composites is a weaker argument and would not touch simples, which the emptiness thesis also covers.
- B: Correct: independence is built into the very concept of intrinsic nature, so dependence excludes it and emptiness follows immediately.
- C: Incorrect: the identity of object and cognition is a Yogācāra thesis that Mādhyamika criticises as a further reification.
- D: Incorrect: this states the Buddhist theory of the unique particular and belongs to epistemology rather than to the emptiness derivation.

Examiner trap 24: Omitting the two truths from an emptiness answer makes the doctrine read as nihilism, which is exactly the misreading Nāgārjuna warns against with the image of the wrongly seized snake.

REMEDIAL DRILLS — 8 ERROR-TARGETING ITEMS

MCQ 25. The label that is not a name

Which of the following statements about Buddhist tradition-labels is accurate?

- A. Theravāda, Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are three names for a single school opposed to a uniform Mahāyāna system
- B. "Hīnayāna" was the shared self-designation of the early schools before Mahāyāna adopted a different name
- C. Vaibhāṣika and Yogācāra are Theravāda formations, while Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna formations
- D. Theravāda is one surviving school with the Pali canon, while Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika belong to the Sarvāstivāda world

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the three are distinct, with different canons and doctrines, and Mahāyāna is itself internally diverse rather than uniform.
- B: Incorrect: the label was applied by Mahāyāna authors to disciple-vehicle traditions and was not adopted by them as a self-description.
- C: Incorrect: it scrambles the placements, since Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are non-Mahāyāna while Yogācāra and Mādhyamika are Mahāyāna.
- D: Correct: this states the placements accurately and keeps the Pali canonical tradition distinct from the Sanskrit, Chinese and Tibetan transmission of Sarvāstivāda material.

Examiner trap 25: Writing "Hīnayāna (Theravāda)" repeats a polemical classification as though it were a neutral synonym and simultaneously misplaces two of the four philosophical schools.

MCQ 26. Store-consciousness is not a self

Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) differs from the self (ātman) rejected by Buddhism because it is

- A. imperceptible to ordinary cognition and therefore knowable only through the testimony of an authoritative teacher
- B. a conditioned and continually transforming stream that carries seeds rather than an unchanging substantial owner
- C. shared among all sentient beings as a single cosmic reservoir in which individual experience is temporarily located
- D. confined to the present life and destroyed at death, so that it cannot support rebirth or moral consequence

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the difference is ontological rather than epistemic, and testimony is not an independent means of knowledge in this school.
- B: Correct: being conditioned and transforming is precisely what distinguishes it from a permanent bearer, which is why it does not violate no-self.
- C: Incorrect: a single cosmic reservoir would be closer to an absolute consciousness and would abandon the school's anti-substantialism.
- D: Incorrect: it is invoked precisely to explain continuity across death, which a stream destroyed at death could not do.

Examiner trap 26: Calling store-consciousness a Buddhist soul concedes the Madhyamaka objection that Yogācāra reifies consciousness, without noticing that Yogācāra itself insists on its conditioned character.

MCQ 27. Emptiness and nihilism

The doctrine of two truths is indispensable to Madhyamaka because it

- A. preserves persons, causation, moral consequence and practice at the conventional level while denying intrinsic nature at the ultimate level
- B. establishes that conventional truth is simply false and must be abandoned once ultimate truth has been realised by the practitioner
- C. demonstrates that ultimate truth is a higher reality behind appearances, into which empty phenomena are finally resolved
- D. proves that the two levels contradict each other, which is why Madhyamaka is willing to abandon the law of non-contradiction

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- A: Correct: the conventional level is where practice, ethics and language operate, and preserving it is exactly what blocks the nihilist reading.
- B: Incorrect: conventional truth is not mere falsehood but the operative domain of Buddhist discipline itself.
- C: Incorrect: positing a higher reality behind appearances would install the substrate that emptiness of emptiness is designed to prevent.
- D: Incorrect: Madhyamaka does not abandon non-contradiction; its negations are scoped to things taken as self-established.

Examiner trap 27: Equating emptiness with Advaita Brahman converts an anti-substantialist doctrine into an absolute-substantialist one and reverses its central claim.

MCQ 28. The type of negation

Madhyamaka denial of all four corners of the catuṣkoṭi avoids contradiction because the negation employed is

- A. implicative (paryudāsa-pratiṣedha), so that denying each corner asserts the remaining alternatives in turn
- B. merely rhetorical, so that the denials are not intended as claims and carry no philosophical commitment at all
- C. non-implicative (prasajya-pratiṣedha) and scoped to things taken as possessing intrinsic nature, so no fifth thesis is installed
- D. provisional, so that the denials are withdrawn once the opponent has been silenced in the course of debate

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: implicative negation would indeed assert alternatives and would make the fourfold denial self-contradictory.
- B: Incorrect: the denials are genuine philosophical claims about the incoherence of intrinsic nature, not debating rhetoric.
- C: Correct: the negation withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting an alternative, and the scope restriction is what makes this coherent.
- D: Incorrect: the denials are not withdrawn, and the "no thesis" claim is defended precisely as a stable position.

Examiner trap 28: Writing that Nāgārjuna rejects logic mistakes a scoped non-implicative negation for irrationalism and forfeits the reply to the self-refutation charge.

MCQ 29. Buddhist means of knowledge

The Buddhist restriction to two means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is argued from

- A. the practical observation that comparison and testimony rarely yield certainty in ordinary human affairs
- B. the claim that the number of means of knowing is fixed by the number of kinds of object there are to be known
- C. the scriptural authority of the Buddha, whose word settles disputes about the correct enumeration of knowledge-sources
- D. the impossibility of establishing invariable concomitance, which restricts valid knowledge to immediate perception

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the argument is not statistical or practical but structural, resting on a division of possible objects.
- B: Correct: there are held to be exactly two object-types, the unique particular and the constructed general character, so exactly two means correspond to them.
- C: Incorrect: the school argues the point philosophically and does not treat testimony as an independent authoritative means.
- D: Incorrect: denying invariable concomitance and restricting knowledge to perception is the Cārvāka position, not the Buddhist one.

Examiner trap 29: Describing Buddhist logic as Nyāya logic with a shorter list ignores that it rests on momentary particulars, exclusion and the denial of an enduring knower.

MCQ 30. Exclusion and its critics

The objection that the exclusion theory of meaning (apoha) is circular holds that

- A. exclusion cannot apply to negative terms, since there is no positive class from which the exclusion could be made
- B. exclusion presupposes momentariness, which has not itself been established independently of the theory of meaning
- C. excluding non-cows presupposes already knowing what a cow is, so the account assumes what it set out to explain
- D. exclusion applies only to words and not to concepts, so it cannot explain the generality present in thought itself

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: negative terms are not the difficulty raised by Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara against the theory.
- B: Incorrect: momentariness is argued independently through causal efficacy and is not the target of the circularity charge.
- C: Correct: this is the standard charge, and Dharmakīrti's reply appeals to shared causal capacity rather than to a prior grasp of a universal.
- D: Incorrect: the theory is expressly about conceptual generality as well as about words, so the restriction is not one it accepts.

Examiner trap 30: Declaring the circularity objection dissolved overstates the reply, since many critics hold that causal convergence explains classification without explaining positive determinate cognition.

MCQ 31. Reading the silence

The most defensible reading of the Buddha's refusal to answer the undeclared (avyākṛta) questions is that

- A. he lacked the relevant knowledge, which is why the tradition preserves the questions without preserving answers
- B. the questions were reserved for advanced disciples and were answered privately outside the public discourses
- C. the questions were philosophically trivial and were dismissed because they had no bearing on any doctrine
- D. the questions are both unconvincing to liberation and defective in presupposing a substantial self or world

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: the agnostic reading fits poorly with the strong positive teaching of suffering, its origin, its cessation and the path.
- B: Incorrect: no doctrine of a private answer is offered, and the arrow parable gives a stated reason for the refusal itself.
- C: Incorrect: the questions are treated as seriously misleading rather than trivial, since answering them would concede an extreme.
- D: Correct: combining the therapeutic reason given in the arrow parable with the presuppositional defect is the reading best supported by the sources and by no-self.

Examiner trap 31: Reading the fire-going-out simile as a hidden self departing in some direction inverts its point, which is that directional predication lapses once the sustaining conditions cease.

MCQ 32. The comparison most often written wrongly

In comparing Buddhism with Jainism, which of the following is accurate?

- A. Both deny the soul, but Jainism explains continuity by karmic matter while Buddhism explains it by a causal series
- B. Both reject a creator God, but Jainism affirms a real conscious soul while Buddhism denies any permanent self
- C. Both affirm a permanent self, but Jainism treats it as omniscient while Buddhism treats it as momentary in nature
- D. Both accept Vedic authority, but Jainism restricts it to ethics while Buddhism restricts it to meditative practice

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- A: Incorrect: its first clause is false, since Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, even though its account of karmic matter is correctly described.
- B: Correct: the shared rejection of a creator is genuine, and the decisive contrast is that the Jaina jīva is real and intrinsically conscious while Buddhism denies any such substance.
- C: Incorrect: Buddhism affirms no permanent self at all, so the shared premise of the option is false.

- D: Incorrect: both traditions are classified as unorthodox precisely because they reject Vedic authority.

Examiner trap 32: Saying that Buddhism and Jainism both deny the soul is the single most frequently penalised comparison error in the topic, because it erases the pluralist realism that defines Jainism.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Current canonical primary sequence

Verified wording and status. The fourteen numbered questions below are the complete Buddhism-primary sequence for 2018–2026. Wording and marks follow the verified ledgers exactly. Every model is independent learner practice, not an official UPSC key.

Ownership. Primary numbering is reserved for Buddhism-owned questions. Three cross-owner questions are preserved separately as Supporting S1–S3 and are not counted among the fourteen primary questions.

Word bands used. 10 marks: 150–200 words. 15 marks: 250–300 words. 20 marks: 340–400 words.

FOURTEEN PRIMARY BUDDHISM PYQS — COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Primary PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoded. The hinge word is "apply". The examiner wants a derivation, not two definitions placed side by side. Show that emptiness is extracted from dependent origination, and protect the conclusion from nihilism.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

For Mādhyamika, dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) means that whatever arises does so only in dependence on causes, conditions, parts and conceptual designation. Nāgārjuna converts this causal principle into an ontological one in six steps.

To possess intrinsic nature (svabhāva) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; but everything conditioned arises in dependence on conditions; therefore nothing conditioned possesses intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty; therefore whatever is dependently arisen is empty (śūnya). Nāgārjuna accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty.

Emptiness is therefore not non-being. A chariot, a flame or a person functions perfectly well while being undiscoverable as a self-grounded substance. The two truths secure this: at conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya) persons, moral consequence and compassion operate; at ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya) no dharma has own-being. Even emptiness is empty, being itself a dependent designation rather than a hidden absolute.

The application is thus strict: dependence excludes independence, and emptiness names exactly that exclusion.

Why this earns marks. It gives the derivation as a numbered inference rather than as an assertion, defines svabhāva instead of leaving emptiness as a slogan, and closes the nihilism exit with the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

Primary PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoded. "Give reasons in favour" fixes the verdict direction: argue for consistency. But a bare defence scores less than a defence that first shows why the objection seems compelling and then dissolves it.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The objection has real force. If no permanent self exists, it seems there is no one to be bound, no one to practise and no one to be liberated; and if everything is momentary, nothing survives to enjoy liberation. Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya both press this.

The Buddhist reply begins by exposing a presupposition. The question "who attains nirvāṇa?" already assumes the substantial claimant whose removal is the liberation. Cessation of conditioned suffering is not a possession acquired by an owner; it is the extinction of attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and delusion (moha), and therefore the ceasing of the process that manufactures suffering.

Once this is seen, no permanent self (nairātmyavāda) is not an obstacle to liberation but its condition. Ignorance superimposes "I" and "mine" on the five aggregates; that appropriation generates craving, clinging and renewed becoming. Insight into no-self removes the cognitive basis of appropriation, and the chain loses its fuel. Momentariness supplies the complementary explanation: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition, whereas a permanent bondage would be permanent.

Continuity of practice is preserved by the causal continuum (santāna). The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream, exactly as one lamp lights another. Theravāda classifications treat nibbāna as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) without making it the state of an eternal self; Nāgārjuna adds that saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms.

One pressure survives: the first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream. That is a cost, not a contradiction — so the two doctrines are consistent, and mutually required.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection at full strength, answers by exposing a presupposition rather than by defending, shows that the doctrines are mutually supporting rather than merely compatible, and ends with a qualified verdict that matches the directive.

Primary PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoded. "How" asks for arguments, not for a translation of vijñaptimātra. Three distinct arguments plus one sentence protecting the school from solipsism is a complete answer at this length.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Yogācāra advances representation-only (vijñaptimātra): what is given is cognition-as-presentation, not an independently established object. Three arguments support the denial and divide labour.

The dream argument removes realism's evidence: a dream supplies depth, objects and an apparent perceiver without any external correlate, so the mere fact that experience appears outer cannot prove an outer cause. The atom critique removes its coherence: partless atoms have no sides with which to combine, while atoms with parts are not ultimate, so the realist account of gross objects is unstable. The time-gap argument, taken from Sautrāntika and pressed further, removes its explanatory role: since object and cognition are momentary, the object has already ceased when its cognition arises, leaving only its form — so the inferred external cause does no work.

Order is then explained internally. Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carries karmic seeds (bīja) whose maturation produces regular, shared experience; the world is intersubjective because karmically co-conditioned, not because one ego invents it.

The denial is therefore of independent establishment, not of causal order.

Why this earns marks. It supplies three arguments with distinct functions instead of one analogy, names the store-consciousness mechanism that keeps the position from collapsing into solipsism, and states the thesis in its defensible form.

Primary PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Demand decoded. Two explicit demands: define, then derive. The derivation is where marks are won or lost, because dependence alone yields impermanence and not strict momentariness.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is the principle that whatever arises, arises in dependence on causes and conditions, and ceases when those conditions cease: this being, that becomes; from the cessation of this, that ceases. Its primary subject-matter is the arising and cessation of suffering, and it supplies the causal grammar of the second and third Noble Truths.

The derivation of momentariness proceeds in two stages, and conflating them is the standard error.

Stage one is immediate. What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it alters as those conditions rise and fall. Therefore whatever is conditioned is impermanent (anitya).

Stage two requires an added premise from the Buddhist logicians: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect (sat = arthakriyā-samartha). A wholly permanent entity cannot satisfy this. If it produces its whole effect at once, nothing remains for later production — the simultaneity horn (yauḡapadya). If it produces effects successively, it functions differently at different times, and what functions differently has changed — the succession horn (krama). Nyāya's escape, that it acts when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present, is closed by the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma: either the permanent thing already had the power, so the auxiliaries are idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, so the permanent thing is redundant. Hence yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

Continuity is preserved, not denied: the causal series (saṁtāna) with similarity (sādrśya) explains why a flame or a river looks like one thing.

Critically, Nyāya's counter-charge — that a series explains succession but not the ownership of memory and desert — retains force, so the derivation is powerful without being uncontested.

Why this earns marks. It separates the two stages of the derivation, names both horns and the dilemma that closes the realist escape, retains the continuity device, and ends with the residual objection rather than an unqualified claim.

Primary PYQ 5 · 2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.

Demand decoded. "Logical derivative" is the operative phrase: the examiner wants an inference reconstructed, with its premises exposed. "Explain" permits exposition but rewards the candidate who shows exactly what dependence does and does not by itself deliver.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) states that whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions and ceases when they cease. Momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) states that whatever is real is momentary. The second is a derivative of the first, but the derivation has two stages and an added premise, and an answer that hides the premise misrepresents the logic.

Stage one: from dependence to impermanence. If a thing arises only when conditions cooperate, its being is indexed to those conditions. Conditions rise and fall; the thing alters with them; therefore it cannot remain numerically identical through all times. So whatever is conditioned is impermanent (anitya). This much is already contained in the three marks (trilakṣaṇa).

Stage two: from impermanence to strict momentariness. Impermanence permits long-lived changing things; momentariness does not. The extra premise is the Buddhist criterion of reality: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect, sat = arthakriyā-samartha. From it the logicians construct a dilemma against any permanent efficient cause. Either it produces its whole effect simultaneously, in which case nothing is left for later production (yauḡapadya); or it produces successively, in which case it functions differently at different moments, and what functions differently is not wholly unchanged (krama). Nyāya replies that the permanent substance acts when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) obtain; the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma closes this, since either the thing already possessed the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing causally redundant. A second line adds that perishing needs no external destroyer: arising already contains ceasing. Therefore yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

What is preserved. The doctrine is not annihilationism. Apparent persistence is explained by the causal series (saṁtāna), whose successive members are similar enough (sādrśya) to be designated as one thing — the flame and the stream. Memory, moral consequence and rebirth are carried by the same series.

Verdict. The derivation is genuinely logical rather than merely historical, but it is conditional on the criterion of the real. Nyāya's most effective counter is therefore criterial rather than perceptual: it refuses to identify reality with causal efficacy, and it presses that a series cannot own memory or desert. Momentariness stands as the strongest Buddhist argument against substance, while remaining hostage to a premise its opponents deny.

Why this earns marks. It answers "logical derivative" by exhibiting the inference in two stages, exposes the hidden premise that most scripts suppress, closes the realist escape route by name, preserves continuity, and delivers a conditional verdict rather than a summary.

Primary PYQ 6 · 2020 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Demand decoded. Two demands joined by a challenge. Enumerate and use the aggregates, then answer the challenge directly instead of restating no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Buddhism replaces the question "what is the self?" with an exhaustive inventory. The person is analysed into five aggregates (pañca-skandha): form or material body (rūpa), feeling (vedanā), perception or recognition (saṃjñā), dispositions or formations (saṃskāra), and consciousness (vijñāna).

Each is examined and found impermanent; what is impermanent and appropriated is unsatisfactory; and what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be regarded as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self". No sixth item is discovered behind or above them. "Self" is therefore a designation (prajñapti) made upon the aggregates, not a discovery among them. The chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha makes the semantic point precisely: "chariot" is correct usage without naming an extra entity beyond parts in working arrangement.

The force of the argument depends entirely on the enumeration being exhaustive, which is why the Puggalavāda of the Vātsīputrīyas — a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates — was rejected as a relapse into self-theory.

Liberation follows without a soul. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering. Ignorance superimposes ownership on the aggregate-stream; that appropriation generates craving and renewed becoming; insight into no-self withdraws the appropriation and the process runs down. Practice is carried by the causal series (saṁtāna), and the practitioner is the conventional person, which is all that discipline requires.

The residual difficulty is that a series explains succession more easily than ownership; Buddhism answers by treating ownership as a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It enumerates the aggregates and then uses them as an argument, supplies the semantic reading of the chariot, cites the rejected internal foil as evidence of principled cost, and answers the liberation challenge by redescribing liberation rather than by denying the difficulty.

Primary PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Distinguish" requires criteria, not two paragraphs. Fix the axes — what is denied, by whom, and with what consequence — and the answer writes itself.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Both are forms of no-self, differing in scope.

Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) denies a permanent, independent person (pudgala) behind experience. The person is a designation on the five aggregates, and no owner is found among or behind them. This is the minimum thesis shared across Buddhist traditions, and it is what the chariot analogy establishes.

Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) extends the same analysis to the constituent factors themselves, denying that any dharma possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva).

The difference is therefore between the owner and the inventory on which the owner was denied. Early Buddhism and the realist Abhidharma schools accept the first while treating dharmas as ultimately real; Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are precisely such positions. Mahāyāna, and Mādhyamika above all, presses the second, which is why dependence yields emptiness there but conditioned realism in the earlier schools.

The distinction is one of philosophical scope, not of institutional affiliation, and it should not be converted into a contrast between Theravāda and Mahāyāna as wholes.

Why this earns marks. It fixes a single criterion of distinction, attaches each thesis to the schools that stress it, connects the difference to the divergent conclusions drawn from dependent origination, and adds the qualification that blocks the standard mislabelling.

Primary PYQ 8 · 2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss" makes the residual objection compulsory. State the Nyāya case at full strength, give the Buddhist devices by name, and close with an honest verdict.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The Nyāya objection, in the line of Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Udayana, is sharp. If every mental state perishes instantly, the state that remembers is not the state that experienced, so there is no rememberer. Recognition (pratyabhijñā) — "this is that same jar", "I am the one who saw it" — appears to disclose identity through time, and moral desert seems to require that the doer be the enjoyer.

Buddhism answers with three named devices. The causal continuum (santāna) locates memory within one stream: the earlier experience conditions a later cognition that presents itself as recollection, so no permanent subject is required. Similarity (sādrśya) explains recognition: a later causal phase resembling an earlier one is conventionally taken as numerically the same, which is why the flame and the river look like single things. Reconnection (pratisandhāna) extends continuity across the discontinuities of sleep and death, and Yogācāra supplements it with store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja), a conditioned transforming stream rather than a disguised self.

The resulting position is deliberately a middle: the later subject is neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than the earlier one (na sa eva na cānyaḥ). Strict identity would be eternalism; strict difference would destroy responsibility.

Critically, the reply is strong against the demand for a carrier and weak against the demand for a subject. Nyāya's residual force is that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining how it is owned, and Advaita presses further that the unity of experience seems to need a witness.

The defensible verdict is that Buddhism explains personal identity successfully as continuity, while conceding that ownership is a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection with named opponents, answers with three distinct technical devices rather than one, gives the middle formula in its canonical phrasing, and separates what the reply achieves from what it concedes.

Primary PYQ 9 · 2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Three demands: assess compatibility, report the responses, and criticise. The second demand requires named opponents; the third requires a verdict that is graded rather than triumphant.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The tension is genuine. Momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) holds that whatever is real is momentary; action and moral consequence (karma) requires that the fruit of an act reach the one who performed it. If the agent perishes with the act, the recipient appears to be someone else, and moral desert collapses.

The Buddhist position. Buddhism refuses the disjunction on which the objection rests. The relation between the acting stage and the receiving stage is neither identity nor utter difference — na sa eva na cānyaḥ. Strict identity would reinstate the eternal self (ātman) already denied; strict difference would make reward and punishment fall on a stranger. What holds them together is the causal continuum (santāna): the fruit is received by the stream that the earlier stage conditioned. The illustration is one lamp lighting another — not the same flame, not an unrelated one. Rebirth is relinking (pratisandhāna) of one series to another rather than transmigration, so nothing crosses over. Moral quality itself is located in intention (cetanā), a formation among the aggregates. Yogācāra adds store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja) to explain why latent potential survives long intervals.

Opponents and responses. Nyāya, in the Vātsyāyana–Uddyotakara–Udayana line, argues from recognition, memory and desert to an enduring self; the Buddhist replies with the series and with similarity (sādrśya), which explains why a later similar phase is taken as the same. Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa argues that duty and cognition require a persisting subject; Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reply that the subject is a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions. Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that bondage and release cannot belong to no one; the two-truths reply is that persons and practice are valid designations at conventional truth while nothing has intrinsic nature at ultimate truth.

Critical verdict. The compatibility is real but asymmetric. Buddhism explains succession — why this fruit follows that act — with unusual precision, and protects impermanence and responsibility simultaneously. What it explains less convincingly is ownership:

causal continuity shows why a later stage inherits, but not obviously why it deserves. The Buddhist rejoinder, that desert is a conventional notion tracking causal continuity and that the demand for ultimate desert presupposes an ultimate subject, is coherent. The doctrines are therefore compatible, at the price of relocating moral desert to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It states the tension precisely, resolves it through the canonical middle formula, names three distinct opponents with their specific arguments and the specific Buddhist replies, adds intention as the locus of moral quality, and closes with a graded verdict that identifies exactly what is and is not secured.

Primary PYQ 10 · 2022 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoded. Two tasks, and the first is usually done badly. "Internal relation" is not a list of three items; it asks how the three depend on one another.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The Three Jewels (Triratna) are the Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha, the threefold refuge of the Buddhist practitioner.

Internal relation. They form a functional triad rather than three parallel objects of devotion. The Buddha is the one who discovered and demonstrated the path; the Dharma is the teaching and the truth it states, and is what actually liberates; the Saṅgha is the community that preserves, transmits and exemplifies the teaching. The dependence therefore runs in two directions. In order of origin it is Buddha → Dharma → Saṅgha, since the teaching derives from the awakening and the community from the teaching. In order of access it is Saṅgha → Dharma → Buddha, since a present-day practitioner reaches the teaching through the community that preserved it. What liberates is identified as the Dharma, which is why refuge is not devotion to a person.

Consistency with no-self. The objection is immediate: if there is no self, who takes refuge? Buddhism answers that the refuge-taker is the conventional person, a designated person (prajñapti-puruṣa) upon the five aggregates, not an ultimately real soul. That is all refuge requires, because what is needed is a causal series capable of being conditioned by instruction — and intention and dispositions are themselves aggregates.

Far from conflicting, the two doctrines cohere: no-self purifies refuge of ego-metaphysics. Refuge is not the surrender of a soul to a saviour but the reorientation of a stream by a teaching.

Critically, the reply relocates the practitioner to conventional truth, so the Advaitic pressure about the unity of the practising subject remains — a cost, not an inconsistency.

Why this earns marks. It answers "internal relation" with two directions of dependence rather than a list, identifies the Dharma as the liberating member, answers the consistency challenge with the technical term for the conventional person, and concedes the surviving pressure without conceding the charge.

Primary PYQ 11 · 2023 · Q8(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.

Demand decoded. A quotation-anchored question. The examiner is testing whether the candidate can show that ignorance is causally productive rather than merely absent knowledge, and can then present the whole path as the removal of that cause.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The quoted statement is not an epistemic slogan but a causal thesis: misreading how things exist is itself the engine of suffering, and correcting the misreading dismantles it.

Why ignorance is productive. Ignorance (avidyā) is not blankness. It is the active misconstrual of conditioned processes as stable possessions — treating what is dependently arisen as though it had intrinsic nature and belonged to an owner. That misconstrual generates appropriation: what is taken as "mine" is defended, pursued and mourned. This is why ignorance heads the twelve links (dvādaśa-nidāna), conditioning formations, consciousness, name-and-form, the six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and ageing-and-death.

Where the chain can be cut. Feeling (vedanā) arises unavoidably from contact; craving (tṛṣṇā) does not arise unavoidably from feeling. That gap is the operative joint, and the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga) is built to work on it. Grouped under three trainings, wisdom (right view, right intention) attacks ignorance directly, ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) removes

the conduct that continually renews craving, and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration) stabilises the attention in which feeling is prevented from hardening into demand.

Why cessation follows. The reverse order (pratiloma) of the chain states that with the cessation of ignorance, formations cease, and so on to the cessation of ageing-and-death. Cessation is therefore not an additional event to be hoped for; it is entailed by removing a condition in a dependently arisen series. This converts the third Noble Truth from an assertion into a consequence, and it is exactly what the quoted sentence claims.

What liberation is. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion. Since the self was never found, nothing is annihilated; the process of grasping simply ceases. The practitioner is the conventional person, and continuity of practice is carried by the causal series (saṁtāna), not by a soul.

Critical assessment. The soteriology is unusually tight: diagnosis, cause, cessation and therapy are one argument, and the metaphysics of impermanence and no-self are entailments of the therapeutic claim rather than additions to it. Its contested point is whether knowledge alone, however transformative, can uproot deeply conditioned craving; the tradition answers by making insight inseparable from conduct and attention, which is why the path has eight factors and not one.

Why this earns marks. It converts the quotation into a causal claim and defends it, uses the twelve links and the reverse order to make cessation an entailment, maps the eightfold path onto the exact joint it targets, and finishes with a critical point that arises from the doctrine rather than from outside it.

Primary PYQ 12 · 2024 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoded. "Answer with arguments" forbids a descriptive contrast. The task is to show how one premise supports two conclusions, which means locating the extra premise on which the schools differ.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Both conclusions start from dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda): whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions. They diverge because they apply different criteria of the ultimately real to that shared premise.

"Everything is void" — Mādhyamika. To possess intrinsic nature (svabhāva) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; everything conditioned awaits conditions; therefore nothing conditioned has intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty. Nāgārjuna accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty (śūnya). The criterion of ultimacy here is independence, and dependence excludes it.

"Everything is real" — Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika. These schools accept the same causal premise and infer that precisely because things arise causally, they are real as conditioned entities. Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about dharmas and affirms sarvaṃ asti, that dharmas of the three times have some mode of existence; Sautrāntika restricts full existence to the present and holds that external objects are inferred from the form (ākāra) borne by cognition. The criterion of ultimacy here is causal efficacy, and dependence supplies it.

Why this is not a contradiction. The two answer different questions. "Everything is void" answers does anything possess intrinsic nature? "Everything is real" answers is anything causally efficacious? The realists deny permanence, not causal reality; the Mādhyamika denies intrinsic nature, not conventional functioning. The two truths make this explicit: at conventional truth things function; at ultimate truth none has own-being.

The genuine dispute is therefore not verbal but criterial — whether causal efficacy is sufficient for ultimate status, or whether independence is required.

Why this earns marks. It isolates the shared premise, exhibits both derivations as arguments, names the two realist schools separately with their distinguishing theses, and resolves the apparent contradiction by identifying the divergent criterion instead of asserting that the schools simply disagree.

Primary PYQ 13 · 2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. A three-way consistency question with "critically discuss". It differs from the 2018 fifteen-marker by expressly adding momentariness, so the answer must show what momentariness specifically contributes rather than treating it as a synonym

for no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The three doctrines are not merely compatible; each is required by the others.

What no-self contributes. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, not a possession acquired by an owner. The objection "who attains?" therefore presupposes the very claimant whose removal constitutes the attainment. No permanent self (nairātmyavāda) removes the false claimant, and in doing so removes the appropriation that generated craving in the first place.

What momentariness contributes, distinctly. It is not a restatement of no-self. It supplies the positive explanation of possibility: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition. A permanent bondage, or a permanent defilement inhering in a permanent substance, could not be removed at all. Momentariness thus underwrites the third Noble Truth, while no-self underwrites the diagnosis of what must be given up.

How practice is carried. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (saṁtāna), the later liberated stream being neither identical with nor unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Theravāda classifications treat nibbāna as unconditioned (asaṁskṛta) — outside the dependent series, not a substance with properties. Nāgārjuna adds that saṁsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

Critically. Two costs remain. The first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream, and the Advaitin presses that the unity of experience still requires a witness. Buddhism answers by refusal rather than by explanation, on the ground that a witness would be one more reification.

The verdict is consonance, purchased by relocating the liberated subject to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It differentiates the distinct contributions of no-self and momentariness instead of treating them as one point, handles the unconditioned classification without error, cites Nāgārjuna's non-duality of saṁsāra and nirvāṇa, and states the surviving Advaitic pressure as a cost rather than a refutation.

Primary PYQ 14 · 2026 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How does the Buddhist theory of momentariness problematize the issue of human action and responsibility? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Explain why strict momentariness creates an agency problem, then distinguish numerical identity from causally connected responsibility and assess the residual objection.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Momentariness creates an apparent gap between action and responsibility. If the agent who acts perishes immediately, the later recipient of karmic consequence is not numerically the same subject. A permanent soul cannot solve the problem within Buddhism because no-self denies such a substance. The Buddhist reply replaces identity with causal continuity. An intentional act conditions the succeeding stream of psycho-physical events; later stages inherit dispositions and consequences from earlier stages through the causal continuum, or saṁtāna. The fruit therefore occurs neither in an utterly identical self nor in an unrelated being: the later phase is "neither the same nor another." Intention, cetanā, gives action its moral quality, while continuity links that quality to later experience. Yogācāra's store-consciousness and seeds offer one school-specific elaboration, not a universal substantial carrier. The account avoids fatalism because conditioned sequences can be redirected by insight and practice. Yet a realist objection remains: causal connectedness may explain transmission without fully explaining ownership or desert. Buddhism answers that conventional personal identity is sufficient for responsibility, while ultimate analysis finds only dependent events. Thus momentariness problematizes, but need not abolish, agency.

SUPPORTING CROSS-TOPIC PYQS — OUTSIDE PRIMARY NUMBERING

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S1 · 2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist half is owned by this topic and is the half most often written thinly.

Demand decoded. A two-sided comparative question. Give each side's account of how the cognition arises, not merely its ontology of absence.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Nyāya. Absence (abhāva) is admitted as a real category. In "there is no jar on the table", the table is the locus (anuyogin) and the jar is the counterpositive (pratiyogin) whose absence qualifies that locus, so absence-cognition has structured intentional content rather than blankness. No independent means of knowledge called non-cognition is required: under suitable conditions the same perceptual situation that presents the empty locus presents jar-absence through the qualifier–qualified relation (viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya-bhāva). The conditions are that the jar would have been perceptible if present, that the locus is available, and that the senses are unobstructed. Where the missing item is itself inferential, its absence may be inferentially established.

Buddhists. No separately existing negative entity is admitted. The judgement is explained by perception of the positive locus together with non-apprehension of the jar, and is then handled conceptually — by exclusion (apoha) and by inference, since the Buddhist epistemologists recognise only perception and inference and reduce non-apprehension to them.

The contrast is thus categorical: Nyāya adds absence to the world; Buddhism adds it only to the conceptual construction of the world.

Why this earns marks. It gives both sides the technical vocabulary their own systems use, explains the mechanism of the cognition rather than only the ontology, and closes with a single sentence that names the precise point of disagreement.

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S2 · 2024 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Cārvāka-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of ātmā.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Cārvāka; it is solved here because the Buddhist half of the differentiation is owned by this topic and carries most of the analytical weight.

Demand decoded. "Differentiate" demands fixed axes. The trap is to write two summaries; the reward is for showing that a shared conclusion is reached by opposite routes and issues in opposite consequences.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Both schools deny an eternal self (ātman), and there the agreement ends. They differ in method, in what replaces the self, and in what the denial costs.

Method. Cārvāka argues from a restriction of knowledge. Accepting perception as the sole reliable means, and refusing inference independent standing, it holds that no transcendental self is ever perceived; what is observed is a living body in which awareness appears. The denial is therefore epistemically driven and reductive. Buddhism argues from an exhaustive analysis. The person is divided into five aggregates (pañca-skandha) — form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness — each found impermanent, unsatisfactory when grasped and not fit to be owned; and no sixth item is discovered. The denial is therefore analytically driven, and Buddhism accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.

What replaces the self. For Cārvāka the replacement is the body: consciousness is treated as arising from the organised material elements, as intoxicating power arises from ingredients that individually lack it. For Buddhism the replacement is a process: the person is a designation (prajñapti) on a causal series (santāna), illustrated by the chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha. Buddhism explicitly refuses the materialist reduction, since consciousness is one aggregate conditioned by others rather than a by-product of body alone.

Consequences. This is where the differentiation earns its marks. Cārvāka's denial abolishes rebirth, moral consequence and liberation together; ethics becomes prudential and the goal becomes worldly well-being. Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to preserve rebirth, moral consequence and liberation without a bearer: the fruit falls on the stream that the acting stage conditioned, on the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (na sa eva na cānyah), with moral quality located in intention (cetanā).

Assessment. Cārvāka's position is economical and immune to the charge of speculative surplus, but it purchases economy by rejecting inference, which its rivals argue is self-defeating. Buddhism's position is more demanding, since it must explain memory, recognition and desert without an owner, and Nyāya's charge that a series cannot own what it transmits retains force.

The differentiation is therefore not one of degree. Cārvāka rejects the self to shrink the world to what perception delivers; Buddhism rejects it to redescribe the world as process while keeping everything the self was invoked to explain.

Why this earns marks. It uses three fixed axes rather than two summaries, names the technical devices on each side, identifies the decisive contrast in consequences rather than in doctrine alone, and ends with a balanced assessment that gives each position its characteristic strength and cost.

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S3 · 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Pramāṇa and Pramāṇaphala.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist side of the debate is owned by this topic through the Dignāga–Dharmakīrti material.

Demand decoded. "Exposition of the debate" requires both positions and the reason they differ. The reason is metaphysical, and saying so is what lifts the answer above a definitional contrast.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Nyāya. The knower (pramātr), the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), the object (prameya) and the resulting true cognition (pramā or pramāṇaphala) are analytically distinct factors in a realist cognitive episode. The operative instrument or causal complex is the pramāṇa; true cognition is its fruit. Means and result are therefore different.

Buddhists. Dignāga tightens the relation so that the instrument of knowledge and its result are not ultimately different. The resultant cognition — the determination of the object together with the self-awareness of cognition (svasaṃvedana) — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa. The analysis into instrument (karaṇa) and result (phala) is a conceptual overlay on a single momentary cognition.

Why they differ. The disagreement is downstream of metaphysics. Nyāya has an enduring knower who uses a real instrument on a real object; Buddhism, having denied the permanent self and admitted only momentary events, has no bearer to hold the fourfold apparatus apart. Nyāya is instrumentally realist; Buddhist epistemology is cognition-centred.

Why this earns marks. It presents both positions in their own vocabulary, identifies the Buddhist thesis precisely as non-difference rather than as identity, and explains the disagreement by tracing it to the dispute over the self instead of leaving it as a clash of definitions.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE — SIX MODELS

These six questions are original practice items written in UPSC style. They are not previous-year questions and are not represented as such.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain the two senses of the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad) in Buddhism. Why is the doctrinal sense indispensable to the practical one?

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The Middle Path operates in two registers.

Practically, it rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification, replacing both with the Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga) grouped under wisdom (right view, right intention), ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration). The rejection is diagnostic: indulgence feeds craving, while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it.

Doctrinally, it rejects eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), replacing both with dependent origination and conditioned continuity.

The doctrinal sense is indispensable because the practical path is unintelligible without it. If a permanent self existed, training could not transform it, and the third Noble Truth would fail. If nothing continued, discipline could accumulate no result, and the fourth would fail. Only conditioned continuity — change without a permanent bearer, and continuity without annihilation — makes a path both necessary and effective.

Both senses share one logic: Buddhism denies the hidden assumption common to each pair of extremes rather than choosing between them.

Why this earns marks. It gives both senses with their positive content, then answers the "why" with a specific structural dependence rather than a general remark about coherence.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Buddhist epistemology is not a shortened Nyāya list." Examine this claim with reference to the two means of valid knowledge and the exclusion theory of meaning.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The claim is correct, and the reason is structural rather than numerical.

Dignāga and Dharmakīrti admit two means of valid knowledge because they hold that the number of means is fixed by the number of object-types. There are exactly two: the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa), which is momentary, causally efficient and ineffable, grasped by non-conceptual perception; and the constructed general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa), grasped by inference. Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and testimony are reduced to these, not omitted from a list.

The exclusion theory (apoha) confirms the point. Since only unique particulars are ultimately real, a general term cannot denote a real universal; "cow" functions as "not-non-cow", generality being constructed negatively upon shared causal capacity.

Both theses follow from momentariness and no-self, which is also why the instrument of knowledge is held to be non-different from its result. A shortened Nyāya list would still contain an enduring knower and real universals; Buddhist epistemology contains neither.

Why this earns marks. It refutes the claim by exhibiting a different principle of individuation, links two doctrines to the same metaphysical source, and names the consequence for pramāṇaphala.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Analyse the four schools of Buddhism as an argumentative escalation rather than as a classification. What does each successive position gain and lose?

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The fourfold matrix is a philosophical doxography, and its explanatory value lies in the fact that each position is generated by an objection the previous one cannot absorb.

Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about external dharmas and affirms sarvam asti, that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence. It gains a genuine object for every cognition and a real relation between a past act and its future fruit. It loses ontological economy and strains momentariness, since extending existence across the three times sits awkwardly with strict one-moment duration.

Sautrāntika answers by restricting full existence to the present. Since the object-moment has ceased when its cognition arises, cognition bears only the object's form (ākāra), from which the external object is inferred. It gains consistency with momentariness. It loses direct access, and now owes an account of why the inferred cause should correspond to the form it produces.

Yogācāra presses exactly there: if all that is ever given is the form, the external object performs no explanatory work. Representation-only (vijñaptimātra) gains economy, and explains order through store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja). It loses the easy explanation of intersubjective agreement, which must now be derived from shared karmic conditioning, and it exposes consciousness itself to the charge of reification.

Mādhyamika presses that charge: even consciousness lacks intrinsic nature. Emptiness gains complete freedom from reification, including the emptiness of emptiness. It loses any positive ultimate, and must defend a non-implicative negation (prasajya-pratiśedha) against the objection that denying all four corners either says nothing or refutes itself.

Read as an escalation, the four schools display one method — remove whatever the analysis shows to be unnecessary — applied with increasing severity.

Why this earns marks. It supplies the objection that drives each transition, states a specific gain and a specific cost for every school, and ends with the methodological unity that makes the sequence an argument rather than a list.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The doctrine of two truths is what separates emptiness from nihilism." Critically examine, with reference to the four-cornered analysis.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The claim is substantially correct, though it needs a supplement.

The problem. The four-cornered analysis (*catuṣkoṭi*) sets out four alternatives — it is, it is not, it both is and is not, it neither is nor is not — and Nāgārjuna denies all four. To a realist this looks like the abolition of every position, hence nihilism, and the further charge that the denial is itself a thesis, so the claim to have no thesis (*pratijñā*) is self-refuting.

The first defence is the negation type. Madhyamaka negation is non-implicative (*prasajya-pratiśedha*) rather than implicative (*paryudāsa-pratiśedha*), and it is scoped: the four corners are denied of things taken as possessing intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*). Denying them therefore withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting four incompatible propositions, and no fifth positive thesis is installed. Nāgārjuna's supplement is that his own words are empty too, so they generate no ontological commitment; empty utterance cures empty reification as one magically created figure may counteract another (*nirmitaka*).

The second defence is the two truths, and this is what the claim identifies. At conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*), persons, causation, moral consequence, compassion and the path all function; at ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*), nothing possesses own-being. Conventional truth is not falsehood but the operative domain of Buddhist practice. Without it, the fourfold denial would indeed leave nothing standing.

Critically, the two truths are necessary but not sufficient: the negation nuance must also be stated, or the doctrine still looks self-refuting. And whether a non-implicative negation can be sustained without covertly functioning as a thesis remains disputed, as the internal *Prāsaṅgika*–*Svātantrika* division shows.

The accurate verdict is that the two truths block nihilism, while the scoped negation blocks self-refutation, and emptiness needs both.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection in both its forms, distinguishes two distinct defences and assigns each to the charge it answers, and refines the quoted claim instead of simply endorsing it.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the claim that Buddhism preserves everything the self was invoked to explain, while dispensing with the self itself.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The claim states Buddhism's ambition accurately. The question is whether the ambition is achieved, and the honest answer is: largely, but not entirely.

What the self was invoked to explain. In the realist systems, an enduring self (*ātman*) accounts for four things: continuity through time, memory and recognition, the justice of moral consequence, and the unity of one experiencing life.

How Buddhism replaces each. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (*santāna*), whose successive members are similar enough (*sādrśya*) to be designated as one thing — the flame and the river. Memory is a later cognition conditioned by an earlier experience within the same stream, extended across discontinuities by reconnection (*pratisandhāna*) and, in *Yogācāra*, by store-consciousness (*ālaya-vijñāna*) carrying seeds (*bīja*). Moral consequence is preserved by the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (*na sa eva na cānyaḥ*), with moral quality located in intention (*cetanā*), itself an aggregate. Practice and refuge are preserved by the conventional person (*prajñapti-puruṣa*).

Where the replacement succeeds. It succeeds against the demand for a carrier. Every function the realist assigned to a substance is discharged by a causal relation, and the resulting system is more economical: it explains bondage and release with the same apparatus, since only a conditioned series can be interrupted by removing a condition.

Where it is pressed hardest. Two functions resist. First, ownership: *Nyāya*, in the *Vātsyāyana*–*Uddyotakara*–*Udayana* line, argues that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining whose memory it is, and that desert requires more than inheritance. Second, unity: *Śaṅkara*-type *Advaita* argues that the presentation of a manifold as one field requires a self-luminous witness, and that denying the self presupposes it. Buddhism answers the first by treating ownership as a conventional designation and the second by refusing the witness as one more reification — coherent answers that relocate rather than discharge the demand.

Verdict. The claim holds for continuity, memory-transmission, karmic inheritance and practice, and holds only at the conventional level for ownership and unity. Buddhism therefore dispenses with the self successfully as an explanator posit while conceding that

some of the work it did survives as convention rather than as ultimate fact — which is why the dispute with Nyāya and Advaita has never been settled by either side.

Why this earns marks. It converts an evaluative claim into a checklist of four explanatory functions, supplies the specific Buddhist replacement for each with technical terms, separates successes from residues, names the opponents who press the residues, and delivers a differentiated rather than a global verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Buddhist and Jaina responses to the problem of change and permanence, and assess which secures the reality of the world at lower philosophical cost.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Both are non-Vedic renouncer traditions, both deny a creator, and both must explain how a thing can change and still be spoken of as the same. Their solutions are opposites.

The Jaina solution. The real (sat) possesses origination (utpāda), decay (vyaya) and persistence (dhrauvya) together. Permanence belongs to substance (dravya) and change to modes (paryāya), so the gold persists while bracelet gives way to ring. Since the real has innumerable aspects, cognition is standpoint-relative (naya) and assertion carries the operator syāt, generating the sevenfold predication. Reality is many-sided (anekāntavāda), and the soul (jīva) is a real conscious substance obscured by action-matter.

The Buddhist solution: deny the persisting substance altogether. Whatever is conditioned is impermanent, and the criterion of the real as causally efficient (sat = arthakriyā-samartha) radicalises this into momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda), since a permanent entity can produce its effect neither all at once (yauḡapadya) nor successively (krama) without ceasing to be permanent. Apparent persistence is a causal series (saṁtāna) of sufficiently similar moments; the person is a designation on five aggregates; no soul is admitted.

The costs, weighed. Jainism secures the world cheaply in ontology and expensively in logic. Nothing needs to be re-described: things really persist and really change. But predication must be permanently qualified, the schema of assertion becomes sevenfold, and the system must carry six substances, innumerable souls and material action-matter. Buddhism secures the world cheaply in logic and expensively in re-description. Assertion stays ordinary and the ontology is austere — momentary causally efficient events — but almost every ordinary notion must be relocated to conventional truth: the same thing, the same person, the rememberer, the deserver.

Assessment. If "reality of the world" means the truth of ordinary claims taken at face value, Jainism secures it at lower cost, because it never demotes them. If it means an ontology free of unexplained composites and unverifiable substances, Buddhism secures it at lower cost, because it posits less. The decisive contrast is methodological: Jainism qualifies the sentence to save the world; Buddhism qualifies the world to save the sentence.

The standard error must be avoided: Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, and only Buddhism denies it.

Why this earns marks. It states both solutions in their own technical vocabulary, converts "cost" into two explicit currencies rather than leaving it vague, delivers a conditional verdict that depends on how the question is read, and closes by disarming the comparison error that examiners most often penalise.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH — NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Read this only after the Basic block and the practice sections. Nothing below is needed for a full-marks core answer on dependent origination, momentariness, no permanent self, the four schools, liberation or any routed previous-year question. Each module is an evaluative enrichment: use at most one, in the critical paragraph of a fifteen- or twenty-marker, after the core derivation is already complete.

1. The Mādhyamika interpretation dispute

□□ The issue. Is Nāgārjuna best read as a quietist and purely dialectical thinker who advances no philosophical position at all, or as an anti-essentialist philosopher with a robust conventional realism?

□ The two readings. A reductio-centred reading stresses the prasaṅga method and the anti-thesis claim of the Vigrahavyāvartanī, treating every Mādhyamika utterance as parasitic on an opponent's commitment. More assertive readings allow carefully stated conventional philosophical claims, on the ground that the two truths would be pointless if nothing could be said at the conventional level.

- ☐ Strongest extra objection. Emptiness destroys all assertion, including Buddhist doctrine itself.
- ☐ Counter-reply. The standard reply is that what is denied is svabhāva, not dependent conventional discourse, and that the "emptiness of emptiness" blocks the reification of emptiness into a new absolute.
- ☐ Internal marker. The Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika division is where the dispute becomes institutional: Candrakīrti is associated with reductio without independent syllogisms, while Bhāvaviveka allows independent (svatantra) inferences in debate. Source trail: Nāgārjuna, Mūlamadhyamakakārikā; Candrakīrti, Prasannapadā; Radhakrishnan.
- ☐ Answer use. One sentence only: "Whether Madhyamaka can state a conventional position without reinstating a thesis remains disputed, as the Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika division shows."

2. The Yogācāra "idealism" debate

- ☐ The issue. Does representation-only (vijñaptimātratā) deny external objects metaphysically, or does it mainly expose how experience is mind-structured?
- ☐ The two readings. A strong idealist reading takes external objects to be denied outright. A phenomenological or epistemic reading takes the school to be criticising the representational model of objecthood rather than asserting solipsism.
- ☐ Strongest extra objection. Consciousness-only makes intersubjective experience mysterious: if there is no shared object, why do observers agree?
- ☐ Counter-reply. Yogācāra answers through beginningless latent impressions (vāsanā) and store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna), with shared karmic conditioning producing similarly structured experience in similarly conditioned beings. Source trail: Vasubandhu, Viṃśatikā and Triṃśikā; Chatterjee and Datta; C. D. Sharma.
- ☐ Answer use. Deploy only if a question expressly asks whether Yogācāra is idealist; otherwise the core statement — denial of an independently established object — is sufficient and safer.

3. The person-theory (Pudgalavāda) as a pressure point

- ☐ The issue. Can Buddhist continuity be secured better by a "person" theory than by bare aggregate-stream language?
- ☐ The positions. Orthodox no-self lines reject the pudgala outright. The Pudgalavādin move attempts to preserve responsibility without a permanent self by holding that the person is neither identical with nor wholly different from the aggregates.
- ☐ Strongest extra objection. "Person" smuggles the soul back in under a new name.
- ☐ Counter-reply. The Pudgalavādins insist the person is neither identical with nor different from the aggregates, so no substance is asserted; orthodox schools nevertheless judge the move too concessive. Source trail: Milindapañha for continuity analogies; the Kathāvatthu tradition; Radhakrishnan.
- ☐ Answer use. In a core answer the foil is already covered in the Basic block as evidence of internal pressure. Advanced use is only to note that the dispute shows the ownership problem was felt inside Buddhism and not merely imported by Nyāya.

4. Two truths and the security of ethics

- ☐ The issue. If ultimate analysis dissolves self and substance, what secures moral seriousness at the conventional level?
- ☐ The two readings. A minimalist reading treats convention as merely practical, with no normative weight of its own. A stronger Mahāyāna reading holds that compassion and moral consequence are intelligible precisely at the conventional level, which is where liberation is sought and beings are helped.
- ☐ Strongest extra objection. Ultimate truth empties ethics of force: if no one ultimately suffers, compassion has no ultimate object.
- ☐ Counter-reply. Liberation and compassion operate within dependent conventional life rather than outside it, and Nāgārjuna's insistence that saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms is designed to prevent the ultimate level from becoming an escape from the conventional one. Source trail: Nāgārjuna, Mūlamadhyamakakārikā; Majjhima Nikāya; Chatterjee and Datta.

5. Controlled comparisons — one line at most, after the Indian argument is complete

| Comparison | Point of contact | Disanalogy that must be stated |

|---|---|---|

| Hume's bundle theory and no-self | Both deny a substantial self on broadly empiricist grounds | Hume has no karmic continuity and no liberation-soteriology, and treats the self as a fiction of the imagination; Buddhism has a morally weighted causal series |

| Heraclitean flux and momentariness | Both stress universal change | Heraclitus retains logos as an ordering principle; Buddhist momentariness is tied to dependent origination and causal efficacy |

| Process metaphysics and momentary dharmas | Both treat reality as event rather than inert substance | A process metaphysics is not a no-self path and has no exclusion theory or cessation-goal |

| The four-cornered analysis and Kant's antinomies | Both show reason generating opposed metaphysical conclusions | Kant preserves the phenomenal object and limits the categories; Nāgārjuna targets svabhāva itself through emptiness |

| Therapeutic philosophy and the Buddha's silence | Both dissolve misleading questions rather than answering them | The Buddha's therapy is soteriological and rooted in suffering, moral consequence and liberation |

| Nominalism and exclusion (apoha) | Both deny real universals | The exclusion mechanism and its karmic-epistemic background have no exact Western counterpart, and classical nominalism retains enduring individuals |

□□ Rubric. Western parallels are illustrative only. They must never replace the Indian argument and belong in at most one or two lines after the Buddhist case is complete.

6. What not to over-study

□□ Full scholastic taxonomies of every Buddhist school, exhaustive Abhidharma lists, and the Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika divide treated as a compulsory sub-question are all poor investments of preparation time. □ Promotion trigger: these modules would become core only if a future paper directly asked whether Yogācāra is idealist, whether emptiness is self-refuting, whether the person-theory is compatible with no-self, or whether the two truths destabilise ethics.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Compressed revision notes for the complete topic. They do not repeat the teaching introductions; they carry definitions, exact terminology, derivations, comparisons, traps, answer routes and rapid-recall facts for every subtopic taught above, preserving the Basic / Optional-Advanced distinction.

A. System identity and answer-worthiness

- Printed syllabus, item 14 (verbatim): Schools of Buddhism : Prat Ityasaṃutpada; Kṣāṇikavāda, Nairātmyavāda.
- Buddhism is unorthodox (nāstika) on the Veda criterion, non-theistic on the creator criterion, anti-substantialist on the self criterion. Three distinct denials; never merge them.
- Frame: Four Noble Truths — suffering, origin, cessation, path. Second and third truths need a causal theory; that theory is dependent origination.
- The three printed terms are the three metaphysical commitments the therapy requires: conditionality (to explain origin), impermanence (to allow cessation), no-self (to allow transformation).
- Marks-essential core: both senses of the Middle Path, the Noble Eightfold Path, the three marks, the twelve links, momentariness, the aggregates, cessation of conditioned suffering, the Three Jewels, the four schools, all fourteen owned PYQs.
- Core supporting depth: means of valid knowledge, exclusion theory, the undeclared questions, the creator-God critique.
- Optional advanced: Madhyamaka interpretation dispute, Yogācāra idealism debate, the person-theory, two truths and ethics, Western comparisons.

B. The double Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā)

- Practical: rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification; positive content = Noble Eightfold Path (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga).
- Three trainings: wisdom (prajñā) = right view, right intention · ethical discipline (śīla) = right speech, right action, right livelihood · meditative discipline (samādhi) = right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.
- Doctrinal: rejects eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda); positive content = conditioned continuity.
- The shared hidden assumption denied by both middles: that continuity requires an identical persisting thing.
- Structural test: eternalism defeats the third truth; annihilationism defeats the fourth.
- Operative target of the path: the feeling → craving junction, plus insight at ignorance.

- ☐ Never define the Middle Path as moderation or as a mean between extremes.

C. Dependent origination and the twelve links

- Formula in four clauses: *imasmim sati idam hoti; imass' uppādā idam uppajjati; imasmim asati idam na hoti; imassa nirodhā idam nirujjhati.*
- Maps to the truths: fact · dependent arising · dependent cessation · path.
- Three marks (*trilakṣaṇa*; Pali: *tilakkhaṇa*): impermanence (*anitya*), unsatisfactoriness (*duḥkha*), no-self (*anātman*). First two predicated of conditioned formations; the third applied more widely.
- Twelve links (*dvādaśa-nidāna*): ignorance (*avidyā*) · formations (*saṃskāra*) · consciousness (*vijñāna*) · name-and-form (*nāma-rūpa*) · six sense-bases (*ṣaḍāyatana*) · contact (*sparsa*) · feeling (*vedanā*) · craving (*tṛṣṇā*) · clinging (*upādāna*) · becoming (*bhava*) · birth (*jāti*) · ageing-and-death (*jarā-maraṇa*).
- Fragile pairs: formations before consciousness; craving before clinging before becoming.
- Three readings: three-life pedagogic · present-process psychological · structural-soteriological. Answer use: state the list, then name two readings.
- Reverse order (*pratiloma*) makes the third truth an entailment, not a hope. Visual pedagogy: wheel of becoming (*bhava-cakra*).
- Ignorance heads the list without being a first cause; the figure is a wheel because *avidyā* is itself conditioned.

D. Momentariness (*kṣaṇikavāda*)

- Thesis: *yat sat tat kṣaṇikam*; scholastic formulation in substance *sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam*.
- Criterion of the real: *sat* = *arthakriyā-samartha* — causal efficacy (*arthakriyākāritva*).
- Dilemma: simultaneity horn (*yaugapadya*) — complete power leaves nothing for later; succession horn (*krama*) — different function means change.
- Escape closed: *sahakāri-anapekṣā* — auxiliaries (*sahakārin*) are either idle or decisive, so the permanent thing is redundant either way.
- Second argument: destruction (*vināśitvānumāna* / *kṣaṇabhaṅga*) — perishing is intrinsic; no external destroyer required.
- Continuity device: causal series (*santāna* / *santati*) + similarity (*sādrśya*); illustrations flame and stream.
- Method note: momentariness is established negatively, by eliminating the permanent efficient cause, never by perceiving moments.
- ☐ Momentariness ≠ non-existence. Reality is evental, not substantial.
- Residual: *Nyāya* recognition (*pratyabhijñā*) argument — a judgement of sameness seems to need a subject holding both terms.

E. No permanent self (*nairātmyavāda*), the aggregates and the two no-selves

- Five aggregates (*pañca-skandha*): form (*rūpa*) · feeling (*vedanā*) · perception (*saṃjñā*) · formations (*saṃskāra*) · consciousness (*vijñāna*).
- Argument: each is impermanent; what is impermanent and grasped is unsatisfactory; what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be "mine, I, my self"; no sixth item is found. The enumeration's exhaustiveness is the argument.
- Chariot analogy (*Milinda-pañha*): a term can be true without naming a further entity. The person is a designation (*prajñapti*), conventionally valid and not ultimately self-subsistent.
- Personal no-self (*pudgala-nairātmya*): denies the enduring person — shared minimum thesis.
- Phenomenon no-self (*dharma-nairātmya*): denies intrinsic nature in the factors — stressed by *Mahāyāna*, above all *Mādhyamika*.
- One-line contrast: the first dissolves the owner; the second dissolves the inventory.
- Foil: *Puggalavāda* of the *Vātsīputrīyas* — a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates; rejected as a relapse toward self-theory, and useful as evidence of internal pressure honestly refused.

F. Continuity: action and moral consequence, memory, identity, rebirth

- Middle formula: *na sa eva na cānyaḥ* — neither the same nor another.
- Devices: *santāna* (series) · *sādrśya* (similarity) · *pratisandhāna* (reconnection) · *Yogācāra ālaya-vijñāna* + *bīja*.
- Moral quality resides in intention (*cetanā*), itself a formation among the aggregates.

- Rebirth is relinking, not transmigration: one psycho-physical series conditions another; nothing crosses over. Illustration: one lamp lights another.
- Objection map: who remembers → series; who recognises → similarity; who deserves → neither-nor formula; what is reborn → relinking; what stores it → store-consciousness.
- Residual force: a series explains succession better than ownership; the reply relocates desert to conventional truth.
- ☐ Never answer the karma objection by reintroducing a subtle self.

G. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) and the Three Jewels (Triratna)

- Definition: extinction of the three fires — attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa), delusion (moha) — hence cessation of the process producing suffering.
- Classification: unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) in important traditions — outside the dependent series, not a substance with properties.
- Four consistency moves: (i) "who attains?" presupposes the disputed self; (ii) nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed; (iii) it is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series; (iv) therefore no-self removes the false claimant while momentariness explains why the chain can cease.
- Three Jewels: Buddha discovered and demonstrated · Dharma liberates · Saṅgha preserves and transmits. Origin runs Buddha → Dharma → Saṅgha; access runs Saṅgha → Dharma → Buddha.
- Refuge-taker = conventional person (prajñapti-puruṣa); no-self purifies refuge of ego-metaphysics.
- Theravāda foregrounds the liberated saint (arhat; Pali: arahant); Mahāyāna foregrounds the awakening being (bodhisattva) — dominant ideals, never a selfish/altruistic caricature.
- Nāgārjuna: saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms.
- Residual: the first-person claim "I am liberated" is a conventional index; the Advaitic unity-of-experience objection is answered by refusal.

H. The two realisms: Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika

| Issue | Vaibhāṣika | Sautrāntika |

|---|---|---|

| Access | direct realism (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda) | representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda) |

| Time | sarvam asti — dharmas of three times have some mode of existence | presentism — only present dharmas fully exist |

| Name from | the Kashmir Mahāvibhāṣā commentary | reliance on the sūtras |

| Cost | overpopulated ontology; strains momentariness | owes an account of correspondence |

- Sautrāntika argument: momentariness → cause precedes effect → object-moment has ceased → cognition bears only the form (ākāra) → external object inferred.
- Why sarvam asti is asserted: a past act must be able to bear future fruit, and a cognition must have an object; both relations need two relata.
- Both supply the "everything is real" half of the 2024 question, where real = causally efficacious, not permanent.
- ☐ Neither is a Theravāda branch; both belong to the Sarvāstivāda-related non-Mahāyāna world.

I. Yogācāra / consciousness-only (vijñānavāda)

- Thesis: representation-only (vijñaptimātra) — denial of an independently established external object.
- Three arguments, divided by function: dream (removes realism's evidence) · atom critique (removes its coherence) · time-gap (removes its explanatory role).
- Atom critique in one line: partless atoms have no sides with which to combine; atoms with parts are not ultimate.
- Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) with seeds (bīja) and latent impressions (vāsanā) explains order, memory, rebirth and shared experience. It is a conditioned transforming stream, not a self.
- Anti-solipsism line: the world is intersubjective because karmically co-conditioned, not because egos agree.
- Three natures (tri-svabhāva): imagined (parikalpita) · dependent (paratantra) · perfected (pariṇiṣpanna) — three descriptions of one flow, not three realities.
- Self-awareness (svasaṃvedana) blocks a regress of knowers and is attacked by Nyāya as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

J. Mādhyamika / emptiness (śūnyavāda)

- Six-step derivation: svabhāva = existing through itself → the self-existent does not await conditions → the conditioned awaits conditions → so nothing conditioned has svabhāva → lacking svabhāva = empty → the dependently arisen is empty.
- Four corners (catuṣkoṭi): asti · nāsti · asti ca nāsti ca · naivāsti naiva nāsti — all denied of what is taken as self-established.
- Negation type: non-implicative (prasajya-pratiśedha), not implicative (paryudāsa-pratiśedha); therefore no fifth thesis is installed.
- Defences of coherence: "no thesis of my own" (Vigrahavyāvartanī) · "my words are empty too" · the magically created figure (nirmitaka) simile.
- Two truths: conventional (saṃvṛti-satya) keeps persons, causation, moral consequence and practice; ultimate (paramārtha-satya) denies own-being. Conventional truth is not falsehood.
- Warning image: emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized. Safeguard: emptiness of emptiness.
- Positive formulation: emptiness is the condition of possibility of change, causation and liberation, not their negation.
- □ Emptiness ≠ non-existence; □ emptiness ≠ Advaita Brahman.

K. Means of valid knowledge, exclusion and the undeclared questions

- Two pramāṇas because two object-types: unique particular (svalakṣaṇa) by perception; general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa) by inference. Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and testimony are reduced, not omitted.
- Particular: momentary, causally efficient, ineffable, ultimately real. General: constructed, expressible, causally inert, conventionally real.
- Perception is non-conceptual (kalpanāpoḍha) — Dignāga — and non-erroneous (abhrānta) — Dharmakīrti; the addition excludes vivid illusions such as the double moon and the whirling-firebrand circle.
- Four types of perception: sense (indriya) · mental (mānasa) · self-awareness (svasaṃvedana) · yogic (yogi-pratyakṣa).
- Exclusion (apoha): "cow" functions as "not-non-cow" through exclusion of the other (anya-apoha); grounded in shared causal capacity. Objection from Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara: circularity and failure to explain positive determination — residual force retained.
- pramāṇa = pramāṇaphala: instrument and result are not ultimately different, because there is no enduring knower to hold the triad apart. Nyāya keeps pramāṇa · pramāṇa · prameya · pramiti distinct.
- Undeclared questions (avyākata / avyākṛta): world eternal/not eternal, finite/infinite; life-principle same as or different from body; Tathāgata after death exists / does not / both / neither.
- Two reasons for the silence: not conducive to the goal (na arthasaṃhita) — the arrow parable of the Cūḷamālukya teaching — and presuppositional defect, since all four options assume a substantial subject. Fire-going-out simile: directional predication lapses once conditions cease.
- Three readings — agnostic (weakest) · pragmatic-therapeutic · logical-semantic. Exam use: combine the last two.
- Creator-God critique: eternal unchanging creation is hard to explain; creation from desire implies lack; suffering sits uneasily with omnipotent benevolence; conditionality already explains arising. It is a refusal of explanatory surplus, and belongs in one or two lines only.

L. Objections, comparisons and answer discipline

Named objector	Objection	Buddhist reply	Residual force
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Nyāya — Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana	recognition, memory and desert require an enduring self	santāna, sādrśya, flame/river; Yogācāra adds ālaya-vijñāna and bīja	a series may not own memories unless something owns the series
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Nyāya realist	a permanent substance acts when auxiliaries are present	sahakāri-anapekṣā / krama-yaugapadya dilemma	the substance-quality model remains intuitively powerful
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Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa	self is required for duty and memory; universals for word-meaning	momentary cognitions plus exclusion explain both conventionally	positive determination remains unexplained
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Uddyotakara	exclusion is circular	exclusion grounded in causal convergence and successful activity	the circularity charge is not fully dissolved
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Śaṅkara-type Advaita	momentariness makes bondage and release unintelligible; emptiness presupposes a witness	two truths; self-revealing cognition without a self	unity of experience is the strongest surviving pressure
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| Nyāya / realist | the four-cornered denial is self-refuting or empty | scoped non-implicative negation; empty words as medicine | the Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika split shows internal unease |

| Puggalavāda foil | a person neither identical nor different is needed | continuity is conventional designation on aggregates | the pressure to preserve agency explains why the foil arose |

| Cārvāka | reject any self beyond the body | Buddhism denies the permanent self yet keeps karmic continuity | requires causal continuity not reducible to perception |

Inter-school one-liners.

- vs Jainism: both non-Vedic and non-creationist; Jainism affirms a real conscious soul (jīva) with permanence-in-substance and change-in-mode, Buddhism denies substance. □ Never say both deny the soul.
- vs Advaita: both deny naive realism about the world; Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous Brahman, Madhyamaka's is the absence of own-being. □ Never assimilate emptiness to Brahman.
- vs Cārvāka: both reject an eternal self; Cārvāka reduces to body and abolishes rebirth and moral consequence, Buddhism analyses into aggregates and preserves them without a bearer.
- vs Nyāya: enduring self-substance and real universals versus momentary particulars and exclusion; four pramāṇas versus two; instrument distinct from result versus non-different.

Graded verdict grid.

- □ Strong: the process account of suffering and release; the double middle; the causal-efficacy argument; the two truths.
- □□ Weak: ownership of memory and desert; positive determination under exclusion; the stability of "no thesis" without the negation nuance.
- □ Contested: whether svasaṃvedana proves or reifies; whether empty statements escape self-refutation; whether a series suffices for moral responsibility.

Answer architecture.

- 10 marks: define in one line → three or four crisp argument steps → one distinction → one line of significance.
- 15 marks: locate in soteriology → state doctrine precisely → argue with one example → named objection and reply → why it matters for suffering and cessation.
- 20 marks: frame through the Four Noble Truths → full doctrine with technical vocabulary → derive the linked claim → contrast two schools or answer a major objection → graded verdict from the three-column grid.

Ready verdict lines.

- 10 marks: Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process, which makes suffering removable but raises the problem of continuity without a self.
- 15 marks: dependent origination, momentariness and no-self form a coherent anti-substantialist system, though Nyāya and Vedānta press hard on memory, agency and liberation.
- 20 marks: Buddhism is strongest as a therapeutic and causal philosophy of liberation; its deepest unresolved issue is whether causal continuity and two truths can fully replace the work done by self, substance and universals in rival systems.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

This is the terminal-friendly, data-complete master flow. It is authored separately from the graphical package and is validated against the same Basic, Advanced and PYQ ledger.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/14: The therapeutic architecture and the answer-worthiness map

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 1/14: The therapeutic architecture and the answer-worthiness map

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PRINTED SYLLABUS, ITEM 14 (verbatim)

"Schools of Buddhism : Prat Ityasaṃutpada; Kṣanikavāda, Nairātmyavāda."

normalised -> praṭītyasaṃutpāda | kṣaṇikavāda | nairātmyavāda

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS (catvāri āryasatyāni) = the frame that generates everything

1 suffering (duḥkha) IS -> the diagnosis

2 suffering HAS AN ORIGIN -> needs a causal theory

3 the origin CAN BE REMOVED -> needs impermanence

4 a PATH exists -> needs a changeable person

|||

v v v

dependent momentariness no permanent self

origination (kṣaṇikavāda) (nairātmyavāda)
(pratītya-
samutpāda)
=> THE THREE PRINTED TERMS ARE THE THREE COMMITMENTS THE THERAPY REQUIRES.

THREE DISTINCT DENIALS — never merge them
unorthodox (nāstika) -> rejects VEDIC AUTHORITY (not "atheist")
non-theistic -> rejects a NECESSARY CREATOR (not materialist)
anti-substantialist -> rejects a PERMANENT SELF (not the person)

ANSWER-WORTHINESS
CORE pratītyasamutpāda · kṣaṇikavāda · nairātmyavāda · both Middle
Paths · Noble Eightfold Path · three marks · twelve links ·
five aggregates · nirvāṇa · Triratna · four schools · 14 PYQs
CORE SUPPORT pramāṇa theory · apoha · avyākṛta silence · creator-God critique
OPTIONAL ONLY Madhyamaka interpretation dispute · Yogācāra idealism debate ·
Pudgalavāda · two truths and ethics · Western comparisons

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/14: The double Middle Path

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 2/14: The double Middle Path
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MIDDLE PATH (madhyamā pratīpad; Pali: majjhimā paṭipadā) — TWO SENSES, ONE LOGIC

PRACTICAL sensual indulgence X----- MIDDLE -----X self-mortification
(kāma-sukhallikānuyoga) (attakilamathānuyoga)
|

POSITIVE CONTENT: NOBLE EIGHTFOLD PATH (āryaṣṭāṅgamārga)
wisdom (prajñā) 1 right view (samyag-dṛṣṭi)
2 right intention (samyak-saṃkalpa)
ethical discipline (śīla) 3 right speech (samyag-vāc)
4 right action (samyak-karmānta)
5 right livelihood (samyag-ājīva)
meditative discipline 6 right effort (samyag-vyāyāma)
(samādhi) 7 right mindfulness (samyak-smṛti)
8 right concentration (samyak-samādhi)
WHY REJECTED: indulgence FEEDS craving; mortification EXHAUSTS without touching it.
TEST APPLIED: causal efficacy against craving — NOT balance, NOT moderation.

DOCTRINAL eternalism X----- MIDDLE -----X annihilationism
(śāśvatavāda) (ucchedavāda)
|

POSITIVE CONTENT: CONDITIONED CONTINUITY
change without a permanent bearer;
continuity without an identical persisting thing

STRUCTURAL TEST eternalism would defeat TRUTH 3 (a permanent cause cannot be removed)
annihilationism would defeat TRUTH 4 (no continuity for discipline)
SHARED HIDDEN ASSUMPTION DENIED: "continuity requires an identical persisting thing"
OPERATIVE TARGET the path attacks IGNORANCE (by insight) and the FEELING -> CRAVING
junction (by mindfulness): feeling is unavoidable, craving is not.
TRAP X defining the Middle Path as moderation or an Aristotelian mean.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/14: Who is speaking — traditions, labels, canons, ideals

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 3/14: Who is speaking — traditions, labels, canons, ideals
=====

EARLY BUDDHISM
(earliest recoverable discourse + discipline traditions;
common core: four truths, middle path, conditionality, three marks)
|
+-----+-----+
||

NON-MAHĀYĀNA WORLD MAHĀYĀNA WORLD

THERAVĀDA one surviving school YOGĀCĀRA consciousness-only
canon: Pali Tipiṭaka MĀDHYAMIKA emptiness
Vinaya | Sutta | Abhidhamma
ideal: liberated saint (arhat; ideal: awakening being
Pali: arahant) (bodhisattva) -> complete
Buddhahood for all beings
SARVĀSTIVĀDA ORBIT
VAIBHĀṢIKA from the Kashmir *Mahāvibhāṣā*
SAUTRĀNTIKA privileges sūtra over Abhidharma
transmission: Sanskrit / Chinese / Tibetan transmission: Sanskrit + Buddhist
Hybrid Sanskrit, Chinese, Tibetan

"HĪNAYĀNA" = a MAHĀYĀNA-APPLIED, historically loaded label for disciple-vehicle traditions. NOT a self-designation. NOT a synonym for Theravāda.

CAUTIONS THAT CARRY MARKS

X "all early Buddhism survives only in Pali" -> Chinese Āgamas + Sanskrit witnesses

X "Mahāyāna = Sanskrit" -> broad orientation only

X "selfish arhat vs altruistic bodhisattva" -> Theravāda knows the bodhisattva career; Mahāyāna knows the arhat

X "the four schools are the history of Buddhism" -> it is a PHILOSOPHICAL DOXOGRAPHY

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/14: Dependent origination — formula, argument, three marks

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 4/14: Dependent origination — formula, argument, three marks

FORMULA (in substance, four clauses — quote ALL FOUR)

imasmim sati idaṃ hoti this being, that becomes

imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati from the arising of this, that arises

imasmim asati idaṃ na hoti this not being, that is not

imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati from the cessation of this, that ceases

PAIR 1 = positive conditionality PAIR 2 = negative conditionality

=> CESSATION IS BUILT INTO THE PRINCIPLE; truth 3 is an ENTAILMENT.

ARGUMENT (write in this order)

1 what is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence

2 a self-existent thing would not depend on conditions

3 all conditioned phenomena arise and cease in dependence

4 therefore they are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness

5 therefore suffering too is a process, not a fate -> it is REMOVABLE

THREE MARKS (trilakṣaṇa; Pali: tilakkhaṇa) SCOPE — examinable

impermanence (anitya; Pali: anicca) -> of conditioned formations

unsatisfactoriness (dukkha; Pali: dukkha) -> of conditioned formations

no-self (anātman; Pali: anattā) -> applied MORE WIDELY

CAUTION: early impermanence is NOT verbally identical with later momentariness.

CAUTION: nirvāṇa is classified UNCONDITIONED (asaṃskṛta) in important traditions.

PRESUPPOSITION explain through CONDITIONS, not through a static substratum

(ātman / Brahman) and not through a creator outside the chain

OBJECTION infinite regress of conditions -> nothing is ultimately explained

REPLY no unconditioned substance is needed to make conditioning

intelligible; the aim is soteriological, not genetic

2023 HINGE ignorance is CAUSALLY PRODUCTIVE: misreading process as possession

generates craving; knowledge cures because the framing did work

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 5/14: The twelve links and where the chain is cut

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1 ignorance (avidyā) -> 2 formations (saṃskāra)

3 consciousness (vijñāna) -> 4 name-and-form (nāma-rūpa)

5 six sense-bases (ṣaḍāyatana) -> 6 contact (sparśa)

7 feeling (vedanā) ===== THE CUT GOES HERE =====> 8 craving (tṛṣṇā)

9 clinging (upādāna) -> 10 becoming (bhava)

11 birth (jāti) -> 12 ageing-and-death (jarā-maraṇa)

FRAGILE PAIRS: formations BEFORE consciousness; craving BEFORE clinging BEFORE

becoming. Reversing either is an immediately visible factual error.

THREE-LIFE ARRANGEMENT (pedagogic, not exclusive)

PAST CAUSES 1-2 | already produced

PRESENT RESULTS 3-7 | already produced

PRESENT CAUSES 8-10 | OPEN -> this is why the chain is NOT fatalism

FUTURE RESULTS 11-12 | conditional on the open box

THREE LEGITIMATE READINGS

three-life pedagogic explains rebirth and karmic continuity

present-process psychological explains contact->feeling->craving HERE AND NOW

structural-soteriological diagnoses a self-sustaining pattern, not a first cause

REVERSE ORDER (pratiloma) ignorance ceases -> formations cease -> ... ->

ageing-and-death ceases

=> the third Noble Truth becomes a LOGICAL CONSEQUENCE, not a hope.

TWO CUT-POINTS ignorance -> removed by INSIGHT (wisdom training)

craving -> removed by DISCIPLINE + MINDFULNESS

VISUAL PEDAGOGY wheel of becoming (bhava-cakra) — a WHEEL because avidyā is itself conditioned, so no absolutely first cause is claimed.

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/14: Momentariness — the elimination argument

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 6/14: Momentariness — the elimination argument

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THESIS yat sat tat kṣaṇikam — whatever is real is momentary
(scholastic, in substance: sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam)
CRITERION sat = arthakriyā-samartha — the real is what CAN PRODUCE AN EFFECT
(causal efficacy, arthakriyākāritva)

SUPPOSE A PERMANENT ENTITY IS CAUSALLY EFFICIENT.

+-----+

HORN 1 — SIMULTANEITY	HORN 2 — SUCCESSION
(yaugapadya)	(krama)
produces the whole effect	produces effects at different
at once -> NOTHING LEFT for	times -> FUNCTIONS DIFFERENTLY
later production	-> HAS CHANGED

+-----+

|
| NYĀYA ESCAPE: "it acts only when auxiliaries (sahakārin) are present"
|
| CLOSED BY sahakāri-anapekṣā: either the power was ALREADY there
| (auxiliaries idle)
| or the auxiliaries SUPPLY it
| (permanent thing redundant)
|

v

PERMANENT + EFFICIENT = INCOHERENT -> yat sat tat kṣaṇikam

SECOND ARGUMENT — DESTRUCTION (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga)
perishing needs NO external destroyer; arising already contains ceasing
=> closes the realist exit of treating destruction as an extra caused event

CONTINUITY PRESERVED causal series (santāna / santati) + similarity (sādrśya)
illustrations: FLAME and STREAM
METHOD NOTE momentariness is established NEGATIVELY, by eliminating the
permanent cause — never by perceiving moments
NYĀYA RESIDUAL recognition (pratyaabhijñā): a JUDGEMENT of sameness seems to
need a subject holding both terms together
TRAP X "momentary" means "non-existent" -> reality is EVENTAL, not substantial

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 7/14: No permanent self — the exhaustive analysis

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THE PERSON, ANALYSED WITHOUT REMAINDER — five aggregates (pañca-skandha)

- 1 form / material body (rūpa)
- 2 feeling (vedanā) -> pleasant | unpleasant | neutral tone
- 3 perception / recognition (saṃjñā)
- 4 dispositions / formations (saṃskāra) <- INTENTION (cetanā) LIVES HERE
- 5 consciousness (vijñāna)

THE TEST APPLIED TO EACH THE CONCLUSION

is it permanent? NO no sixth item is found
is it independent? NO -> "self" is a DESIGNATION (prajñapti)
is it fit to be "mine, -> conventionally valid, not ultimately
I, my self"? NO self-subsistent

** THE ARGUMENT IS THE EXHAUSTIVENESS OF THE LIST **

CHARIOT ANALOGY (Milinda-pañha)
not the axle | not the wheels | not the heap | not something extra above them
=> a TERM CAN BE TRUE WITHOUT NAMING A FURTHER ENTITY
=> the chariot still carries you; the person still practises

TWO NO-SELVES — the 2021 distinction
PERSONAL (pudgala-nairātmya) denies the enduring PERSON
shared minimum across Buddhist traditions
PHENOMENON (dharma-nairātmya) denies INTRINSIC NATURE in the factors
pressed hardest by Mahāyāna / Mādhyamika
ONE-LINE CONTRAST: the first dissolves the OWNER; the second dissolves the
INVENTORY on which the owner was denied.
=> Vaibhāṣika + Sautrāntika accept the first and keep a REAL inventory.

INTERNAL FOIL — Puggalavāda (Vātsīputrīya)
a person "neither identical with nor different from" the aggregates
REJECTED by mainstream Buddhism as a relapse toward self-theory
USE: proves the ownership pressure was felt INSIDE Buddhism and refused on principle

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 8/14: Continuity — karma, memory, identity, rebirth

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MIDDLE FORMULA: na sa eva na cānyaḥ — NEITHER THE SAME NOR ANOTHER

strict identity -> eternalism returns

strict difference-> the fruit falls on a stranger

=> DENY THE DISJUNCTION, do not choose a branch

OBJECTION DEVICE HOW IT WORKS

"Who remembers?" -> santāna earlier experience

conditions later cognition

"Who recognises?" -> sādṛśya similar later phase taken

as numerically the same

"Who deserves?" -> na sa eva na cānyaḥ fruit falls on the continuous series

"What is reborn?" -> pratisandhāna one series RELINKS to

another; nothing travels

"What stores it?" -> ālaya-vijñāna + bīja conditioned transforming

(Yogācāra) stream, NOT an ātman

WHERE MORAL QUALITY LIVES: INTENTION (cetanā) — a formation among the aggregates

=> no bearer beyond the aggregates is needed to make an act good or bad

ILLUSTRATION: one lamp lights another — not the same flame, not an unrelated one

REBIRTH IS NOT TRANSMIGRATION

Jainism / Nyāya / Vedānta give rebirth a SUBJECT that travels

Buddhism gives rebirth a RELATION: one series conditions another

RESIDUAL FORCE (state it — "critically discuss" demands it)

a series explains SUCCESSION better than it explains OWNERSHIP

Buddhist rejoinder: desert, like ownership, is a CONVENTIONAL notion tracking

causal continuity; the demand for ULTIMATE desert presupposes an ultimate subject

TRAP X answering the karma objection by smuggling in a subtle self

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/14: Cessation, the Three Jewels and the consistency proof

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 9/14: Cessation, the Three Jewels and the consistency proof

NIRVĀṆA (Pali: nibbāna) = EXTINCTION OF THE THREE FIRES

attachment (rāga) | aversion (dveṣa) | delusion (moha)

=> cessation of the PROCESS that produces suffering

CLASSIFICATION: unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) in important traditions

= OUTSIDE the dependent series, NOT a substance with properties

X not another momentary event X not an eternal self attained

THE CONSISTENCY PROOF (2018 Q6b · 2025 Q8c) — four moves

1 "who attains?" ASSUMES the very self Buddhism denies

2 nirvāṇa is NOT an entity possessed by a soul

3 it IS the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series

4 => CONSONANCE: no-self removes the false claimant;

momentariness explains why the chain CAN cease

MUTUAL SUPPORT: permanent self -> liberation impossible

non-momentary events -> chain uninterruptible

unconditioned process -> cessation would not follow

THREE JEWELS (Triratna) — 2022 Q7b asks for the INTERNAL RELATION

BUDDHA discovered and demonstrated the path

DHARMA the teaching and the truth it states — THIS IS WHAT LIBERATES

SAṄGHA preserves, transmits and exemplifies it

ORIGIN ORDER : Buddha -> Dharma -> Saṅgha

ACCESS ORDER : Saṅgha -> Dharma -> Buddha

CONSISTENCY : the refuge-taker is the CONVENTIONAL PERSON (prajñapti-puruṣa);

a series capable of being conditioned by instruction is all that

refuge requires — no-self PURIFIES refuge of ego-metaphysics

TRADITION NUANCE Theravāda foregrounds the liberated saint (arhat; Pali: arahant)

Mahāyāna foregrounds the awakening being (bodhisattva)

X never the "selfish vs altruistic" caricature

NĀGĀRJUNA saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are NOT two independent realms

RESIDUAL "I am liberated" is a conventional index; the Advaitic unity-of-

experience objection is answered by REFUSAL, not by explanation

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/14: The four schools as one escalation

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 10/14: The four schools as one escalation

SHARED PREMISE: everything conditioned is momentary and dependently arisen

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STAGE 1 VAIBHĀṢIKA — direct realism (bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda)

sarvam asti: dharmas of past/present/future have SOME mode of existence

WHY: a past act must bear future fruit; a cognition must have an object
 COST: overpopulated ontology; strains momentariness
 | Sautrāntika objects
 v
 STAGE 2 SAUTRĀNTIKA — representational realism (bāhyānumeya-vāda)
 momentariness -> cause precedes effect -> object-moment HAS CEASED
 -> cognition bears only the FORM (ākāra) -> external object INFERRED
 presentism: only present dharmas fully exist
 COST: owes an account of CORRESPONDENCE
 | Yogācāra objects
 v
 STAGE 3 YOGĀCĀRA — representation-only (vijñaptimātra)
 if all that is ever given is the form, the external object DOES NO WORK
 dream argument -> removes realism's EVIDENCE
 atom critique -> removes its COHERENCE (partless atoms cannot combine;
 atoms with parts are not ultimate)
 time-gap argument -> removes its EXPLANATORY ROLE
 order restored by ālaya-vijñāna + bīja + vāsanā; shared world = shared
 karmic conditioning (NOT solipsism)
 three natures (tri-svabhāva): parikalpita (imagined) | paratantra
 (dependent) | pariniṣpanna (perfected) = THREE DESCRIPTIONS OF ONE FLOW
 svasaṃvedana blocks a regress of knowers; Nyāya attacks it
 COST: consciousness itself looks reified
 | Madhyamaka objects
 v
 STAGE 4 MĀDHYAMIKA — emptiness (śūnyavāda)
 even consciousness lacks svabhāva; all dharmas are empty
 COST: no positive ultimate; must defend non-implicative negation

2024 HINGE — "everything is real" AND "everything is void" from ONE premise
 realists: dependence proves ABSENCE OF PERMANENCE -> real = CAUSALLY EFFICACIOUS
 Mādhyamika: dependence proves ABSENCE OF INTRINSIC NATURE -> empty
 => not a contradiction; a DIFFERENT CRITERION OF THE ULTIMATELY REAL
 (causal efficacy vs independence)
 PLACEMENT X Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika are NOT Theravāda branches — Sarvāstivāda orbit

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/14: Emptiness — derivation, four corners, two truths

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 11/14: Emptiness — derivation, four corners, two truths
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 SIX-STEP DERIVATION TO EMPTINESS (2018 Q5b)
 1 svabhāva = existing through oneself, independently
 2 the self-existent does not await conditions
 3 everything conditioned awaits conditions
 4 therefore nothing conditioned has svabhāva
 5 to lack svabhāva is to be EMPTY (śūnya)
 6 therefore the DEPENDENTLY ARISEN IS THE EMPTY (Nāgārjuna's identification)

FOUR CORNERS (catuṣkoṭi) asti | nāsti | asti ca nāsti ca | naivāsti naiva nāsti
 ALL FOUR DENIED — but SCOPED: "of x taken as having svabhāva"
 NEGATION TYPE: prasajya-pratiśedha (non-implicative) NOT paryudāsa (implicative)
 => no fifth thesis is installed; the QUESTION is withdrawn
 IF the negation were IMPLICATIVE, denying all four WOULD be contradiction —
 the SCOPE plus the NEGATION TYPE is the whole reply to the irrationalism charge
 DEFENCES: "no thesis (pratijñā) of my own" (Vigrahavyāvartanī) | "my words are
 empty too" | one magically created figure (nirmīṭaka) counteracts another

TWO TRUTHS saṃvṛti-satya persons, causation, karma, compassion, practice FUNCTION
 paramārtha-satya no dharma has own-being
 conventional truth is NOT falsehood; it is where the path operates
 WARNING: emptiness wrongly grasped destroys, like a SNAKE WRONGLY SEIZED
 SAFEGUARD: EMPTINESS OF EMPTINESS — emptiness is itself dependent designation
 POSITIVE FORM: emptiness is the CONDITION OF POSSIBILITY of change and liberation
 -- if things had fixed natures, nothing could arise, alter or be freed
 TRAP X emptiness = non-existence X emptiness = Advaita Brahman
 X "Nāgārjuna rejects logic" X omitting the two truths from the answer
 [CONTESTED] whether non-implicative negation can be sustained without covertly
 functioning as a thesis — the Prāsaṅgika/Svātantrika division marks it

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/14: Knowing, meaning and the silence

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 12/14: Knowing, meaning and the silence
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 BUDDHIST MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE (Dignāga · Dharmakīrti)
 TWO OBJECTS -> TWO PRAMĀṆAS
 svalakṣaṇa (unique particular) momentary | causally efficient | ineffable |
 ultimately real -> PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa)

sāmānyalakṣaṇa (general character) constructed | expressible | causally inert | conventionally real -> INFERENCE (anumāna)
 upamāna, arthāpatti, anupalabdhi, śabda are REDUCED, not omitted
 PERCEPTION = kalpanāpoḍha (non-conceptual, Dignāga) + abhṛānta (non-erroneous, Dharmakīrti — excludes the double moon and the whirling-firebrand circle)
 FOUR TYPES: indriya | mānasa | svasaṃvedana | yogi-pratyakṣa
 APOHA: "cow" = "not-non-cow" via anya-apoha; grounded in SHARED CAUSAL CAPACITY
 OBJECTION (Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, Uddyotakara): circular + no positive determination
 pramāṇa = pramāṇaphala : instrument NOT ultimately different from result, because there is NO ENDURING KNOWER to hold the triad apart
 (Nyāya keeps pramāṇa | pramāṇa | prameya | pramiti distinct)
 WHY IT IS NOT "NYĀYA WITH FEWER PRAMĀṆAS": the count is fixed by the OBJECT-SIDE, universals are denied, and the knower is dissolved (2025 Q5b routed contrast)

UNDECLARED QUESTIONS (avyākata / avyākṛta)
 world eternal? not eternal? finite? infinite?
 jīva same as the body? different from it?
 Tathāgata after death: exists? does not? both? neither?
 TWO REASONS na arthasaṃhita (not conducive) — ARROW PARABLE, Cūḷamālukya
 PRESUPPOSITIONAL DEFECT — all four options assume a substantial subject
 FIRE SIMILE a fire gone out has not gone east/west/north/south
 THREE READINGS agnostic (weakest) | pragmatic-therapeutic | logical-semantic
 EXAM USE: COMBINE THE LAST TWO
 BRIDGE the four options ARE the four corners; the early tradition sets them aside therapeutically, Nāgārjuna shows LOGICALLY why they must be
 CREATOR-GOD CRITIQUE = REFUSAL OF EXPLANATORY SURPLUS (one or two lines only; owned by Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika and Paper II)

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 13/14: Named objections, replies, residues and comparisons

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 13/14: Named objections, replies, residues and comparisons

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FIVE OBJECTIONS, ONE COMPLAINT: BUDDHISM REMOVED THE OWNER AND KEPT THE PROPERTY
 NYĀYA (Vātsyāyana/Uddyotakara/Udayana) memory, recognition, desert need a self
 REPLY santāna + sādṛśya + flame/river (+ ālaya-vijñāna, bīja)
 RESIDUAL a series may not OWN memories unless something owns the series
 NYĀYA REALIST (2) a permanent substance acts when auxiliaries are present
 REPLY sahakāri-anapekṣā / krama-yaugapadya dilemma
 RESIDUAL the substance-quality model remains intuitively powerful
 KUMĀRILA BHATṬA self for duty and memory; real universals for word-meaning
 REPLY momentary cognitions + apoha explain both conventionally
 RESIDUAL positive determination unexplained
 ŚAṂKARA-TYPE ADVAITA liberation and unity of knower unintelligible without a witness
 REPLY two truths + self-revealing cognition without a self
 RESIDUAL unity of experience is the strongest surviving pressure
 NYĀYA / REALIST emptiness collapses into nihilism; "no thesis" is self-refuting
 REPLY scoped non-implicative negation + two truths + empty words as medicine
 RESIDUAL Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika split shows internal unease
 ALL THREE karma without a self is unjust
 REPLY neither identity nor utter difference; conventional desert
 RESIDUAL is causal continuity ENOUGH for desert, or only for explanation?

=====

COMPARISONS — one line each, and never reversed
 vs JAINISM both non-Vedic, both non-creationist; JAINISM AFFIRMS a real conscious soul (jīva), permanence-in-substance + change-in-mode.
 X NEVER "both deny the soul"
 vs ADVAITA both deny naive realism; Advaita's ultimate is POSITIVE self-luminous Brahman, Madhyamaka's is the ABSENCE of own-being.
 X NEVER "emptiness = Brahman"
 vs CĀRVĀKA both reject an eternal self; Cārvāka reduces to BODY and abolishes rebirth/karma/liberation; Buddhism analyses into AGGREGATES and keeps them without a bearer (2024 Q6a routed contrast)
 vs NYĀYA enduring self + real universals + four pramāṇas + instrument distinct from result VERSUS momentary particulars + apoha + two pramāṇas + pramāṇa = pramāṇaphala (2025 Q5b routed contrast)
 INTERNAL Vaibhāṣika direct vs Sautrāntika inferred; Yogācāra consciousness-only vs Mādhyamika emptiness of consciousness too

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 14/14: Verdict grid, answer rail and the closing line

ASCII MASTER FLOW — PANEL 14/14: Verdict grid, answer rail and the closing line

=====

GRADED VERDICT GRID (use one cell per column for a balanced conclusion)
 STRONG process account of suffering/causation/liberation | the double middle | causal-efficacy argument | two truths without abolishing practice
 WEAK ownership of memory and desert | positive determination under apoha | stability of "no thesis" without the negation nuance

CONTESTED does svasaṃvedana prove or reify? | do empty statements self-refute? |
is a causal series sufficient for MORAL responsibility?
USE 10 marks = one cell | 15 marks = one from STRONG + one from WEAK
20 marks = one from EACH column

ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

10 MARKS define in one line -> 3-4 crisp argument steps -> ONE distinction
-> one line of significance
15 MARKS locate in soteriology -> doctrine stated precisely -> argument with one
example -> NAMED objection and reply -> why it matters for cessation
20 MARKS frame through the Four Noble Truths -> full doctrine with technical
vocabulary -> DERIVE the linked claim -> contrast two schools or answer a
major objection -> graded verdict from the grid

ANSWER RAIL — follow it and the script writes itself

four truths frame -> dependent origination formula (all four clauses)
-> twelve links + the cut at feeling->craving
-> momentariness via causal efficacy + the two horns + saḥakāri-anapekṣā
-> five aggregates -> no-self -> two no-selves
-> continuity: na sa eva na cānyaḥ, santāna, cetanā, relinking
-> nirvāṇa: extinction of three fires + unconditioned + four consistency moves
-> four-school escalation -> exact contrast demanded by the question
-> named objection + reply + RESIDUAL FORCE
-> QUALIFIED VERDICT from the grid

PYQ ANCHORS 2018 Q5b/Q6b · 2019 Q5b/Q7c · 2020 Q6a/Q7b · 2021 Q5d/Q7b ·
2022 Q6a/Q7b · 2023 Q8a · 2024 Q6b · 2025 Q8c ·
2026 Q5(b) [14 primary-owned]

ROUTED 2018 Q5d and 2025 Q5b (Nyāya-owned) · 2024 Q6a (Cārvāka-owned)
CLOSE Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process: this makes suffering
removable, and leaves OWNERSHIP as its one genuinely unfinished problem.